# Theories of CONSUMPTION



JOHN STOREY

ROUTLEDGE

# THEORIES OF CONSUMPTION

*Theories of Consumption* explores the concept of consumption from the post-disciplinary perspective of cultural studies.

John Storey brings together work that up until now has been located in distinct disciplinary spaces including work on reception theory in literary studies and philosophy; work on consumer culture in sociology, anthropology and history; and work on media audiences (both ethnographic and theoretical) in media studies and sociology.

Moving beyond the usual analysis of consumer culture, Storey presents a critical assessment of a range of theoretical approaches to the study of consumption. In doing so, he provides an authoritative overview of a significant selection of research and analysis that has explored consumption as an object of study.

This book provides an ideal introduction to consumption for students of media and cultural studies and will also be useful for students within a number of other disciplines such as sociology, history, anthropology, cultural geography and both literary and visual studies.

**John Storey** is Emeritus Professor of Cultural Studies at the Centre for Research in Media and Cultural Studies, University of Sunderland, UK. He has published extensively in cultural studies, including 11 books. His work has been translated into Arabic, Chinese, Dutch, German, Indonesian, Japanese, Korean, Persian, Polish, Portuguese (Brazil and Portugal), Russian, Serbian, Slovenian, Spanish, Swedish, Turkish and Ukrainian. He is also on editorial/advisory boards in Australia, Canada, China, Germany, Lithuania, the Netherlands, Spain, the UK and the USA, and has been a Visiting Professor at the universities of Vienna, Henan and Wuhan and a Senior Fellow at the Technical University of Dresden.



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# PREFACE

There are a lot of good books about consumption (for example, Aldridge 2003, Brewer and Porter 1993, Bocock 1993, Clarke 2003, Corrigan 1997, Douglas and Isherwood 1996, Edwards 2000, Featherstone 1991, Humphrey 2010, Littler 2009, McCracken 1990, McKay 1997, Miles 1998, Miller 1987 and 1995, Mort 1996, Lewis 2013, and Sassatelli 2007), but this one is different in that rather than focus exclusively on consumerism (although it does this in Chapter 8), it ranges more broadly across the concept of consumption. Primarily, it is a book about theories of consumption. In other words, it does not confine itself to the usual analysis of consumer society but instead presents a critical assessment of a range of 'theoretical approaches' to the study of consumption. In doing this, it is hoped the book will provide a clear and wide-ranging understanding of the concept as well as a good appreciation of the theoretical possibilities available when undertaking undergraduate and postgraduate work on objects of consumption. In the 'post-disciplinary' spirit of cultural studies, the book brings together, in what is, hopefully, a fruitful relationship, work that up until now has largely remained separate, located in distinct disciplinary spaces. Each chapter considers consumption from a different theoretical perspective. Sometimes theory is explicit, while at other times it is the framing discourse of a particular methodology. But in both cases I think we can identify particular theories of consumption. For example, to conduct an ethnographic study of television viewing is to assume certain 'theoretical' things about audience activity and the source of meaning.

Consumption is often thought of in two quite separate ways: as an economic activity and as a cultural practice. If we think of consumption as a purely economic activity, it ends with the moment of purchase. But once we have bought something we do not stop consuming it. When you buy a CD you may listen to it hundreds of times; each of these times is a moment of consumption not captured by thinking of it in purely economic terms. In other words, the moment of purchase is just

the beginning of consumption. But more than this, we consume many things that we do not buy. I do this when I borrow a book from the university library. This does not involve purchase but is does involve consumption. All these moments beyond purchase are moments when consumption becomes cultural as it becomes entangled in social use and the making of meaning. As such it can be made to fulfil a wide range of social and personal purposes. What and how we consume may serve to say who we are or who we would like to be; it may be used to produce and maintain particular lifestyles; it may promise compensation in times of loss or provide a symbolic means to celebrate success and mark achievement; it can serve to meet both our needs and our desires; it can provide the material for our dreams; it can mark and maintain social difference and social distinction, and it can be the sign of our oppression and exploitation.

In *The History of Sexuality* Michel Foucault tracks the discourse of sexuality through a series of nineteenth-century discursive domains: medicine, demography, psychiatry, pedagogy, social work, criminology, government. Rather than silence on matters sexual (which is what we might have expected given the stereotype of Victorian prudery), he encounters instead 'a political, economic and technical incitement to talk about sex' (1981: 22–3). He argues that these different discourses on sexuality are not simply about sexuality, they actually *constitute* sexuality as an object of knowledge. This is not to say that sexuality did not exist as a non-discursive formation in nineteenth-century Europe, rather it is to recognize that our 'knowledge' of sexuality, and the 'power-knowledge' relations of sexuality constituted by it, are discursive (see Storey 2015). Throughout the writing of this book I have tried to remain mindful of Foucault's insight. Therefore, what counts as consumption varies from chapter to chapter, as the different theoretical approaches construct in discourse their own understanding of consumption as an object of study.

In broad terms, the book seeks to provide a critical map of consumption. To avoid the twin dangers of misunderstanding and misrepresentation, I have allowed critical sources, when and where appropriate, to speak in their own words. This has the added advantage of allowing the student of consumption a greater direct access to the material discussed. It also gives the book a certain 'dialogic', rather than 'monological', quality (Bakhtin 1984). However, the book is not intended as a substitute for reading at first hand the material discussed here. The value of the book, as I see it, is not that it provides the means to avoid further reading, rather that it presents a critical map of the discourses of consumption, and in so doing, it also argues for a particular way to read these discourses.

# ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I would like to thank Natalie Foster for inviting me to write this book.
I should also acknowledge that the book draws on material first published in *Cultural Consumption and Everyday Life* (Storey, 1999). But it is not a second edition. I have done a great deal more than simply update. Revised, rewritten, refocused and restructured, it is a very different book now. The other book appeared in a series called *Cultural Studies in Practice*, which I edited with Graeme Turner. Rewriting the book I was reminded many times that Graeme was a wonderful co-editor. Finally, I would like to thank Yen and Charlie, as always, for help and support during the writing of the book.



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# 1

# WHY WE CONSUME

The title of this chapter is slightly misleading in that the simple answer to the question is that we have no choice: humans must consume to live. However, the real question behind the title is why do humans seem to consume so much in capitalist societies. We have to disentangle these two versions of consumption if we are to answer the second question. Karl Marx distinguishes between 'production in general' and specific historical modes of production. As he explains it, production in general 'is common to all social conditions, that is without historic character, *human*' (1973: 320). But the human need to produce is always located historically in a particular mode of production: humans have always produced but how they produce is always historically situated. In other words, there is a difference between a slave mode of production and a capitalist mode of production. If we think of Marx's distinction in terms of consumption, we arrive at a similar conclusion: there is 'consumption in general' and there are specific modes of consumption. What is called consumerism (we will discuss it and consumer society in more detail in Chapter 8) is a particular historical mode of consumption unique to capitalism. In an attempt to understand this particular historical mode of consumption we will address three theoretical explanations. Each offers an influential theoretical framework to explain its relatively recent explosive growth: Karl Marx's theory of alienation, the social emulation model and Colin Campbell's theory of the Romantic ethic.

## Marx, alienation and consumption

According to Marx, alienation helps produce consumption. Alienation occurs when we are prevented from realizing our full human capacities in acts of labour. Unable to do this we turn to consumption in search of creative fulfilment. In order to fully comprehend this argument we have to understand Marx's view of human

nature. Marx distinguishes between 'human nature in general' and 'human nature as modified in each historical epoch' (1976: 759). Human nature in general consists of certain needs and capacities. These can be divided into those that are 'natural' and those that belong to our 'species being' (what marks us out as human). Our 'natural' needs and capacities we share with other animals (food, shelter, reproduction, etc.), while those of our 'species being' are unique to us as humans and are historically and socially variable in their concrete manifestation. In other words, and contrary to many conservative accounts, human nature is not fixed and unchanging; it is not something set, but always in a state of becoming. What it means to be human in the contemporary world is very different from what it was 5,000 or 10,000 years ago. It will be different again in the future. We may be a biological bundle of needs and capacities, but these needs and capacities change as we change the world around us. As Marx claims, 'all history is nothing but a continual transformation of human nature' (Marx; quoted in Ollman 1976: 79). Our humanity, like the world in which we live, is a social production.

Our species being manifests itself in two ways: subjectively in terms of our awareness of belonging to a species (we think about what it is to be human) and in objectively realized forms such as institutions and works of art. It displays itself in our consciousness of ourselves and of others acting in the world in the present, with an awareness of a past and the expectation of a future. Moreover, as humans we not only produce, we consciously consider, and reflect on, and modify how and what we produce. Humans are said to be the only animals that act in this way.

> The animal is immediately identifiable with his life-activity. It does not distinguish itself from it. It is its life-activity. Man makes his life-activity the object of his will and of his consciousness . . . Conscious life-activity directly distinguishes man from animal life-activity.
>
> (Marx 2011a: 54)

In other words, we are able to reflect on what we are doing, both at the time of doing it and later after it has been done, whereas animals, Marx believed, just do it – they produce to satisfy immediate physical needs. We are purposive in a way that animals are not.

> A spider conducts operations that resemble those of a weaver, and a bee puts to shame many an architect in the construction of her cells. But what distinguishes the worst architect from the best of bees is this, that the architect raises his structure in the imagination before he erects it in reality. At the end of every labour-process, we get a result that already existed in the imagination of the labourer at its commencement. He not only effects a change of form in the material on which he works, but he also realizes a purpose of his own that gives the law to his modus operandi, and to which he must subordinate his will.
>
> (Marx 1976: 284)

In this way, then, what makes us human and divides us from other animals is our capacity for reflective productive activity that goes well beyond our immediate needs. But it is important that we do not understand productive activity as simply labour; it is production more generally: 'active man creates the human world and, through the act of production, produces himself. He does not simply produce things, implements or goods; he also produces history and situations. He creates "human nature": nature in himself and for himself' (Lefebvre 2002: 95). As Marx explains, making very clear the absolute importance of an expanded notion of production to include consumption, 'the productive life is the life of the species' (2011a: 54). Human becoming is the gradual transformation of the natural into the human. We have biological needs and capacities but these are worked on and as they are worked on they become human and social: how we have sex and what we eat, for example, become more and more human as they become more and more historically and socially variable. Our relationship with nature (both our own and that external to us) is socially and historically mediated. We do not just satisfy our needs or exercise our capacities: we wonder about them, we reflect on what might be best or what might be possible. We write novels and poetry about our needs and capacities; we sing songs about them; we produce films and television dramas and documentaries, and paint great works of art in an attempt to explain or celebrate them. We do not just have sex to reproduce, we do it for pleasure and for love; and we laugh and cry and dream about this in ways that are unimaginable to other animals. So what begins as the satisfaction of a natural need or the exercise of a natural capacity is gradually transformed into a social activity that helps define us as human. What was once a simple act of nature becomes a social practice available to be mediated in the highest forms of human reflection. What was once a natural act becomes a social act entangled in history and politics, open to law and regulation, helping to define what it is to be human. But we never lose contact with nature. To paraphrase Lefebvre, we separate from nature without detaching ourselves from it (2002: 192).

Writing about the industrial working class in the nineteenth century, Marx points to 'the contradiction between its human nature and its condition of life, which is the outright, decisive and comprehensive negation of that nature' (quoted in McLellan 1971: 113). In human history, alienation first emerges after the break-up of what Marx calls primitive communism, with the division of labour, when some people become predominantly one thing: for example, farmers, soldiers, priests or rulers. In each instance the nature of productive activity is more and more focused and reduced. However, it is under the capitalist mode of production that this focus assumes its most intensified and destructive form.

Marx starts his analysis of alienation from the assumption that creative labour is an essential part of our species being. Through productive activity we externalize ourselves in the world. For example, as I write these words I produce myself as a writer. Without writing I cannot claim to be a writer: the words I write produce and reproduce me as a writer. According to Marx, under capitalism (he is writing about nineteenth-century capitalism and thinking particularly of the new factory system), the alienation of labour manifests itself in a number of ways. First, the

product of labour does not belong to the worker. The worker is paid to work; therefore the person or persons who pay(s) the wage own(s) what the worker produces. As a consequence, the worker encounters what he or she has produced 'as an alien object' (Marx 2011a: 53) with an existence independent of their will. That is, once his or her labour is 'congealed' (50) in the object produced, it takes on an existence outside of his or her productive activity. According to Marx, 'The alienation of the worker in his product means not only that his labor becomes an object, an external existence, but that it exists outside him, independently, as something alien to him, and that it becomes a power on its own confronting him' (51). It is as a power confronting the worker that the second aspect of alienation becomes manifest. If I were a contemporary of Marx, a worker who baked bread, my reward would be a weekly wage. Once this wage is spent, no matter how hungry I might be, the bread I had made, the object of my labour, my labour made material (i.e. 'congealed' in the object of my labour), would confront me in a shop as alien objects that have the power to satisfy my hunger, but which I cannot eat unless I have sufficient money to buy. What I have made now exists independently of my will, and I have no control over what becomes of what I have made; it is now a commodity that circulates in search of profit. To give another example, closer to home, the books I write exist in the marketplace beyond my control. If I want a new copy of one of my books I need to have sufficient money to buy one. I cannot simply go into a shop and announce the fact I am the author and take one from the shelf as my own: although I wrote these books, they now exist as alien objects that confront me as existing outside my productive activity. As Marx explains, as has been discussed already, what defines us as humans is our productive activity, therefore, if this productive activity is realized in an object existing outside our control, an alien object, we are in some way humanly diminished. 'It is the same in religion. The more man puts into God, the less he retains in himself. The worker puts his life into the object; but now his life no longer belongs to him but to the object' (ibid.). We invented God, invested him with our fears and desires, and then we let him rule over us as an alien being, independent of our will. In part, alienation happens when we take what is socially constructed or humanly made as if it were an expression of nature or divine law – the commodities the worker produces enter the marketplace as if they were objects that just existed. As Marx further explains it,

> Just as in religion the spontaneous activity of the human imagination, of the human brain and the human heart, operates independently of the individual – that is, operates on him as an alien, divine or diabolical activity – in the same way the worker's activity is not his spontaneous activity. It belongs to another, it is the loss of his self (52–3).

A third aspect of alienation concerns the relationship between the worker under the capitalist mode of production and his or her species being (as already discussed, the socially-developed needs and capacities that divide us from other animals).

> In tearing away from man the object of his production . . . estranged labor tears from him his species life, his real species objectivity, and transforms his advantage over animals into the disadvantage that his inorganic body, nature, is taken from him (55).

In other words, under capitalism the worker is alienated from his 'essential nature' (ibid.):

> the fact that labour is external to the worker, i.e., it does not belong to his essential being; that in his work, therefore, he does not affirm himself but denies himself, does not feel content but unhappy, does not develop freely his physical and mental energy but mortifies his body and ruins his mind. The worker therefore only feels himself outside his work, and in his work feels outside himself. He is at home when he is not working, and when he is working he is not at home. His labor is therefore not voluntary, but coerced; it's forced labor. It is therefore not the satisfaction of a need; it is merely a means to satisfy needs external to it. Its alien character emerges clearly in the fact that as soon as no physical or other compulsion exists, labor is shunned like the plague. (52)

If, as Marx claims, 'The object of labor is . . . the objectification of man's species life' (55), the alienation of these objects to the ownership and control of another will fundamentally diminish our species being and severely stunt the realization of our full human potential. While it has always been true that we have had to work to live, under capitalism we live to work; productive activity, the very essence of our species being, has been reduced to no other purpose than a means to stay alive. Put simply, most humans are redefined as workers; they are valued to the extent they produce and they consume. Such a redefinition is an alienation of our full human potential. Increasingly under capitalism the worker 'has no existence as a human being but only as a worker' (Marx 2011c: 60). In this way, Marx argues, the worker sells his or her 'human identity' (Marx 2011b: 16).

But because of our very nature, we continue to search for our human identity. Denied to us in production, we seek it in consumption. As Marx explained, the worker 'does not fulfil himself in his work . . . does not develop freely a physical and mental energy, but is physically exhausted and mentally debased' (1963: 177). This situation is compounded by the fact that work 'is not the satisfaction of a need, but only a *means* for satisfying other needs' (177; original emphasis). Lacking the ability to find herself in her work (i.e. express her human creativity), she is forced to seek it outside her work in consumption. 'The worker therefore feels himself at home only during his leisure, whereas at work he feels homeless' (177). In other words, in search of the human identity denied in work, the worker searches for it in patterns of consumption. As Herbert Marcuse, writing much later, put it, 'The people recognize themselves in their commodities; they find their soul in their automobile, hi-fi set, split-level home, kitchen equipment' (2002: 11).

## Social emulation

Neil McKendrick identifies the practice of social emulation as a key factor in the dramatic growth of consumption in the eighteenth century:

> In imitation of the rich the middle ranks of society spent more frenziedly than ever before, and in imitation of them the rest of society joined in as best they might – and that best was unprecedented in the importance of its impact on aggregate demand. Spurred on by social emulation and class competition, men and woman surrendered eagerly to the pursuit of novelty, the hypnotic effects of fashion, and the enticements of persuasive commercial propaganda.
>
> (1982: 11)

The practice of social emulation, he argues, was facilitated by three factors. First, the close proximity of the different social classes played a key role, in that it provided possibilities for social mobility, social competition and, of course, social emulation. The second factor was what he calls 'the compulsive power of fashion begotten by social competition' (ibid.). He argues that the size and nature of London was the third important factor. As he points out, the population of London increased from 200 000 in 1600 to 900 000 in 1800, making it the largest city in Europe. In addition to this, by 1750 11 per cent of the population of England lived in the city, making London the European city with the highest proportion of total population living in its confines. When the number of visitors to London is added to the indigenous population (he estimates that up to 16 per cent of the adult population of the late eighteenth-century England would have spent some time in London), and then one thinks of how all these people may have been 'exposed to the influence of London's shops, London's lifestyle and the prevailing London fashions, its potential for influencing consumer behaviour was enormous' (21). In this way, he contends, London 'served as a shopwindow for the whole country, the centre of forms of conspicuous consumption which would be eagerly mimicked elsewhere' (ibid.). The poet Robert Southey, writing in 1807, had no doubts about the commercial appeal of the capital:

> If I were to pass the remainder of my life in London I think the shops would always continue to amuse me. Something extraordinary or beautiful is for ever to be seen in them . . . There is a perpetual exhibition of whatever is curious in nature or art, exquisite in workmanship, or singular in costume; and the display is perpetually varying as the ingenuity of trade and the absurdity of fashion are ever producing something new.
>
> (quoted in McKendrick 1982: 78)

McKendrick argues that social emulation and 'the manipulation of social emulation [through advertising and sales campaigns] made men [and women] pursue

"luxuries" where they had previously bought "decencies", and "decencies" where they had previously bought only "necessities"' (98). Social emulation and the manipulation of social emulation were driven by the emergence in the eighteenth century of what he calls the 'Western European fashion pattern' (41), characterized by the rapid speed of change. He points to the key role played by manipulation:

> potent as the force of fashion was, it needed to be released and mobilized and exploited before it could significantly add to aggregate demand. The conditions making this possible grew steadily more favourable . . . But it still required active and aggressive selling to reach that market and exploit its full potential (63).[1]

Ann Bermingham is critical of the use of social emulation as a model for understanding the growth of consumption. She thinks it an inadequate approach to the processes and patterns of consumption in that it always assumes a top-down flow of cultural influence. As a model of explanation, she claims, it always 'reinforces the political view that culture is the province of the elite' (1995: 12). Moreover, such arguments, she observes, always draw their evidence from the self-understanding and self-presentation of dominant voices in past periods in history. Such unproblematic use of the views expressed by dominant voices may lead to a failure by historians to penetrate the surface discourse to reveal what might be the ideological stake that these voices have in specific arguments about social emulation. For example, as Bermingham makes clear, expressions of distaste at people supposedly consuming above their station might be driven by a fear that such an activity might lead to other, more socially threatening, ideas and practices (12). In other words, the reality might be that the dominant voices are really articulating their fear of where social emulation might lead, rather than identifying actual instances of it in practice. In addition to this, Bermingham further observes that '[t]he top-down model of emulation is also flawed in that it cannot accommodate situations where cultural forms seem to flow in the reverse direction' (ibid.). Ben Fine and Ellen Leopold, for instance, cite the eighteenth-century example of social emulation upwards: the frock-coat's movement from being the work wear of agricultural labourers to becoming the fashion wear of members of the royal family (1990: 172).

Fine and Leopold offer another type of objection to the social-emulation model as presented by McKendrick. They point out 'that the effect of directing attention to consumption through the market is to rewrite history favourably in terms of the rich and powerful, who act as the leading edge of change and as subjects to be emulated' (1990: 152). Further to this, they accuse him of wishing 'to revive the idea of the making of history by the wealthy as the leading and progressive edge' (155); he is accused of advocating a version of history in which 'economic progress is associated with the history of the rich or nouveau riche' (157).[2] Rejecting the view that social emulation is always a linear flow from top to bottom

> deprives luxury spending of its progressive attributes. The lower orders are no longer simply passive beneficiaries and transforming multipliers of consuming habits imposed from above, and spending by the upper classes is no longer required to serve as a catalyst in the transformation of goods from luxuries into basic necessities (172–3).

But more than this,

> The concept of emulation (source of the trickle-down effect) . . . establishes a progressive role for the upper classes in the creation of consumer society. They are seen as the ultimate source of demand, introducing ideas for consumption goods which are passed down through all other strata in society, transformed as they go from luxuries to decencies to basic necessities. There is an implication that the state of idleness made possible by unearned incomes may be warranted by the inventiveness of those so under-occupied in dreaming up demands for new luxury goods . . . The belief that wealth produces 'breeding', which is itself the source of taste and refinement, is therefore used to justify the existence of the social pyramid. But the inequalities of that pyramid are entirely glossed over (176).

However, although a 'bottom-up' model may correct the elitism of the 'top-down' model, it too would remain locked in a very limited notion of the meaning and social significance of consumption. Therefore, although it is certainly true that specific practices of consumption may result from a desire to emulate other social classes, people can be observed to engage in consumption for many other reasons. We should, as Bermingham suggests, move beyond social-emulation models and open up our critical gaze to see consumption in terms of 'structures of appropriation, circulation, and bricolage, and the complex workings of aesthetics, fantasy, discipline, and sexuality' (1995: 13).

The feminist historian Amanda Vickery is also of the view that social emulation offers an inadequate explanation for the growth in consumption in the late eighteenth century. She argues that as a model of explanation it presents an 'unimaginative interpretation of human motivation' in its assumption that 'envy and wishful thinking are the norm' (1993: 275). Furthermore, she contends that it is a model, especially as used by McKendrick, that often operates with a very particular view of women, as on the one hand driven by a 'pathological desire to consume', and on the other 'simply innately covetous and congenitally wistful about the prospect of upward mobility' (277). For example, whereas Harold Perkin makes a general claim about the causes of the consumer revolution – 'the key to that demand was social emulation, keeping up with the Joneses, the compulsive urge for imitating the spending habits of one's betters' (1968: 110) – McKendrick is quite explicit about the gender of those doing the consuming:

> Her increased earning released her desire to compete with social superiors, a desire pent up for centuries or at least restricted to very occasional excess

> . . . It was this new consumer demand, the mill girl who wanted to dress like a duchess . . . which helped to create the industrial revolution (1974: 200, 209).

Vickery argues, in a view that supports Bermingham's point discussed earlier, that much of this way of situating women in the practices of consumption derives from an uncritical reading of historical sources. As she explains, 'Generalizations about this homogeneously feminine consumer motivation are illustrated by uncritical quotation from eighteenth-century travellers' reports, satirical social commentary and moralists' diatribes . . . Ancient prejudices have thus been passed off as actual behaviour' (277).[3] Mica Nava makes a similar point in a critical review of Janet Wolff's (1985, 1990) discussion of women's cultural experience in the nineteenth-century city. Nava seeks to draw attention to the potential difference between women's actual lived experience and the depiction of this in intellectual presentations of modernity. Much of Wolff's argument, according to Nava, is heavily reliant on 'the invisibility of women in the literature of modernity' (Nava 1997: 59). The problem identified by Nava is the way in which this invisibility is allowed to play a crucial but misleading role in explaining women's cultural experience of nineteenth-century urban life. As she explains,

> The absence from the literature is read as evidence of a 'real' absence rather than evidence of itself. A different reading of women's participation in modernity would have emphasized the constructedness of this literature. It would have highlighted the intellectual exclusion of women and the ambivalence of the authors about cultural change – the androcentrism of most of the texts about modernity (59).

Vickery also points out how the social-emulation model has a tendency to foreshorten and impoverish analysis of consumption by 'assuming that beyond their material function goods only convey information about competitive status and sexuality and that consumables once possessed carry the same social and personal meanings for all consumers' (1993: 277). Against such a position she argues for a view of consumption 'as a positive contribution to the creation of culture and meaning' (278). In her own research she seeks to 'move beyond the moment of purchase', to the way goods are 'used and the multitude of meanings invested in possessions over time' as they are placed in new contexts and in new relationships with other goods (281, 282). It is important, she maintains, if we are to fully understand consumption, that we try to track items as they enter the personal economy of the consumer, where they may be given new meanings as they are placed in shifting contexts and changing relationships, and they become part of the processes she calls 'inconspicuous consumption' (284). As an example of these processes she cites research she carried out on Ellen Weeton Stock, a woman who worked as a governess in early nineteenth-century Lancashire. In a letter to her daughter Mary, written to accompany a number of family heirlooms, Stock wrote:

> The green ribbon is part of a boxful my mother once had; they were taken in a prize which my father captured during the American war. . . The piece of patchwork is an old quilt, I made it about 20 years ago; the hexagon in the middle was of our best bed hangings . . . they were chintzes my father brought home with him from one of his voyages. . . I am thus minded, my Mary, that you might know something of the history of your mother's family (quoted in Vickery 1993: 293–4).

Each item is valued for its meaning rather than its material substance.

Although Colin Campbell (1983) accepts McKendrick's argument about the birth of a consumer society in the late eighteenth century, and the central role played by women consumers, he is dismissive of the idea that the social-emulation model can adequately explain this. As he contends, 'the fact that modern societies are characterized by multiple and diverse elite groups presents a problem concerning who exactly one is to emulate' (284). Furthermore, 'for those at the pinnacle, emulation is hardly an available motive and yet their pattern of consumption seems to lack none of the dynamic apparent among their emulators' (ibid.). Moreover, as Campbell also observes, 'behaviour which is imitative is not necessarily also emulative' (1993: 40). That is to say, a domestic servant may wear a dress similar to one worn by her aristocratic employer without this necessarily implying that she is seeking to be like her mistress. Although it is the case that domestic servants accepted new and second-hand clothes from their employers, the significance and meaning of such acceptance may not be entirely self-evident. As Vickery suggests,

> it is not clear that wearing a Lady's dress made a parlour maid look, feel or get treated like a lady. To presume she wished she was a lady might seem legitimate, but certainly does not follow from evidence that she accepted a second-hand dress. After all, second-hand dresses could be attractive simply because they had a high resale value. Besides, the strenuous efforts ex-servants made to retrieve their wages and wardrobe, including the threat of legal action, suggest that clothing was seen as an important part of their earnings, rather than merely the coveted equipment of social emulation (1993: 284).

If social emulation is to have an impact on production it requires to be matched by emulative spending. McKendrick argues that domestic servants played a crucial role in the transmission of consumer taste and behaviour from the dominant classes in the metropolis to other classes in the provinces. In this way, he maintains, social emulation flowed downward from the rich to their domestic servants, then to industrial workers and finally to agricultural workers. Working in this way, he argues, social emulation 'became an engine for growth, a motive power for mass production' (1982: 66). But as Fine and Leopold point out, 'Emulative spending developing from below stairs appears highly improbable' (1990: 169). They cite the example of Barbara Johnson, who in the 1760s paid £7 15s 9d for material to make a day dress, at a time when her housemaid's basic annual salary would have

been about £7 7s. It therefore seems highly unlikely that domestic servants engaged in emulative spending. The clothes they wore that echoed their employers' tastes were handed down from mistress to maid. Fine and Leopold offer two reasons for this. The first is the increasing pace of fashion among the dominant classes in late eighteenth-century England. The other reason presents a direct challenge to the very idea of social emulation: 'Employers often selected and purchased clothes for their servants to wear . . . [because servants'] clothes were a highly visible sign of their employers' wealth and status . . . [they] reflected his or her taste, not that of the servant' (170).

## The Romantic ethic

Colin Campbell (1983, 1987, 1993, 1995) argues that in order to fully understand the development of modern forms of consumption we need to take into account what he calls the Romantic ethic. In what he describes as 'a very ambitious argument' (1987: 2), he maintains that Romanticism, the intellectual and artistic movement which developed alongside industrialization, played a crucial role in the development and rapid growth of consumer society in the late eighteenth century.

Campbell begins his argument with a process the German sociologist Max Weber (1965) referred to as 'disenchantment'. Weber used the term to describe a historical process in which emotions are gradually removed from the natural world ('the night was frightening') to be relocated in the inner-world of the individual ('she experienced the night as frightening'). This is an important part of the historical development of a growing separation of the subjective inner-world of the self and the objective outer-world of nature. It gradually produces a way of being in the world in which there is the objective world outside the self and the subjective response to it. As Campbell comments,

> Objective reality and subjective response were now mediated through consciousness in such a way that the individual had a wide degree of choice concerning exactly how to connect them. Beliefs, actions, aesthetic preferences and emotional responses were no longer automatically dictated by circumstances but 'willed' by individuals (1987: 73–4).

According to Campbell, this process reached a crucial stage with the development of Romanticism and what the Romantic poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge called for the first time 'self-consciousness' (73).

The importance of Romanticism for Campbell is that it was the first cultural movement committed to 'a radically different doctrine of the person' (1983: 286).

> Romanticism . . . led to the creation of a distinctive ideal of character, one which, although most obviously applied to the artist, was also meant to serve for the consumer or 're-creator' of his [or her] products. Since the key

> characteristic of the divine was taken to be creativity, both in the sense of productivity and of originality, imagination became the most significant and prized of personal qualities, with the capacity to manifest this both in works of art and through an ability to enter fully into those created by others acting as unambiguous signs of its presence (52).

The Romantic concept of the self involved the view that one should trust one's feelings; that one should seek within for guidance. This led to what we might call a commitment to experience; that is, a doctrine which maintains that one should seek out experiences and then learn from these experiences; and if one is an artist, one should express one's experiences so that others may in turn learn from the expression of experience. The Romantics believed firmly in the view 'that happiness comes from "self-expression" ' (285). Campbell argues that 'the romantic doctrine of learning through experiencing tended to emphasise the value not just of all feelings (whether positive or negative) but especially that of pleasure . . . [what William Wordsworth called] "the grand elementary principle of pleasure" ' (286). This commitment to experiencing pleasure, Campbell argues, 'is a doctrine which provides an intellectual justification to the consumptive mode as via powerful experience we can come to know the world and ourselves' (287). It is this new way of thinking and being in the world, the Romantic self, with its redefinition of the individual and how to improve the individual through exposure to many new and different experiences, that Campbell sees as crucial to the development of a consumption ethic.

To establish an informing connection between Romanticism and this new consumption ethic, Campbell argues that the best place to look is in its 'development of new doctrines of art and the artist, doctrines which of necessity also applied to the consumer of these products' (288). Romanticism advocated an expressive theory of art; the work of art was seen as an expression of the artist's 'genius'; it is an embodiment of his or her experience, imagination and feeling (see Abrams 1953). But crucially for the development of a consumption ethic, Romanticism did not just advocate a new view of the production of art, it also insisted that consumption of art should be understood differently. The value of consuming Romantic art was that it gave the consumer access to the artist's genius. Consuming Romantic art, in other words, involved the re-creation of the artist's experience, imagination and feeling. As Percy Bysshe Shelley argued in *A Defence of Poetry* (first published in 1821),

> A man [or woman], to be greatly good, must imagine intensely and comprehensively; he must put himself in the place of another and of many others; the pains and pleasures of his species must become his own. The great instrument of moral good is the imagination; and poetry administers to the effect by acting upon the cause. Poetry enlarges the circumference of the imagination by replenishing it with thoughts of ever new delight . . . Poetry strengthens that faculty which is the organ of the moral nature of man, in the same manner as exercise strengthens a limb (2009: 682).

The Romantic theory of poetry demands of readers an active and imaginative engagement with poetry, one, that is, which is capable of re-creating (in the act of reading) the written manifestation of the experience, the feelings and the imagination of the poet. As Campbell explains,

> It is noticeable how such a theory [the Romantic theory of poetry] places almost as much emphasis upon the 're-creative' abilities of the reader as upon the original creative faculties of the poet, for whilst the latter must be moved by what he sees, and also capable of translating this experience into an affective, and hence effective, work of art, the former must possess sufficient imaginative skill to be able to use the words on the page to produce a convincing illusion. The reader is also, in that sense, assumed to be a creative artist, capable of conjuring up images which have the power to 'move' him [or her] (1987: 189).

Campbell argues that the Romantic theory of poetry, with its belief in moral renewal through pleasure, 'led to the creation of a distinctive ideal of character, one which, although most obviously applied to the artist, was also meant to serve for the consumer or "re-creator" of his [or her] products' (193).

> Romanticism provided that philosophy of 'recreation' necessary for a dynamic consumerism: a philosophy which legitimates the search for pleasure as a good in itself . . . [In this way it] served to provide ethical support for that restless and continuous pattern of consumption which so distinguishes the behaviour of modern man [sic] (201).

In this way, Campbell argues, 'romantic doctrines provided a new set of motivations and justifications for consuming cultural products, ones which emphasized the value of the subjectively-apprehended experience of consumption itself' (1983: 289).[4]

Having established the origins of the dominant mode of modern consumption in both the theoretical concerns and practical consequences of Romanticism, Campbell then elaborates a more detailed theory of contemporary consumption. He begins by distinguishing between two forms of hedonism, traditional and modern. What marks the difference between these two modes is an expansion of the field of pleasure from a location in quite specific experiences to a belief that it can be located in all experiences. The movement from one to the other is the result of a shift from seeking pleasure in 'sensations' to seeking pleasure in 'emotions'. As he explains,

> The key to the development of modern hedonism lies in the shift of primary concern from sensations to emotions, for it is only through the medium of the latter that powerful and prolonged stimulation can be combined with any significant degree of autonomous control, something which arises

> directly from the fact that an emotion links mental images with physical stimuli (1987: 69).

In other words, traditional hedonism sought pleasure in particular objects and practices, modern hedonism seeks pleasure in the meaning of objects and practices (76). Figure 1.1 presents Peter Corrigan's useful diagrammatic summary of Campbell's argument.

According to Campbell, the shift from seeking pleasure in what is known to provide pleasure to seeking it in what has yet to be experienced as pleasurable had a dramatic effect on consumption. As he explains,

> The capacity to gain pleasure from self-constructed, imaginative experience crucially alters the essential nature of all hedonistic activity . . . In the . . . traditional pattern of hedonistic conduct imagination does not have a significant role to play because the nature of anticipated pleasure is known from past experience. The expectation of pleasure triggers desire but what one 'expects' to enjoy is mainly what one 'remembers' enjoying. Novel objects or activities thus tend to be regarded with suspicion as their potential for pleasure is as yet unknown. In modern hedonism, on the other hand, if a product is capable of being represented as possessing unknown characteristics then it is open to the pleasure-seeker to imagine the nature of its gratifications and it thus becomes an occasion for day-dreaming. Although employing material from memory, the hedonist can now imaginatively speculate upon what gratifications and enjoyments are in store, and thus attach his [or her] favoured day-dream to this real object of desire. In this way, imagined pleasures are added to those already encountered and greater desire is experienced for the unknown than the known (85–6).

Campbell sees this as the key to modern patterns of consumption:

| **Traditional hedonism** | **Modern hedonism** |
|---|---|
| Search for pleasure tied to specific practices | Search for pleasure in any or all experiences |
| Pleasure tied to sensations | Pleasure tied to emotions |
| Emotions not under control of subject | Emotions controlled by subject |
| Pleasure derived from control of objects and events | Pleasure derived from control of the meanings of objects and events |

**FIGURE 1.1** Traditional versus modern hedonism.

Source: Corrigan (1997: 16).

> The introduction of daydreaming into hedonism thus not only strengthens desire, but helps to make desiring itself a pleasurable activity. While for traditional man [sic] deferred gratification had simply meant the experience of frustration, for modern man it becomes a happy hiatus between desire and consummation that can be filled with the joys of day-dreaming. This reveals a unique feature of modern self-illusory hedonism – the fact that the desiring mode constitutes a state of enjoyable discomfort, and that wanting rather than having is the main focus of seeking pleasure (86).

For Campbell, the process is driven forward by the inevitable gap which always opens up between the attainment of an object of desire in actuality and the anticipation of its attainment in imagination. It is generally the case that the actual experience of consumption will fail to match the experience imagined in anticipation. In this way, 'The consummation of desire is thus a necessarily disillusioning experience', in that the gap between anticipation and reality will always produce, regardless of the pleasures actual experience of consumption may bring, a 'resultant recognition that something is missing' (ibid.). Although Campbell's argument is that consumers are driven from object to object, from anticipatory daydreaming to disillusioning reality, longing for an object of desire which can be experienced in actuality as it is experienced in imaginative anticipation, his 'central insight [however] . . . is the realization that individuals do not so much seek satisfaction from products, as pleasures from self-illusory experiences which they construct from their associated meanings' (89). In this way, he argues,

> The essential activity of consumption is thus not the actual selection, purchase or use of products, but the imaginative pleasure-seeking to which the product image lends itself, 'real' consumption being largely a resultant of this 'mentalistic' hedonism. Viewed in this way, the emphasis upon novelty as well as that upon insatiability both become comprehensible (ibid.).

In this way, it is the cycle of anticipation and disillusionment which drives the desire to consume. All that is required to keep the process moving is the appearance of new commodities for consumption. Campbell's argument is a refutation of claims that modern consumerism is evidence of materialistic desire to consume more and more objects.

The idea that contemporary consumers have an insatiable desire to acquire objects represents a serious misunderstanding of the mechanism which impels people to want goods. Their basic motivation is the desire to experience in reality the pleasurable dramas which they have already enjoyed in imagination, and each 'new' product is seen as offering a possibility of realizing this ambition. However, since reality can never provide the perfected pleasures encountered in day-dreams (or, if at all, only in part, and very occasionally), each purchase leads to literal disillusionment, something which explains how wanting is extinguished so quickly, and why people disacquire goods as rapidly as they acquire them. What is not extinguished,

however, is the fundamental longing which daydreaming itself generates, and hence there is as much determination as ever to find new products to serve as replacement objects of desire (89–90).

It is the continual dynamic interaction between anticipated experience and actual experience, and the profound longing to close the gap between the two, which is the key to understanding the limitless nature of modern consumption (see Figure 1.2).

Although Campbell acknowledges the ways in which advertisers may attempt to fuel this process, he rejects the view that they can in any way control the cycle of production and reproduction of longing. He recognizes that 'advertisers [may] make use of the fact that people day-dream, and indeed feed those dreams' (91). But, as he insists, because 'the practice of day-dreaming is itself endemic to modern societies [it] does not require the commercial institution of advertising to ensure its continued existence' (ibid.).

To work as material for day-dreams, commodities must be actively consumed. Moreover, in an important distinction, running counter to much 'common sense' about consumption, Campbell is insistent that it is important 'to conceive of these . . . products as providing the material for day-dreams rather than as being day-dreams' (93). The activity of the consumer is crucial.

> [It] is important not only because the individual has to actively use the words, pictures, and sounds to construct an 'as-if' world for himself [sic] to inhabit, but also because the process of day-dreaming (which has in any case preceded contact with the . . . item in question) may well continue long after direct contact has ceased; images relating to a particular film or novel being brought to mind subsequently and embroidered in pleasurable fashion (ibid.).

However, although consumption is an active process, the essential activity of the consumer is in the imaginative process of seeking pleasure. This leads to a concern 'with the "meaningfulness" of products', rather than 'a concern with the meaning of a product' (1995: 120).

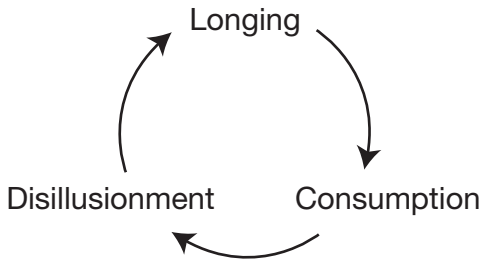



**FIGURE 1.2** Cycle of consumption.
Source: Campbell (1987).

## Notes

1 Colin Campbell (1987: 21–4) suggests that McKendrick has certain 'unresolved problems' in his account in that he wants to insist on the primary role played by the new fashion pattern in generating the consumer society of the eighteenth century while at the same time claiming that the fashion pattern itself was produced by market manipulation. This appears to be an argument in which cause produces effect and effect produces cause.

2 They also claim that 'The result is to construct a rationale in favour of contemporary consumerist society, however understood, and the role of those privileged within it' (152). Paul Glennie identifies another problem perhaps symptomatic of much historical work on consumption, 'McKendrick's account was largely researched from sources relating to producers and traders, from which it is difficult to identify the new consumers, and how and why their demand changed' (1995: 167).

3 Colin Campbell makes an interesting point about the nature of some of these sources:

> most of these observers of the social scene were themselves either members or representatives of the superior classes, their jealous regard for their own privileges, combined with an intense anxiety about the stability of the social order (especially after 1789), meant that they were prone to see imitative consumption as inherently threatening. In other words their strident condemnation stemmed less from any knowledge that such conduct arose out of emulative desires than fear that it might, with the consequence that they condemned imitation for what it could represent rather than what it was known to be (1993: 41).

4 Campbell is aware that Romanticism's influence on the development of consumer society is to say the least ironic; especially so, given that its proponents' own perception of what they were doing involved a sense of being in conflict with the emerging industrial society in which they lived (see Campbell 1983: 293, and Campbell 1987: 209).



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# 2

# CONSUMPTION AS MANIPULATION

The focus of this chapter is on three approaches to consumption which in different ways, both positive and negative, have had an enormous influence – and quite rightly so – on the development of cultural studies, especially in the UK. The first is the work of a group of German intellectuals (especially Theodor Adorno, Max Horkheimer, Leo Lowenthal and Herbert Marcuse) collectively known as the Frankfurt School. This section will also include a critical assessment of the political-economy-of-culture approach as a way of demonstrating the continuing influence of the Frankfurt School's work on contemporary cultural analysis. This is followed, in the second section, by a discussion of Leavisism (the work of F. R. Leavis, Q. D. Leavis and, Denys Thompson). The third section contains a discussion of the early work of the French cultural theorist Roland Barthes. Although these three bodies of work represent quite different traditions and different approaches to consumption, what connects them, as I have already said, is their influence on cultural studies, and what makes them of significance for the particular concerns of this book is the fact that, despite their many differences, all three operate with a model of consumption as manipulation. The chapter concludes with a brief discussion of some of the problems with critical approaches that begin with the assumption that consumption is best understood as a form of manipulation.

## The Frankfurt School

The Frankfurt School is the name given to a group of German intellectuals associated with the Institute for Social Research at the University of Frankfurt. The Institute was established in 1923. Following the coming to power of Nazism in Germany in 1933, the Institute moved to New York, becoming a temporary part of the University of Columbia (until 1949). The experience of life in the United States had a profound impact on the School's thinking on consumption.

In 1947 Theodor Adorno and Max Horkheimer coined the term 'culture industry' to designate the products and processes of mass culture. The products of the culture industry, they claim, are marked by two features: cultural homogeneity, 'film, radio and magazines make up a system which is uniform as a whole and in every part . . . all mass culture is identical' (1979: 120–21); and predictability:

> As soon as the film begins, it is quite clear how it will end, and who will be rewarded, punished, or forgotten. In light music [popular music], once the trained ear has heard the first notes of the hit song, it can guess what is coming and feel flattered when it does come (125).

Furthermore, 'Under the regime of the culture industry . . . the film leaves no room for imagination or reflection on the part of its audience . . . the film forces its *victims* to equate it directly with reality' (1977: 353–4; my italics). In a later essay, Adorno elaborates the same theme that the outcomes of consumption are determined by production:

> In all its branches, products which are tailored for consumption by the masses, and which to a great extent determine the nature of that consumption, are manufactured according to plan . . . The culture industry intentionally integrates its consumers from above (1991: 85).

Whereas in the perspective developed by the Frankfurt School's contemporaries in England, the Leavisites (discussed in the next section), the concern is that mass culture will lead to 'anarchy' (Matthew Arnold 2013; see Storey 2010), thus bringing an end to cultural and social authority, the Frankfurt School can see only the development of a depoliticized ideological conformity and the iron grip of social authority. The Frankfurt School maintains that the culture industry, by producing a culture marked by 'standardisation, stereotype, conservatism, mendacity, manipulated consumer goods' (Lowenthal 1961:11), had worked to depoliticize the working class; that is, it had limited its horizon to political and economic goals that could be realized within the oppressive and exploitative framework of capitalist society. Leo Lowenthal contends that, 'Whenever revolutionary tendencies show a timid head, they are mitigated and cut short by a false fulfilment of wish-dreams, like wealth, adventure, passionate love, power and sensationalism in general' (ibid.). In short, the culture industry discouraged the 'masses' from thinking beyond the confines of the present. Herbert Marcuse develops this line of argument to suggest that capitalism, working through the culture industry, promotes an 'ideology of consumerism', which generates false needs,[1] and that these needs work as a mechanism of social control:

> the irresistible output of the entertainment and information industry carry with them prescribed attitudes and habits, certain intellectual and emotional

> reactions which bind the consumers more or less pleasantly to the producers and, through the latter to the whole. The products indoctrinate and manipulate; they promote a false consciousness which is immune against its falsehood . . . it becomes a way of life. It is a good way of life – much better than before – and as a good way of life, it militates against qualitative change. Thus emerges a pattern of one-dimensional thought and behaviour in which ideas, aspirations, and objectives that, by their content, transcend the established universe of discourse and action are either repelled or reduced to the terms of this universe (2002: 14).

In other words, by supplying the means to certain needs, capitalism, working through the productions of the culture industry, is able to prevent the formation of more fundamental desires. The inevitable result, or so it is claimed, is that the political imagination of working people is stunted. In this way, the Frankfurt School argue, work and leisure under capitalism form a compelling relationship: the effects of the culture industry are guaranteed by the nature of work; the work process secures the effects of the culture industry. The function of the culture industry is therefore, ultimately, to organize leisure time in the same way as capitalist industrialization has organized work time. Work under capitalism stunts the senses; the function of the culture industry is to continue the process:

> the escape from everyday drudgery which the whole culture industry promises . . . [is a] paradise . . . [of] the same old drudgery . . . escape . . . [is] predesigned to lead back to the starting point. Pleasure promotes the resignation which it ought to help to forget (Adorno and Horkheimer 1979: 142).

In short, work leads to mass culture; the consumption of mass culture leads back to work.

In 'On Popular Music' (first published in 1941), Adorno makes three specific claims about the music the culture industry produces. First, he claims that it is 'standardised'. Once a musical and/or lyrical pattern has proved successful it is exploited to commercial exhaustion. Moreover, details from one popular song can be interchanged with details from another. Unlike the organic structure of 'serious music' (Adorno's usual example is the music of Beethoven), where each detail expresses the whole, popular music is mechanical in the sense that a given detail can be shifted from one song to another without any real effect on the structure as a whole. In order to conceal standardization, the music industry engages in what Adorno calls 'pseudo-individualization':

> Standardisation of song hits keeps the customers in line by doing their listening for them, as it were. Pseudo-individualization, for its part, keeps them in line by making them forget that what they listen to is already listened to for them, or 'pre-digested' (2013: 69).

It is Adorno's second claim – that popular music promotes passive listening – which brings us back to the question of consumption. The Frankfurt School maintain, as we noted earlier, that work under capitalism is dull and therefore promotes the search for escape, but, because it is also dulling, it leaves little energy for real escape – the demands, say, of 'serious music'. Instead refuge is sought in forms such as popular music – the consumption of which is always passive, and endlessly repetitive, confirming the world as it is, rather than as it might be. Adorno sees popular music as the 'non-productive correlate' to life in the office or on the factory floor. The 'strain and boredom' of work leads men and women to the 'avoidance of effort' in their leisure time. Denied 'novelty' in their work time, and too exhausted for it in their leisure time, 'they crave a stimulant' – popular music satisfies the craving.

> Its [popular music's] stimulations are met with the inability to vest effort in the ever identical. This means boredom again. It is a circle which makes escape impossible. The impossibility of escape causes the widespread attitude of inattention toward popular music. The moment of recognition is that of effortless sensation. The sudden attention attached to this moment burns itself out instanter and relegates the listener to a realm of inattention and distraction (71).

Popular music generates a kind of blurred dialectic: a mutually reinforcing relationship in which to consume it demands inattention and distraction, while in return, its consumption produces in the consumer inattention and distraction.

Adorno's final point is the claim that popular music operates as 'social cement' (ibid.). Its 'socio-psychological function' is to achieve in the consumers of popular music 'psychical adjustment' (ibid.) to the needs of the prevailing structures of power. This 'adjustment' manifests itself in 'two major socio-psychological types of mass behaviour . . . the "rhythmically" obedient type and the "emotional" type' (72). The first type dances in distraction to the rhythm of his or her own exploitation and oppression. The second type wallows in sentimental misery oblivious to the real conditions of existence.

In spite of its Marxist sophistication, the approach of the Frankfurt School to the consumption of popular culture is, ultimately, a conservative discourse from above (a discourse of 'us' and 'them') on the culture of other people. Moreover, it is a form of analysis that leaves very little room for a critical engagement with consumption, other than one, that is, in which we know all the answers before we ask the questions.

A perspective that has unproblematically inherited many of the limiting assumptions of the Frankfurt School is the political economy approach to culture. Peter Golding and Graham Murdock offer this outline of its procedures and protocols:

> What distinguishes the critical political economy perspective . . . is precisely its focus on the interplay between the symbolic and economic dimensions

> of public communications. It sets out to show how different ways of financing and organising cultural production have traceable consequences for the range of discourses and representations in the public domain and for audiences' *access* to them (1991: 15; my italics).

The significant word here is 'access' – privileged over 'use' and 'meaning'. This reveals the limitations of the approach: good on the economic dimensions but weak on the symbolic. Golding and Murdock suggest that the growing tendency in cultural studies to engage in a 'romantic celebration of subversive consumption is clearly at odds with cultural studies' long standing concern with the way the mass media operate ideologically, to sustain and support prevailing relations of domination' (17). What I find particularly revealing about this claim is not the critique of studies of consumption in cultural studies, but the claim about the assumed proper purposes of cultural studies. They seem to be suggesting, that is, that unless the focus is firmly and exclusively on domination and manipulation, cultural studies is failing in its stated task. Moreover, what is also quite explicit is the claim that there are only two positions of cultural analysis: either, on the one hand, romantic celebration, or on the other, a full recognition of, and total focus on the ideological power of the culture industries – and only the second position amounts to a serious scholarly engagement. The logical conclusion to be drawn is twofold: first, all attempts to show people resisting ideological manipulation are forms of romantic celebration; second, left pessimism is the only guarantee of political and scholarly seriousness.

Political economy's idea of cultural analysis seems to involve very little more than detailing access to, and availability of, cultural texts and practices. Nowhere does it actually advocate a consideration of what these texts and practices might mean (textually) or be made to mean in use (consumption). Moreover, as Golding and Murdock point out,

> in contrast to recent work on audience activity within cultural studies, which concentrates on the negotiation of textual interpretations and media use in immediate social settings, critical political economy seeks to relate variations in people's responses to their overall location in the economic system (27).

This seems to suggest that audience negotiations are fictions, merely illusory moves in a game of economic power. Cultural theorists, especially within cultural studies, who reject this view are dismissed as being guilty of giving currency to 'an influential version of . . . free market philosophy' (28). By reducing consumption to simple questions of 'access', the political-economy-of-culture approach threatens, despite its admirable intentions, to collapse everything back into the economic.

## Leavisism

The work of the Leavisites (I am concerned here only with the work of F.R. Leavis, Q.D. Leavis and Denys Thompson) spans a period of 40 years. However, their

attitude to consumption, especially the consumption of popular culture, was formed in the early 1930s with the publication of three works: *Mass Civilisation and Minority Culture* (F.R. Leavis), *Fiction and the Reading Public* (Q.D. Leavis) and *Culture and Environment* (F.R. Leavis and Denys Thompson).

Leavisism is based on the assumption that 'culture has always been in minority keeping' (Leavis and Thompson 1977: 3). Really meaningful consumption is always limited to a truly cultured minority. As Leavis and Thompson explain,

> Upon the minority depends our power of profiting by the finest human experience of the past; they keep alive the subtlest and most perishable parts of tradition. Upon them depend the implicit standards that order the finer living of an age, the sense that this is worth more than that, this rather than that is the direction in which to go, that the centre is here rather than there (5).[2]

Unfortunately, the twentieth century has witnessed a change in the status of this minority. No longer can it command cultural deference; no longer is its cultural authority allowed to go unchallenged. Q.D. Leavis describes this as a situation in which 'the minority, who had hitherto set the standard of taste without any serious challenge' have experienced a 'collapse of authority' (1978: 185, 187). She longs for a return to a previous golden age when 'the masses' exhibited an 'unquestioning assent to authority' (191).[3] She quotes Edmund Gosse to confirm the seriousness of the situation.

> One danger which I have long foreseen from the spread of the democratic sentiment, is that of the traditions of literary taste, the canons of literature, being reversed with success by a popular vote. Up to the present time, in all parts of the world, the masses of uneducated or semi-educated persons, who form the vast majority of readers, though they cannot and do not . . . appreciate the classics of their race, have been content to acknowledge their traditional supremacy. Of late there have seemed to me to be certain signs, especially in America, of a revolt of the mob against our literary masters. . . . If literature is to be judged by a plebiscite and if the plebs recognise its power, it will certainly by degrees cease to support reputations which give it no pleasure and which it cannot comprehend. The revolution against taste, once begun, will land us in irreparable chaos (quoted in Q.D. Leavis 1978: 190).

According to F.R. Leavis, what Gosse had only feared had now come to pass. It is against the threat of continuing cultural decline that Leavisism proposes to develop particular strategies of consumption: 'to introduce into schools training in resistance [to mass culture]' (F.R. Leavis 1933: 188–9); and outside schools, to promote a 'conscious and directed effort . . . [to] take the form of resistance by an armed and active minority' (Q.D. Leavis 1978: 270).

In this way, the Leavisites were concerned to address what F.R. Leavis, writing in 1930, called the 'desperate plight of culture today' (2013:12). They viewed the twentieth century as being marked by an increasing cultural decline. The century was characterized, they claimed, by the development of a culture of 'standardisation and levelling down' (Leavis and Thompson 1977: 3) which had its origins in the nineteenth century, with the devastating impact of industrialization and urbanization, but which had continued to develop in the twentieth. To have any hope of reversing or even slowing down this process, they argued, would require special attention to matters of consumption; in short, 'the citizen . . . must be trained to discriminate and to resist' (5).There are, however, certain forms of mass culture which are better avoided altogether. Popular fiction, for example, is condemned for offering addictive forms of 'compensation' and 'distraction':

> This form of compensation . . . is the very reverse of recreation, in that it tends, not to strengthen and refresh the addict for living, but to increase his [or her] unfitness by habituating him to weak evasions, to the refusal to face reality at all (100).

Similarly, Q.D. Leavis refers to such reading as 'a drug addiction to fiction' (1978: 152), and, for those readers unfortunate enough to become involved with romantic fiction, it can lead to 'a habit of fantasying [which] will lead to maladjustment in actual life' (54). For those not addicted to the consumption of popular fiction there is always the danger of the cinema. The cinema's increasing popularity makes it a very dangerous source of pleasure indeed: 'they [films] involve surrender, under conditions of hypnotic receptivity, to the cheapest emotional appeals, appeals the more insidious because they are associated with a compellingly vivid illusion of actual life' (F.R. Leavis 1998: 15). For Q.D. Leavis, Hollywood films are 'largely masturbatory' (1978: 165). Although the popular press is described as 'the most powerful and pervasive de-educator of the public mind' (Leavis and Thompson 1977: 138), and radio is claimed to be putting an end to critical thought (F.R. Leavis 2013: 14), it is for advertising, with its 'unremitting, pervasive, masturbatory manipulations', that F.R. Leavis saves his most condemnatory tone.

The texts and practices of advertising are for Leavisism the very epitome of cultural decline. To understand why we must understand Leavisism's attitude to language. In their manifesto for good educational practice, *Culture and Environment*, Leavis and Thompson state: 'it should be brought home to learners that this debasement of language is not merely a matter of words; it is a debasement of emotional life, and the quality of living' (1977: 4). In this way, advertising is not just blamed for debasing the language, but is condemned for debasing the emotional life of the whole language community; reducing 'the standard of living'. They provide examples (mostly written by F.R. Leavis himself) for analysis. The questions they pose are very revealing of their general attitude. Here is a typical example, an advert for Two Quakers tobacco:

THE TOBACCO OF TYPICAL TWIST

'Yes, it's the best I've ever smoked. But it's deuced expensive.' 'What's the tuppence extra? And anyway, you get it back an' more. Burns clean and slow – that's the typical twist, – gives it the odd look. Cute scientific dodge. You see, they experimented . . .' 'Oh! cut the cackle, and give us another fill. You talk like an advertisement.' Thereafter peace and a pipe of Two Quakers.

They suggest the following questions for school students in the fifth and sixth forms (mostly 17 and 18 years of age): '1. Describe the type of person represented; 2. How are you expected to feel towards him? 3. What do you think his attitude would be towards us? How would he behave in situations where mob passions run high?' (16–17). Two things are remarkable about these questions. First of all, the connection that is made between the advertisement and so-called mob passions. Second, notice the exclusive 'we'; and note also how the pronoun attempts to construct membership of a small, educated elite. Other questions operate in the same way. Here are a few examples:

> What kind of person can you imagine responding to such an appeal as this last? What acquaintance would you expect them to have of Shakespeare's work and what capacity for appreciating it? Pupils can be asked to recall their own observations of the kind of people they may have seen visiting 'shrines' (51).

After describing the cinema as 'cheapening, debasing, distorting', they ask: 'Develop the discussion of the educational value of cinema as suggested here' (144). Rather than encouraging 'discrimination and resistance', it is difficult to see how such questions would invite, with regard to the patterns of consumption of 'other' people, anything other than a debilitating and self-confirming snobbery.

It is easy to be critical of the Leavisite approach to consumption. However, it should be remembered that from a historical point of view, the tradition's work is absolutely foundational to the project of the study of consumption in (British) cultural studies. Furthermore, the impact of the tradition is difficult to overestimate: for more than a century (if we include the work of Matthew Arnold) it was undoubtedly the dominant paradigm in cultural analysis. Indeed, it could be argued that it still forms a kind of repressed 'common sense' in certain areas of British and American academic and non-academic life. However, having said this, although it is true that the Leavisites helped establish an educational space for the study of consumption, we should remain in no doubt about the nature of the kind of pedagogic practice they had in mind. The principal problem is Leavisism's working assumption that consumption of popular culture (the consumption practices of the many) are always presented, and are explicitly understood as, examples of cultural decline. Given this assumption, theoretical research and empirical investigation continued to confirm what they always expected to find.

The Leavisites looked down from the splendid heights of high culture to the commercial wastelands of the consumption practices of other people down below, seeking only confirmation of cultural decline, cultural difference and the need for cultural deference, regulation and control. This was a discourse of how 'other people' found satisfaction in forms of consumption which the Leavisites found distasteful – i.e. both the people and the commodities they consumed, because, ultimately, Leavisism is less about practices of consumption and much more about 'the masses' and their lived cultures.[4]

## The mythologies of Roland Barthes

Roland Barthes' early work on popular culture – with its concern with the processes of signification – introduces a very different way of seeing consumption as manipulation. Barthes' aim is to make explicit what he feels too often remains implicit in the texts and practices of popular culture. His directing principle is to always interrogate what he sees as 'the falsely obvious' (1973: 11). As he explains in *Mythologies*, one of the founding texts of British cultural studies, 'I resented seeing Nature and History confused at every turn, and I wanted to track down, in the decorative display of what-goes-without-saying, the ideological abuse which, in my view, is hidden there' (ibid.).

Barthes uses Ferdinand de Saussure's (1974) structuralist model of language to produce a semiological analysis of French popular culture. He uses Saussure's schema of signifier/signified = sign and adds to it a second level of signification. In Barthes' deployment, as illustrated in Figure 2.1, the sign of primary signification becomes the signifier of secondary signification. In *Elements of Semiology* he substitutes the more familiar terms denotation (primary signification) and connotation (secondary signification): 'the first system [denotation] becomes the plane of expression or signifier of the second system [connotation) . . . The signifiers of connotation . . . are made up of signs (signifiers and signifieds united) of the denoted system' (1967: 89–91).

Barthes claims that it is at the level of secondary signification or connotation that what he calls 'myth' is produced for consumption. Myths are the stories societies live by. They provide ways of conceptualizing and understanding the world, and

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Primary signification | 1. Signifier | 2. Signified |
| Denotation | 3. Sign | |
| Secondary signification | I. SIGNIFIER | II. SIGNIFIED |
| Connotation | III. SIGN | |

**FIGURE 2.1** Primary and secondary signification.

therefore they are crucial to a society's efforts to construct and maintain a sense of self-identity (in terms of acceptable sameness and unacceptable difference). For Barthes myth attempts to become a society's 'common sense' – to produce and put into circulation modes of thinking in which what is cultural (i.e. made by humans) is understood as natural (i.e. a result of the 'laws' of nature). For Barthes' myth, like classical versions of ideology, is a body of ideas and practices which seek to defend the prevailing structures of power by actively promoting the values and interests of the dominant groups in society. Myth is successful to the extent it is able to naturalize and universalize the interests of dominant groups as if they were the interests of all members of society. To understand this aspect of Barthes' argument we need to understand the polysemic nature of signs; that is, that they have the potential to signify multiple meanings. He argues that all forms of signification can be shown to operate in this way. His most famous example of the workings of secondary signification is taken from the cover of the French magazine *Paris Match* (1955). He begins his analysis by establishing that the primary level of signification consists of a signifier: patches of colour and figuration. This in turn produces the signified: 'a black soldier saluting the French flag'. Together they form the primary sign. The primary sign then becomes the signifier 'black soldier saluting the French flag', producing the signified 'French imperiality'. Here is Barthes' account of his encounter with the cover of the magazine:

> I am at the barber's, and a copy of *Paris Match* is offered to me. On the cover, a young Negro in a French uniform is saluting, with his eyes uplifted, probably fixed on the fold of the tricolour. All this is the meaning of the picture. But, whether naively or not, I see very well what it signifies to me: that France is a great Empire, that all her sons, without colour discrimination, faithfully serve under her flag, and that there is no better answer to the detractors of an alleged colonialism than the zeal shown by this Negro in serving his so-called oppressors. I am therefore faced with a greater semiological system: there is a signifier, itself already formed with a previous system (a black soldier is giving the French salute); there is a signified (it is a purposeful mixture of Frenchness and militariness); finally there is a presence of the signified through the signifier (1973: 125–6).

At the level of primary signification (denotation) the cover of *Paris Match* presents a black soldier saluting the French flag. This produces, according to Barthes, at the level of secondary signification (connotation), a positive image of French imperialism. Following the defeat in Vietnam (1946–54), and the then current war in Algeria (1954–62), such an image would have been seen by many to be of some political urgency. Of course this is not the only way French imperialism might be given positive connotations. Barthes suggests other mythical signifiers the press might employ:

> I can very well give to French imperiality many other signifiers beside a Negro's salute: a French general pins a decoration on a one-armed Senegalese, a nun hands a cup of tea to a bed-ridden Arab, a white schoolmaster teaches attentive piccaninnies (138).

Barthes contends that 'myth has . . . a double function: it points out and it notifies, it makes us understand something and it imposes it on us' (126).

> Myth has an imperative, buttonholing character . . . [it arrests] in both the physical and the legal sense of the term: French imperialism condemns the saluting Negro to be nothing more than an instrumental signifier, the Negro suddenly hails me in the name of French imperiality; but at the same moment the Negro's salute thickens, becomes vitrified, freezes into an eternal reference meant to establish French imperiality (134–5).[5]

The ideological power of myth derives from its capacity to transform history into nature: 'Semiology has taught us that myth has the task of giving an historical intention a natural justification, and making contingency appear eternal. Now this process is exactly that of bourgeois ideology' (142). As Barthes eloquently explains, 'myth is constituted by the loss of the historical quality of things: in it, things lose the memory that they once were made' (155).

> In the case of the soldier Negro . . . what is got rid of is certainly not French imperiality (on the contrary, since what must be actualised is its presence); it is the contingent, historical, in one word: *fabricated*, quality of colonialism. Myth does not deny things, on the contrary, its function is to talk about them; simply, it purifies them, it makes them innocent, it gives them a natural and eternal justification, it gives them a clarity which is not that of an explanation but that of a statement of fact. If I state the fact of French imperiality without explaining it, I am very near to finding that it is natural and goes without saying . . . In passing from history to nature, myth acts economically: it abolishes the complexity of human acts . . . it organises a world which is without contradictions because it is without depth, a world wide open and wallowing in the evident, it establishes a blissful clarity: things appear to mean something by themselves (156).

This is what is happening on the cover of *Paris Match*: the black soldier saluting the flag is 'naturalized' into a benign image of French imperialism. We are invited to share in the obviousness of it all: there is nothing to discuss, it is unmistakable that one implies the presence of the other. As Barthes explains,

> what allows the reader to consume myth innocently is that he [or she] does not see it as a semiological system but as an inductive one. Where there is only equivalence, he sees a kind of causal process: the signifier and the signified

> have, in his eyes, a natural relationship. This confusion can be expressed otherwise: any semiological system is a system of values; now the myth-consumer takes the signification for a system of facts: myth is read as a factual system, whereas it is but a semiological system (142).

What makes the move from primary signification (denotation) to secondary signification (connotation) a possibility are the shared cultural codes on which both Barthes and the readership of *Paris Match* are able to draw. Without access to this shared code (conscious or unconscious) the operations of secondary signification (connotation) would not be possible. And of course such knowledge is always both historical and cultural. That is to say, it might differ from one culture to another, and from one historical moment to another. Cultural difference might also be marked by differences of class, 'race', ethnicity, gender, generation or sexual preference. As Barthes explains,

> reading closely depends on my culture, on my knowledge of the world, and it is probable that a good press photograph (and they are all good, being selected) makes ready play with the supposed knowledge of its readers, those prints being chosen which comprise the greatest possible quantity of information of this kind in such a way as to render the reading fully satisfying (1977: 29).

Secondary significations (connotations) are therefore not simply produced by the makers of the image, but activated from an already existing cultural repertoire. In other words, the image both draws from the cultural repertoire and at the same time makes an addition to it. This is a process of consumption as manipulation in which we as readers are active and complicit participants.

## Problems with the consumption-as-manipulation model

As the rest of this book will address, both implicitly and explicitly, a range of problems with the 'consumption-as-manipulation' model, I will conclude this chapter with just a few schematic points that can act as an introduction to the remainder of the book. The Australian cultural critic John Docker finds the claims about the disabling influence of mass culture, as outlined by Adorno and Horkheimer, to be nothing short of 'preposterous, ludicrous' (1994: 41). He describes their attitude to establishing 'evidence' for the claims they make as 'disturbingly casual and even laughable . . . complacent, and . . . repellent' (ibid.). According to Docker, the work of the Frankfurt School (especially Adorno), and the 'modernist conformity' (55) of the early work of Barthes (especially *Mythologies*), displays an 'overriding modernist assumption, that we . . . can read off knowledge of audience responses and reception – the human condition of the mass of the population – from our (presumed) knowledge of mass culture texts' (46). He is

even more dismissive of the work of the Leavisites. For example, he calls Q.D. Leavis's approach 'comical', and describes her approach to consumption as that of 'an old-style colonialist ethnographer, staring with distaste at the barbaric ways of strange and unknown people' (25).

Michael Denning, who is generally quite positive about the work of the Frankfurt School, identifies a certain tendency in Adorno and Horkheimer to simplify the workings of the culture industries.[6] In a discussion of the production of dime novels as a part of the emerging culture industry in the nineteenth-century United States, Denning rejects Adorno and Horkheimer's rather too easy correlation of the culture industry and mass deception, making the point:

> As in other capitalist industries, there are struggles both at the point of production, the writing of these dime novels; and at the point of consumption, the reading of cheap stories. So a history of dime novels is not simply a history of a culture industry; it also encompasses a history of their place in working class culture, and of their role in the struggles to reform that culture (1998: 26).

In other words, Denning is insisting on taking seriously questions of both structure and agency. The trouble with much of the work of the Frankfurt School on mass culture (and evident in similar work undertaken from the perspective of political economy generally) is that it encourages a detailed understanding of the workings of production, while suggesting that a cursory glance will be more than enough to understand the practices of consumption. There can be no doubt that the culture industries seek to manipulate and exploit consumers. But it is certainly not the case that the practices of consumption can be seen as the total and always successful manipulation of passive subjects. What is needed is a more complex account. One that takes on board even some of the more obvious aspects of consumption would be a start; for example, full recognition that a commodity produced by the culture industries may not have sole access to an individual consumer. First, consumption always occurs in a context (i.e. a social space often containing other people and other commodities, perhaps making counter-claims, or just seeking to undermine the appeal of a rival's products); second, consumers are not blank sheets of paper, but people who come to acts of consumption with a history of other moments of consumption.

Docker's criticisms of the Frankfurt School and of the early work of Barthes seem to suggest that how to determine the political effectivity of a text or practice is ultimately an ethnographic question. The nature and extent of impact a text will have on its consumer cannot be judged by formal analysis alone; the only way to decide this question is by examining how it is made meaningful by its consumers. According to the anthropologists George Marcus and Michael Fischer, ethnography is 'modern anthropology's major intellectual contribution to scholarship' (Marcus and Fischer 1986: 20).[7] They describe the ethnographic method as follows:

> Ethnography is a research process in which the anthropologist closely observes, records, and engages in the daily life of another culture – an experience labelled as the fieldwork method – and then writes accounts of this culture, emphasizing descriptive detail. These accounts are the primary form in which fieldwork procedures, the other culture, and the ethnographer's personal and theoretical reflections are accessible to professionals and other readerships (18).

Ethnography (including what passes for ethnography in cultural studies)[8] does not of course give direct access to why and how people consume and turn particular commodities into culture. What it does provide access to is people's accounts of what they are doing and why they do it. This means, regardless of descriptive accuracy, that ethnographic accounts are always reports on other people's reports of what they do and why they do it. Even with these qualifications, political economy might learn some modesty by reading Marcus and Fischer's account of the rescaling of anthropology as it moved from nineteenth- to twentieth-century practice. They describe how 'the nineteenth-century grand vision of an anthropological science of Man' was 'redrawn' under the impact of the twentieth-century practice of ethnography:

> the nineteenth-century tendency to make sweeping global statements was rescaled. As an ethnographer, the anthropologist focuses his efforts on a different sort of holism: not to make universally valid statements, but to represent a particular way of life as fully as possible (22).

Cultural studies has learned a great deal from anthropology. At the very core of cultural studies is a definition of culture borrowed directly from anthropology; that is, Raymond Williams's now famous phrase, culture as 'a particular way of life' (1965: 57).[9] Moreover, cultural studies shares anthropology's view that culture is both a constructed and a contested terrain. Since the 1980s, the influence may have begun to run in a reverse direction. Marcus and Fischer for example, point out that

> The study of the mass-culture industry, popular culture, and the formation of public consciousness has emerged [within anthropology] as one of the most vigorous of new research directions . . . raising questions about cultural hegemony and how meaning structures are formed and negotiated by competing segments within a society (153, 154).

They add that they would like to congratulate the Birmingham Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies for having 'pioneered some of the ethnographic techniques for exploring this topic' (153).

## Notes

1 For an anthropological critique of the notion of 'true' and 'false' needs, see Marshall Sahlins 1976.

2 While this might be true in a general sense, that intellectuals concern themselves with such matters, it is not true that this is the work of a particular intellectual clique (i.e. Leavisites).

3 The Leavisites looked back longingly to a cultural golden age, a mythic rural past, when there was a shared culture uncorrupted by commercial interests. This was a time before the cultural fall of the nineteenth century. The golden age in Leavisism tends to be historically rather mobile, but the Elizabethan period of Shakespeare's theatre is often cited as such a time of cultural coherence before the disintegration of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries. F.R. Leavis writes of Shakespeare belonging 'to a genuinely national culture, to a community in which it was possible for the theatre to appeal to the cultivated and the populace at the same time' (1933: 216). Q.D. Leavis's comments on the organic relations between populace and cultivated are very revealing: 'the masses were receiving their amusement from above . . . They had to take the same amusements as their betters . . . Happily, they had no choice' (1978: 85). According to Q.D. Leavis,

> the spectator of Elizabethan drama, though he might not be able to follow the 'thought' minutely in the great tragedies, was getting his amusement from the mind and sensibility that produced those passages, from an artist and not from one of his own class. There was then no such complete separation as we have . . . between the life of the cultivated and the life of the generality. (264)

Clearly, then, the golden age was not just marked by cultural coherence, but happily for the Leavisites, a cultural coherence based on authoritarian and hierarchical principles. It was a common culture which gave intellectual stimulation at one end, and affective pleasure at the other. This was a mythic world in which everyone knew their place, knew their station in life.

4 As Raymond Williams points out in *Culture and Society*, 'There are in fact no masses; there are only ways of seeing other people as masses' (1963: 289).

5 Barthes' formulation is remarkably similar to Louis Althusser's (2013) concept of 'interpellation' (see Storey 2015).

6 Michael Denning argues for the continued use of the concept of the culture industry:

> The strength of the concept is twofold: it avoids a static and ahistorical dichotomy between elite culture and popular culture, since it marks a decisive break from earlier elite and folk cultures and emphasises the effects of that break on both cultures; and it draws attention to the commodification of culture – the restructuring of cultural production by wage labor, a capitalist market, and a capitalist labor process which divides, rationalizes, and deskills work. (1998: 25)

Denning makes a very valid point, one that is difficult to resist. My only disagreement is the use of industry in the singular rather than industries in the plural. In my view, seeing production in its complex and contradictory plurality presents a much more usable model of what is involved in the processes of production.

7 The British anthropologist Bronislaw Malinowski is generally regarded as the founder of the ethnographic method, first outlined in the opening chapter of his first major work, *Argonauts of the Western Pacific* (1922).

8 This is in part the subject of Chapters 5, 6 and 9 in this volume.

9 The formulation was quickly modified in cultural studies to 'particular *ways* of life'; seeing culture as cultures situated in relations of domination and subordination, struggle and negotiation.



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# 3

# CONSUMPTION AS SOCIAL COMMUNICATION

In this chapter we will consider the idea that consumption is a form of social communication. The chapter begins with a critical assessment of the foundational work of two early sociologists, Thorstein Veblen (working in the USA) and Georg Simmel (working in Germany). This is followed by a discussion of an influential study on the symbolic use of goods by social anthropologist Mary Douglas and economist Baron Isherwood. The work of Pierre Bourdieu on consumption and its use to mark and maintain social distinctions is discussed in the next section. Michel de Certeau on consumption as secondary production is the subject of the final section.

It is not unusual to read that we live in a consumer society in which everyday life is increasingly defined by practices of consumption. Henri Lefebvre, for example, takes a very pessimistic view of what this has produced. He maintains that everyday life is a 'bureaucratic society of controlled consumption' (2002: 68). Such a description of the everyday, while recognizing the power of capitalism to manipulate desire, seems to leave little space for human agency. It also seems to suggest that consumption has one meaning – bureaucratic control – and this meaning now defines the everyday. But to be fair to Lefebvre, in his account the bureaucratically controlled structure of consumption never quite eliminates human agency. This is true in part because he does not mean consumption as such (the buying of goods, etc.), but what he calls 'the persuasive ideology of consumption' (78) under which people are 'programmed' to consume; however, what they consume is a matter of choice. As he explains, 'The publicity that was intended to promote consumption is the first of consumer goods' (105). This ideology has a dual purpose: it promotes specific objects and it promotes a particular way of life. Through it 'we are told how to live better, how to dress fashionably, how to decorate your house, in short how to exist; you are totally and thoroughly programmed' (107). Therefore, although the bureaucratically controlled structure

of consumption may never quite eliminate human agency, it seems to remain the case, according to Lefebvre, that we are 'totally and thoroughly programmed' (ibid.). We shall return to some of these ideas, presented in a very different argument, in Chapter 8. But before that, the rest of the chapter will discuss ways of thinking about consumption that go beyond envisioning it as a form of bureaucratic control. What these different theories of consumption have in common is that each situates practices of consumption as fundamental to human agency and social communication.

## Conspicuous consumption

Around the turn of the nineteenth century, two sociologists, Thorstein Veblen writing in 1899 in the United States and Georg Simmel writing in 1903 and 1904 in Germany, published work that discussed new everyday patterns of urban middle-class consumption. Veblen argues that what he calls the leisure class (the middle class who had become very rich as a result of the industrial revolution), as part of its strategy to secure and display its new social position, seek to present what it has acquired through success in business as if it were something natural to itself. 'Conspicuous consumption' is the chosen means to communicate this fact to other social classes. Veblen argues against the view that this is little more than harmless and irrelevant display. The social display of conspicuous consumption is the very pageant of power; from its prestige grows authority. Moreover, he insists that 'the leisure-class scheme of life . . . extends its coercive influence' throughout society as a whole (1994: 83–4). 'The leisure class stands at the head of the social structure in point of reputability; and its manner of life and its standards of worth therefore afford the norm of reputability for the community' (84). In this way the example of the leisure class acts to direct social energies away from productive work and into wasteful displays of conspicuous consumption.

He offers the example of the ways in which the canons of conspicuous consumption exercise a distorting influence over ideals of feminine beauty. The delicate and the diminutive, for example, are promoted in order to display to the world that the women of the leisure class are incapable of productive work. In this way, women are reduced to symbols of 'vicarious consumption'. Woman is little more than a servant, whose task it is to exhibit in a public display her master's economic power. According to Veblen, 'She is useless and expensive, and she is consequently valuable as evidence of pecuniary strength' (149). Women learn to conform to this standard, and men learn to read women's conformity as the very epitome of beauty. Modes of male dress are not exempt from the dictates of the leisure-class canons of decency and good taste. Male apparel must demonstrate the ability to consume without economic restraint. It must also indicate that the wearer is not engaged in productive work. As Veblen explains,

> Elegant dress serves its purpose of elegance not only in that it is expensive, but also because it is the insignia of leisure. It not only shows that the wearer

> is able to consume a relatively large value, but it argues at the same time that he consumes without producing (171).

In an essay called 'The Metropolis and Mental Life' (first published in 1903), the German sociologist Georg Simmel identified a similar mode of behaviour in the new distinctive urban culture of Berlin at the turn of the century. Confronted by the perceived anonymity of city life, the new urban middle class used particular patterns of consumption to maintain and to display a sense of individuality. As he observed, 'The deepest problems of modern life derive from the claim of the individual to preserve the autonomy and individuality of his existence in the face of overwhelming social forces' (1964: 409). Faced with 'the difficulty of asserting his own personality within the dimensions of metropolitan life' (420), individuals are 'tempted to adopt the most tendentious peculiarities . . . extravagances of mannerism, caprice, and precariousness' (421). Simmel argues that the 'meaning' of such behaviour lies not in its particular content but 'in its form of "being different", of standing out in a striking manner and thereby attracting attention' (ibid.).

Simmel further pursued and elaborated these ideas in an essay on fashion (originally published in 1904). In this essay he argues that modern urban societies are marked by an increased tension between 'two antagonistic principles', which, he claims, have governed the historical development of the human race – the principles of 'generalization' and 'specialization' (1957: 542). Simmel sees these principles as manifest in two types of individual, the 'imitative' and the 'teleological'. As he explains, 'The imitator is the passive individual, who believes in social similarity and adapts himself to existing elements; the teleological individual, on the other hand, is ever experimenting, always restlessly striving, and he relies on his own personal conviction' (543). Fashion, driven as it is by a continuous social cycle of imitation and differentiation, is for Simmel an excellent example of these principles in social operation. Moreover, it is a process that depends for its success on the active involvement of both types of individuals, imitative (who follow fashions and thus satisfy their need to adapt) and teleological (who instigate them and thus satisfy their need to innovate). In more general terms, the way fashion as a social practice is said to work is that subordinate groups seek to improve their social status by imitating the dress codes and forms of behaviour of their immediate superordinate group; the superordinate group is then forced to seek new fashions in order to maintain its social difference. As Simmel explains it, 'the fashions of the upper stratum of society are never identical with those of the lower; in fact, they are abandoned by the former as soon as the latter prepares to appropriate them' (ibid.). In this way, he argues, 'Fashion . . . is a product of class distinction' (544). It is of course always more than the product; it also has a role to play as producer, in that by a strategy of inclusion and exclusion, fashion helps reproduce social power and privilege by marking and maintaining the social differences and distinctions upon which it in part depends. As Simmel points out, 'fashion . . . signifies union with those in the same class, the uniformity of a circle characterized by it, and

. . . the exclusion of all other groups' (ibid.). It is not the content of fashion that matters, but the social differences it makes visible and helps maintain.

> Just as soon as the lower classes begin to copy their style, thereby crossing the line of demarcation the upper classes have drawn and destroying the uniformity of their coherence, the upper classes turn away from this style and adopt a new one, which in turn differentiates them from the masses (545).

When considering the relevance of the work of Veblen and Simmel for a critical understanding of consumption as it is now practised in the twenty-first century we have to fully recognize the historical location of their work and the historical problems it was seeking to address. This raises the question, are their critical insights still relevant for an understanding of contemporary practices of consumption? The answer is a qualified yes. In general terms, the practices and motivations they identified, if anything, seem more widespread now than ever before, and this, paradoxically, is the problem. Put simply, people from all social classes seem to now use consumption conspicuously to mark their difference from and similarity to other consumers. Equally, Simmel's general argument about fashion is no longer only applicable to the rich. But there is a problem with simply thinking we can transfer their arguments to the contemporary. Perhaps the most significant is their assumption that modern urban societies have consensual hierarchies of taste, mirroring consensual hierarchies of social class. In other words, those at the bottom or in the middle, it is assumed, strive to be like those at the top. This is a very linear model of consumption, which excludes the possibility that classes, other than those at the top, might well choose to compete to be different, or that fashions could originate from both bottom and middle. Both simply assume that those at the bottom or those in the middle will always seek to emulate those at the top of the class structure.[1] But beyond this, and even more crucially, it is necessary to broaden the scope of who might be involved in practices of conspicuous consumption and of imitation and differentiation. Such activity is no longer limited to social classes. It can also be used to mark differences of, for example, gender, ethnicity, generation and sexuality.

## Consumption as culture

In stark contrast to the positions outlined by Veblen and Simmel, Mary Douglas and Baron Isherwood reject the view that 'emulation, envy, and striving to be better than the Joneses are the intentions which fuel consumption' (1996: xxi).[2] Instead of imitation and exclusion, they see consumption as a form of expression more concerned with 'making visible and stable the categories of culture' (38). According to Douglas and Isherwood, because goods are expressive they can be used as a symbolic means to communicate with others. As they contend, 'goods are part of a live information system' (xiv). Although 'Goods are neutral, their uses are social; they can be used as fences or bridges' (xv). As they explain,

> As far as keeping a person alive is concerned, food and drink are needed for physical services; but as far as social life is concerned, they are needed for mustering solidarity, attracting support, requiting kindnesses, and this goes for the poor as well as for the rich (xxi).

The symbolic value of objects in the 'information system' is not inherent in the objects themselves. Value is something 'conferred by human judgments' (xxii). To understand the value of one object, it is necessary to locate it in the information system as a whole. Similarly, goods do not communicate by themselves, they communicate 'like flags' (xxiv), and thus require the active agency of human subjects. But as they insist, 'consumption goods are most definitely not mere messages; they constitute the very system itself. Take them out of human intercourse and you have dismantled the whole thing' (49). In this way, 'Consumption is the very arena in which culture is fought over and licked into shape' (37). As they observe,

> The housewife with her shopping basket arrives home: some things in it she reserves for her household; some for the father, some for the children; others are destined for the special delectation of guests. Whom she invites into her house, what parts of the house she makes available to outsiders, how often, what she offers them for music, food, drink, and conversation, these choices express and generate culture in its general sense (ibid.).

Rather than seeing the consumption of goods as 'primarily needed for subsistence [economic theory] plus competitive display [Veblen and Simmel]', they argue that the consumption of goods has a 'double role in providing subsistence and in drawing lines of social relationships' (39). As a mode of communication, 'the essential function of consumption is its capacity to make sense' (40); and thus to 'make and maintain social relationships' (39). Moreover, we must leave behind the 'false distinction' between goods that minister to physical needs (eating and drinking, for example), and those that tender to our more aesthetic inclinations (reading poetry, watching television, for example), because, as they insist, 'all goods carry meaning' (49). Furthermore, 'any choice between goods is the result of, and contributes to, culture' (52). For example, if I invite friends for dinner the food and drink I serve is not randomly chosen, it is selected because, hopefully, it is good to eat and drink, but also because it communicates something about the evening I have planned. I might invite the same friends to a dinner to celebrate a birthday or I might invite them to watch Manchester United win the Champions League, but at each meal I will serve food and drink that seems appropriate for the occasion. In other words, at each meal the meaning of the event is partly constructed as meaningful by the food and drink chosen to communicate these different meanings.

Therefore, to fully appreciate consumption as a mode of communication, we must think of it as a language: 'Forget that commodities are good for eating, clothing, and shelter; forget their usefulness and try instead the idea that commodities are good for thinking; treat them as a nonverbal medium for the human

creative faculty' (40–1). The practice of consumption is a 'joint production, with fellow consumers, of a universe of values. Consumption uses goods to make firm and visible a particular set of judgements in the fluid processes of classifying persons and events' (41). In this way, consumption is a 'ritual activity' (45) in which people consume to communicate with other consumers, and the shifting accumulations of these acts of consumption constitute the making of culture. What underpins this system and ultimately gives it meaning, what consumption is in the end really communicating, is an underlying cognitive order. As they explain, 'the clue to finding real partitioning among goods must be to trace some underlying partitioning in society' (68).

## Consumption as class struggle

In an argument that recalls the work of Veblen and Simmel, but is a great deal more sophisticated than both, Pierre Bourdieu demonstrates how particular patterns of consumption are used for purposes of making, marking and maintaining social distinction. Whereas Douglas and Isherwood see consumption as the neutral underpinning of 'some underlying partitioning in society', Bourdieu maintains that it is a significant area of struggle between and within social classes. Bourdieu's model of consumption, although sharing Douglas and Isherwood's view of consumption as communication, insists that consumption is not a polite conversation about an underlying cognitive order, but a heated debate about class difference and class distinction. He argues that what people consume does not simply reflect distinctions and differences embedded elsewhere, that consumption makes visible, as Douglas and Isherwood suggest, but that consumption is the means by which difference and distinction are produced, maintained and reproduced. In other words, consumption does not reflect the social order, it helps legitimize it. Like Veblen, he seeks to demonstrate how what social groups consume is part of a strategy for hierarchicizing social space. However, whereas Veblen was concerned almost exclusively with the leisure class, Bourdieu argues that differences in consumption are always an important aspect in the struggle between dominant and subordinate classes.[3] He shows how arbitrary tastes and arbitrary ways of living are continually transmuted into legitimate taste and the only legitimate way of life. The 'illusion of "natural distinction" is ultimately based on the power of the dominant to impose, by their very existence, a definition of excellence which [is] nothing other than their own way of existing' (1992: 255). In other words, dominant classes seek to impose their own tastes as if these were in fact universal tastes.

Bourdieu's interest is in the processes by which patterns of consumption help to secure and legitimate forms of power and domination that are ultimately rooted in economic inequality. In other words, he argues that although class rule is ultimately economic, the form it takes is cultural; patterns of consumption are used to secure social distinction, the making, marking and maintaining of social difference. The source of social difference and social power is thus symbolically shifted from the economic field to the field of consumption, making social power

appear to be the result of a specific cultural disposition. In this way, the production and reproduction of cultural space helps produce and reproduce social space, social power and class difference. Bourdieu's purpose, therefore, is not to prove the self-evident, that different classes have different patterns of consumption, but to show how consumption (from high art to food on the table) forms a distinct pattern of social distinction, and to identify and interrogate the processes by which the making and maintaining of these distinctions secures and legitimates forms of power and control rooted ultimately in economic inequalities. He is interested not so much in the actual differences, but in how these differences are used by dominant classes as a means of social reproduction. Only by producing a 'barbarous reintegration of aesthetic consumption into the world of ordinary consumption (against which it endlessly defines itself)' (100) will we fully understand the social and political role of consumption. As he maintains, 'one cannot fully understand cultural practices unless "culture", in the restricted, normative sense of ordinary usage, is brought back into "culture" in the anthropological sense, and the elaborated taste for the most refined objects is reconnected with the elementary taste for the flavours of food' (1).

Bourdieu insists that taste is always more than an aesthetic category. As he points out, 'taste classifies, and it classifies the classifier' (6). We are classified by our classifications and classify others by theirs. In this way, he would argue that similar things are happening when I 'value' a holiday destination or a particular mode of dress, as are happening when I 'value' a poem by John Clare or a song by Bob Dylan or an opera by Giacomo Puccini. Such evaluations are never a simple matter of individual taste, consumption operates both to identify and to mark social distinction and to sustain social difference. While such strategies of classification do not in themselves produce social inequalities, the making, marking and maintaining of them functions to legitimate such inequalities. In this way, taste is a profoundly ideological discourse; it operates as a marker of 'class' (using the term in the double sense to mean both socio-economic category and a particular level of quality). He argues that consumption is, ultimately, 'predisposed . . . to fulfil a social function of legitimating social difference' (7).

The consumption of art is for Bourdieu the model for all forms of consumption. At the pinnacle of the hierarchy of taste is the 'pure' aesthetic gaze – a historical invention – with its emphasis on aesthetic distance, and on form over function. Aesthetic distance is in effect the denial of function: it insists on the 'how' and not the 'what'. It is analogous to the difference between judging a meal good because it was economically priced and filling, and judging a meal good on the basis of how it was served, where it was served, etc. The 'pure' aesthetic gaze emerges with the emergence of the cultural field (in which texts and practices are divided into culture and mass culture). One in effect guarantees the other. Bourdieu sees the art museum as the institutionalization of the aesthetic gaze and the cultural field. Once inside the museum art loses all prior functions (except that of being art) and becomes pure form: 'Though originally subordinated to quite different or even incompatible functions (crucifix and fetish, Pieta and still life), these juxtaposed

works tacitly demand attention to form rather than function, technique rather than theme' (30). For example, an advertisement for soup displayed in an art gallery becomes an example of the aesthetic, whereas the same advertisement in a magazine is an example of the commercial. The effect of the distinction is to produce 'a sort of ontological promotion akin to a transubstantiation' (6). It is the institutionalization of such distinctions that produces what he calls the 'ideology of natural taste', the view that genuine 'appreciation' can only be attained by an instinctively gifted minority armed against the mediocrity of the masses. Ortega y Gasset makes the point with precision: 'art helps the "best" to know and recognise one another in the greyness of the multitude and to learn their mission, which is to be few in number and to have to fight against the multitude' (quoted in Bourdieu 1992: 31; see also Storey 2003).

As Bourdieu points out, 'it is not easy to describe the "pure" gaze without also describing the naive gaze which it defines itself against' (32). The naive gaze is of course the gaze of the popular aesthetic:

> The affirmation of continuity between art and life, which implies the subordination of form to function . . . a refusal of the refusal which is the starting point of the high aesthetic, i.e., the clear cut separation of ordinary dispositions from the specially aesthetic disposition (32).

The relation between the pure and the popular aesthetic is needless to say not one of equality, but a relation of dominant and dominated. The popular aesthetic, in its stress on function over form, is necessarily contingent and pluralistic, contrary, and in deference to the absolute insistence of the supposed transcendent universality of the pure aesthetic. Bourdieu sees the two aesthetics as articulating the two separate but related realms of necessity and freedom. Without the required cultural capital[4] to decipher the 'code' of art, people are made socially vulnerable to the condescension of those who do have cultural capital. What is social is presented as innate, and, in turn, used to justify what is social. Like other ideological strategies, 'The ideology of natural taste owes its plausibility and its efficacy to the fact that . . . it naturalises real differences, converting differences in the mode of acquisition of culture into differences of nature' (68). Aesthetic relations thus mimic and help reproduce social relations of power. As Bourdieu observes,

> Aesthetic intolerance can be terribly violent . . . The most intolerable thing for those who regard themselves as the possessors of legitimate culture is the sacrilegious reuniting of tastes which taste dictates shall be separated. This means that the games of artists and aesthetes and their struggles for the monopoly of artistic legitimacy are less innocent than they seem. At stake in every struggle over art there is also the imposition of an art of living, that is, the transmutation of an arbitrary way of living into the legitimate way of life which casts every other way of living into arbitrariness (57).

Bourdieu's work on consumption is underpinned by his view of education. Rather than being a means to lessen inequality, it functions to legitimate it. He argues that the education system fulfils a quite specific social and political function: that is, to legitimate social inequalities which exist prior to its operations. It achieves this by transforming social differences into academic differences, and presenting these differences as if they were 'grounded in nature' (387). The cultural tastes of dominant classes are given institutional form, and then, with deft ideological sleight of hand, their taste for this institutionalized culture (i.e. their own) is held up as evidence of their cultural, and, ultimately, their social, superiority. In this way, social distinction is generated by learned patterns of consumption that are internalized as 'natural' cultural preferences and interpreted and mobilized as evidence of 'natural' cultural competences, which are, ultimately, used to justify forms of class domination. To fully understand this we need to understand how Bourdieu distinguishes between three types of capital – economic, social and cultural. In capitalist societies economic capital in the form of money, property, etc. is able to buy access to cultural and social capital. Hierarchies openly based on the accumulation of economic capital are vulnerable to challenge. Cultural and social capital is able to conceal and legitimate economic domination by reproducing it in the form of cultural and social hierarchies.[5] One of the great strengths of Bourdieu's work on consumption is that, together with the introduction of invaluable concepts such as cultural capital and social distinction, it makes visible everyday political practices that are in the very fabric of everyday life but are rarely seen as political at all.

## Consumption as secondary production

In *The Practice of Everyday Life*, the French cultural theorist Michel de Certeau is concerned with the ways in which consumption always communicates something about social power. His particular focus is on what he calls the 'ways of operating' of ordinary consumers as they move across the everyday landscape of production. 'Everyday life', he claims, 'invents itself by poaching in countless ways on the property of others' (1984: xii). As he explains,

> The purpose of this work is to make explicit the systems of operational combination (*les combinatoires d'operations*) which also compose a 'culture', and to bring to light the models of action characteristic of users whose status as dominated element in society (a status that does not mean that they are either passive or docile) is concealed by the euphemistic term 'consumers' (xi–xii).

He seeks to deconstruct the term 'consumer', to reveal the activity that lies within the act of consumption or what he prefers to call 'secondary production'. To do this we have to be willing to recognize 'the difference or similarity between . . . production . . . and the secondary production hidden in the process of its utilization

(xiii). Traditionally the critical gaze has fallen on production, seeing consumption as its predictable shadow. De Certeau seeks to challenge the idea that consumption is entirely knowable through an analysis of production. Consumption, he argues, 'is devious, it is dispersed, but it insinuates itself everywhere, silently and almost invisibly, because it does not manifest itself through its own products, but rather through its ways of using the products imposed by a dominant economic order' (xii–xiii). In order to explain what he means he offers the example of the ways in which the indigenous population of what is now South America, 'subverted from within' (xiii) the Spanish colonizers' imposed culture:

> Submissive, and even consenting to their subjection, the Indians nevertheless often made of the rituals, representations, and laws imposed on them something quite different from what their conquerors had in mind; they subverted them not by rejecting or altering them, but by using them with respect to ends and references foreign to the system they had no choice but to accept (ibid.).

In this way, 'their use of the dominant social order deflected its power, which they lacked the means to challenge'; and, as de Certeau observes, 'they escaped it without leaving it. The strength of their difference lay in procedures of "consumption"' (ibid.). Another example of the same process of subversion from within can be seen in the experience of the Africans who were enslaved and transported to the USA to work in the cotton plantations. As part of the process of instilling submission, the slaves were taught Christianity. As in de Certeau's example of Indians resisting Spanish culture, the slaves consumed and used the new religion as a means to think the possibilities of their own freedom. In other words, a religion that should have reconciled them to their position as slaves was used in such a way as to enable them not only to think outside the brutal confines of slavery, but also to think through the challenges and confrontations of the Civil Rights movement and beyond.

For de Certeau, the terrain of the everyday is a site of continual conflict (silent and almost invisible) between the 'strategies' of imposition (the power of production) and the 'tactics' of use (consumption or 'secondary production'). The difference between the two is that 'strategies are able to produce . . . and impose . . . whereas tactics can only use, manipulate' (30). What interests de Certeau is the 'multitude of "tactics" articulated in the details of everyday life' (xiv); what he also calls 'poetic ways of "making do"' (xv). Moreover, 'The tactics of consumption, the ingenious ways in which the weak make use of the strong, thus lend a political dimension to everyday practices' (xvii).

> Many everyday practices (talking, reading, moving about, shopping, cooking, etc.) are tactical in character. And so are, more generally, many "ways of operating": victories of the "weak" over the "strong" (whether the strength be that of powerful people or the violence of things or of an imposed

> order, etc.), clever tricks, knowing how to get away with things, 'hunter's cunning', manoeuvres (xix).

It is not difficult to see how so much of everyday life consists of 'secondary production' as consumers make meaning and culture from objects and practices that they did not produce themselves.

## Notes

1 For a critique of the social emulation model of consumption, see Chapter 1 in this volume.
2 Although they do agree that consumption in certain social contexts, 'with spontaneous sumptuary codes' (xxi), can operate as a means to exclude.
3 The class relations in what Bourdieu calls the cultural field are structured around two divisions: on the one hand, between the dominant classes and the subordinate classes, and on the other, within the dominant classes between those with high economic capital as opposed to high cultural capital, and those with high cultural capital as opposed to high economic capital.
4 Cultural capital is a social currency based on knowledge, familiarity and the ability to feel at ease with the texts and practices of 'legitimate' culture.
5 Although increased access to higher education, for example, would seem to be a move towards greater equality, the fact that it is always matched by a parallel inflation in qualifications demanded for particular types of employment works to undermine this possibility. Whereas in the past a school qualification would have secured a position in a particular type of employment, a university degree is now a requirement. Therefore although more people now go to university in the UK than ever before, the qualifications they leave with are worth much less in the employment market than, say, 20 years ago, when fewer people had degrees. In this way, the education system helps reproduce and legitimate a class hierarchy of social difference and social distinction.



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# 4

# CONSUMPTION AS PRODUCTION

In this chapter I consider a number of approaches in philosophy and literary theory that figure reading is a process that produces the text as read. This is an approach to consumption that maintains that the process of reading fictional texts is itself a form of cultural production. Putting this another way, the meaning of a novel by Thomas Hardy or a short story by Katherine Mansfield, or a poem by T.S. Eliot, cannot be separated from the meanings ascribed to these texts by actual readers who read them. Work on readers in literary theory and criticism is something that has developed over the past 30 to 35 years. Writing in 1980, in an introduction to a collection of essays on the relationship between the reader and the literary text, Susan Suleiman observed how 'The words reader and audience, once relegated to the status of the unproblematic and obvious, have acceded to a starring role' (1980: 3).

The chapter begins with a discussion of hermeneutics, the name given to the study and theory of interpretation. Although hermeneutics is a broad field of study, containing a range of positions on interpretation, I intend here to focus only on the work of the German philosopher Hans-Georg Gadamer. The next section considers the work of two German literary theorists, Wolfgang Iser and Hans Robert Jauss, who are both members of the so-called Constance School. The penultimate section focuses on the concept of 'interpretative communities' developed by the American literary critic Stanley Fish. The chapter concludes with an assessment of Tony Bennett and Janet Woollacott's model of the 'reading formation' and Gerard Genette's concept of paratextuality.

## Hermeneutics

In his major work, *Truth and Method*, Hans-Georg Gadamer argues that an understanding of a text is always from the perspective of the person who understands.

Authors may have intentions, and texts certainly have material structures, but meaning is not something inherent in a text (an unchanging essence); meaning is always something a person makes when he or she reads a text. Moreover, Gadamer is adamant that texts and readers always encounter each other in historical and social locations and that the situatedness of this encounter always informs the interaction between reader and text. In this way, he contends, a text is always read with preconceptions or prejudices; it is never encountered in a state of virginal purity, untouched by the knowledge with which, or the context in which, it is read. This is not, for Gadamer, something to regret, in a vain appeal to 'the ontological obstructions of the scientific concept of objectivity' (1979: 235), but is in fact the very conditions for understanding. It is through our preconceptions and prejudices that we organize our approach to a text. As Gadamer explains, 'the historicity of our existence entails that prejudices, in the literal sense of the word [pre-judgements], constitute the initial directedness of our whole ability to experience' (9). We always begin the task of understanding with 'our own fore-meanings . . . [our] own expectations of meaning' (238). This does not mean that our understanding of a text (its meaning) is therefore a subjective event, leading to the suggestion that any meaning can be subjectively imposed upon a text. Preconceptions or prejudices, as Gadamer insists, are not the same as 'false judgments' (240). Furthermore, although we approach a text with preconceived ideas, what we always encounter is the materiality of the text itself (particular words ordered in particular ways, which allow the reader to recognize a difference between, say, Shakespeare's 'Sonnet 138' and 'Sailing to Byzantium' by W.B. Yeats). This is of course an encounter in which our preconceived ideas may well be modified. An understanding of a text (its meaning) is therefore always a process in which preconceived ideas are confronted (and perhaps modified) by the materiality of the text. He describes this process, what he calls the 'hermeneutic circle' (259), as working like a dialogue of questions and answers: we ask questions of a text, but if a satisfactory understanding is to be achieved we must always remain open to the answers it gives to the questions we ask. Both text and reader bring something to the encounter. In this way,

> meanings cannot be understood in an arbitrary way . . . we cannot hold blindly to our own fore-meaning . . . we [must] remain open to the meaning . . . of the text. But this openness always includes our placing the other meaning [the meaning of the text] in a relation with the whole of our own meanings (238).

However, as Gadamer insists, 'Not occasionally only, but always, the meaning of a text goes beyond its author. That is why understanding is not merely . . . reproductive [simply activating the 'meaning' in the text], but [is] always . . . productive [producing a 'meaning' in the interaction between text and reader]' (264). He describes this process of dialogue between reader and text in which meaning is

made as a 'fusion of horizons' (273). The 'horizon of understanding' (conceptual framework; the taken for granted) of the reader confronts the 'horizon of understanding' of the text. It is in the space opened up between the two that meaning is made in a 'fusion of horizons of understanding' (340). In this way, understanding is a process of 're-creation', which is 'both bound and free' (107). As he explains,

> the discovery of the true meaning of a text or a work of art is never finished; it is in fact an infinite process. Not only are fresh sources of error constantly excluded, so that the true meaning has filtered out of it all kinds of things that obscure it, but there emerge continually new sources of understanding, which reveal unsuspected elements of meaning (266).

In other words, both text and reader are always historically situated, and therefore the encounter between the two is always a fusion of different historical horizons.

To provide some sense of what Gadamer is arguing against, I will now consider briefly the theoretical position of the influential American literary critic E.D. Hirsch. Hirsch argues that the 'objective meaning' of a literary text (as opposed to the contingent and variable 'significances' ascribed by readers) is the author's intended meaning. The meaning of a text and its author's intention are one and the same. Aware of the difficulties entailed in knowing for certain the nature of such intentions, the work of interpretation must nevertheless remain focused on the task to reveal what the author intended:

> Even though we can never be certain that our interpretative guesses are correct, we know that they can be correct and that the goal of interpretation as a discipline is constantly to increase the probability that they are correct . . . Only one interpretative problem can be answered with objectivity: 'What, in all probability, did the author mean to convey?' (1967: 207)

Matters of consumption (reduced by Hirsch to little more than questions of the extent to which authorial intention has been understood or misunderstood by readers) are of only secondary importance. It is of course possible to agree with Hirsch about there being a difference between authorial 'meaning' and the 'significances' discovered by readers in texts and yet draw conclusions very different from Hirsch's. One could argue that since authorial intentions are mostly unknowable (a point Hirsch concedes) and what we do have in abundance, and what in effect the institution of literature is largely made from, are readings of texts, we should take as our focus what readers take texts to mean, rather than what texts have supposedly been intended to mean. This would be to reverse Hirsch's logic of evaluation and to place consumption above production (knowing all the time that consumption is only possible when there is production and that production would surely cease without consumption).

## The Constance School: Iser and Jauss

Wolfgang Iser is a German literary theorist, a member of the Constance School of reception theory. Like Gadamer, Iser insists that the act of reading is always an act of production. He maintains that

> As a literary text can only produce a response when it is read, it is virtually impossible to describe this response without also analysing the reading process . . . the text represents a potential effect that is realized in the reading process . . . the meaning of the text is something that [the reader] has to assemble (1978: ix).[1]

The production of meaning, therefore, involves 'a dialectic relationship between text, reader, and their interaction' (x). Moreover, as Iser insists, 'meaning is [not] an object to be defined, but is an effect to be experienced' (10). It follows from this that the real focus of a literary critic should be not 'to teach the reader the meaning of the text, for without a subjective contribution and a context there is no such thing' (19). Rather, the object of study should be 'an analysis of what actually happens when one is reading a text, for that is when the text begins to unfold its potential; it is in the reader that the text comes to life' (ibid.). As he explains,

> Central to the reading of every literary work is the interaction between its structure and its recipient. [Therefore] . . . the study of a literary work should concern not only the actual text itself but also, and in equal measure, the actions involved in responding to that text. The text itself simply offers 'schematised aspects' through which the subject matter of the work can be produced, while the actual production takes place through an act of concretization (20–1).

Iser distinguishes between the text, the work and the reader. As he explains,

> The literary work has two poles, which we might call the artistic and the aesthetic: the artistic pole is the author's text and the aesthetic is the realization accomplished by the reader. In view of this polarity, it is clear that the work itself cannot be identical with the text or with the concretization, but must be situated somewhere between the two (21).

As he contends, 'the meaning of a literary text is not a definable entity but, if anything, a dynamic happening' (22). The text in effect, he argues, offers itself for 'performance' by a reader. In this way, 'literary texts initiate "performances" of meaning rather than actually formulating meanings themselves . . . [and, moreover] without the participation of the individual reader there can be no performance' (27). In other words, although the author produces the text, it is the reader,

according to Iser, who brings the text to life, and thus brings the work into meaningful existence. Therefore, it is in the act of reading that meaning is realized. However, although the text, in its potential as a performance script, offers to the reader 'certain conditions of actualisation' (34), or what he called in an earlier argument a range of 'polysemantic possibilities' (1974: 136), it still presents itself to the reader as a material structure, 'the repertoire of the text' (1978: 69), and thus limits the play of interpretation. There is always, therefore, 'the role offered by the text and the reader's own disposition, and as one can never be fully taken over by the other, there arises between the two [a] tension' (37).

Although in general terms, 'the role prescribed by the text will be the stronger . . . the reader's own disposition will never disappear totally' (ibid.). Performance of meaning always takes place in a context; the nature of the context both 'illuminates and stabilises the meaning' (62). Iser figures the literary text as an instruction manual for the performance of meaning. The repertoire of the text 'forms an organisational structure of meaning which must be optimised through the reading of the text. This optimisation will depend on the reader's own degree of awareness and on his willingness to open himself [or herself] up to an unfamiliar experience' (85). However, the repertoire of the text cannot totally determine the performance of meaning: the repertoire of the text 'can only offer the reader possibilities of organisation. Total organisation would mean that there was nothing left for the reader to do' (86). Moreover, 'the reader's task is not simply to accept, but to assemble for himself [or herself] that which is to be accepted' (97). As he observes,

> Although the reader must participate in the assembly of meaning by realizing the structure inherent in the text, it must not be forgotten that he stands outside the text. His position must therefore be manipulated by the text if his [or her] viewpoint is to be properly guided. Clearly, this viewpoint cannot be determined exclusively by the individual reader's personal history of experience, but this history cannot be totally ignored either: only when the reader has been taken outside his own experience can his viewpoint be changed. The constitution of meaning, therefore, gains its full significance when something happens to the reader. The constituting of meaning and the constituting of the reading subject are therefore interacting operations that are both structured by the aspects of the text (152).

As Iser contends, 'Reading is an activity that is guided by the text; this must be processed by the reader, who is then, in turn, affected by what he has processed' (163). In this way, reading can be seen as a creative process in which the text 'offers guidance as to what is to be produced, and therefore cannot itself be the product' (107). The difference he draws our attention to, between a text offering guidance on how it should be read and the text as the end product of reading, is an important theoretical distinction. It is a challenge to the many theoretical perspectives which advocate a view of meaning as something imposed on a reader by a text. As Iser

maintains, 'Reading is not a direct "internalisation", because it is not a one-way process, . . . [it is] a dynamic interaction between text and reader' (ibid.).

Hans Robert Jauss, a former student of Gadamer's, is a literary historian and like Iser is a member of the Constance School. Although he shares Iser's view that the indeterminacy of the text requires a reader to realize its meaning, he also insists, against Iser's rather asocial/ahistorical reader, that readers and readings are always historically situated within specific conditions of reading: This is a rejection of the widespread 'belief in the timeless substance of a literary work and in the timeless point of view of the reader' (1982: 196). As he maintains,

> A literary work is not an object which stands by itself and that . . . offers the same view to each reader in each period. It is not a monument that monologically reveals its timeless essence. It is much more like an orchestration that strikes ever new resonances among its readers and frees the text from the material of the words and brings it to a contemporary existence (21).

Therefore, if we are to fully understand the process of reading, he argues, readers and their readings must be located in specific historical conditions of reading. The reading of a text is always mediated by what Jauss calls an 'horizon of expectations' (22).

> A literary work, even when it appears to be new, does not present itself as something absolutely new in an informational vacuum, but predisposes its audience to a very specific kind of reception by announcements, overt and covert signals, familiar characteristics, or implicit allusions. It awakens memories of that which was already read, brings the reader to a specific emotional attitude, and with its beginning arouses expectations for the 'middle and end', which can then be maintained intact or altered, reoriented, or even fulfilled ironically in the course of the reading according to specific rules of the genre or type of text (23).

In other words, texts are always read in the knowledge of other texts already read; information is already stored, and available for use, in the cultural storehouse of the reader.

So far the theories we have considered are all predicated on the notion that literary texts place clear limits on their possible interpretation. Iser, for example, describes his work as a theory of 'aesthetic response' and not a theory of 'aesthetic reception' (1978: x). The distinction he is concerned to make is between an approach which begins with the text and one which starts with the reader.

> A theory of reception . . . always deals with existing readers, whose reactions testify to certain historically conditioned experiences of literature. A theory of response has its roots in the text; a theory of reception arises from a history of readers' judgments (ibid.).

The next example to be discussed is the work of the American literary critic Stanley Fish. As we shall see, he very definitely begins with the reader.

## Interpretative communities

Literature, as Stanley Fish contends, 'is an open category, not definable by fictionality, or by a disregard of propositional truth, or by a prominence of tropes and figures, but simply by what we decide to put into it' (1980: 11). This does not mean that what counts as literature is determined by the subjective will of individual readers; the 'we' Fish refers to is the 'literary community'. As he explains,

> the act of recognising literature is not constrained by something in the text, nor does it issue from an independent and arbitrary will; rather, it proceeds from a collective decision that will be in force only so long as a community of readers or believers continues to abide by it (ibid.).

It follows from this, Fish contends, that 'there is no single way of reading that is correct or natural, only "ways of seeing" that are extensions of . . . [the] perspectives [of] interpretative communities'. (16). The literary community is thus divided into different interpretative communities, each with its own set of interests and concerns, and each seeking to win support for their own particular 'set of interpretative assumptions' (ibid.). Moreover, Fish insists that 'interpretation is the source of texts, facts, authors, and intentions'; all are 'the *products* of interpretation' (16–17).

Interpretative communities provide specific contexts for operating as a reader. In this way, the meaning of a text is always a situated meaning, produced in a specific context. As Fish contends, 'meanings are the property neither of fixed and stable texts nor of free and independent readers but of interpretative communities that are responsible both for the shape of a reader's activities and for the texts those activities produce' (322). Moreover, it is not possible for a text to have a meaning outside a specific situation. As Fish explains,

> communication occurs within situations and . . . to be in a situation is already to be in possession of (or to be possessed by) a structure of assumptions, of practices understood to be relevant in relation to purposes and goals that are already in place; and it is within the assumption of these purposes and goals that any utterance is immediately heard (318).[2]

Fish offers the example of what a group of poetry students were able to do with the names of four linguists and one literary critic, left on the blackboard from a previous class. When the poetry students entered the room, he told them that what they saw on the blackboard was a seventeenth-century English religious poem. Armed with this information, the poetry students proceeded to read, in a detailed and convincing manner, the five names on the blackboard as a seventeenth-century

English religious poem. What allowed them to do this, according to Fish, is the fact that

> It is not that the presence of poetic qualities compels a certain kind of attention [the 'common sense' of literary criticism] but that the paying of a certain kind of attention results in the emergence of poetic qualities. As soon as my students were aware that it was poetry they were seeing, they began to look with poetry-seeing eyes, that is, with eyes that saw everything in relation to the properties they knew poems to possess . . . Thus the meanings of the words and the interpretation in which those words were seen to be embedded emerged together, as a consequence of the operations my students began to perform once they were told that this was a poem (326).

The example of this episode leads Fish to the conclusion that it is not the properties of a text but the interpretative assumptions and strategies performed by readers, situated in interpretative communities, which determine the outcomes of interpretation. In this way, he argues, 'Interpretation is not the art of construing but the art of constructing. Interpreters do not decode poems; they make them' (327). The interpretative strategies of interpretative communities are always 'social and conventional' (331), therefore, as Fish explains,

> while it is true to say that we create poetry . . . we create it through interpretative strategies that are finally not our own but have their source in a publicly available system of intelligibility. Insofar as the . . . literary system . . . constrains us, it also fashions us, furnishing us with categories of understanding, with which we in turn fashion the entities to which we can then point (332).[3]

## Reading formations and paratextuality

Reading formations are, as Tony Bennett and Janet Woollacott explain,

> the product of definite social and ideological relations of reading composed, in the main, of those apparatuses – schools, the press, critical reviews, fanzines – within and between which the socially dominant forms for the superintendence of reading are both constructed and contested (1987: 64–5).[4]

Reading formations are not simply the range of other texts which come into play when one reads a specific text, but texts that carry with them institutional power, directing specific reading strategies, which seek to organize the conditions and relations of reading. What Bennett and Woollacott refer to as

> [the] specific determinations which bear in upon, mould and configure the relations between texts and readers in determinant conditions of reading. [That

> is,] the inter-textual relations which prevail in a particular context, thereby activating a given body of texts by ordering the relations between them in a specific way such that their reading is always-already cued in specific directions that are not given by those 'texts themselves' as entities separable from such relations (64).

In the politics of interpretation, as Bennett and Woollacott contend,

> Texts constitute sites around which the pre-eminently social affair of the struggle for meaning is conducted, principally in the form of a series of bids and counter-bids to determine which system of intertextual co-ordinates should be granted an effective social role of organizing reading practices (59–60).

Bennett and Woollacott reject the view that the texts of popular fiction are little more than containers of ideology, a convenient and always successful means to transmit dominant ideology from the culture industries to the duped and manipulated masses. The problem with such a view is that it leads to 'a politics of simple opposition and to a criticism which is little more than a constant unmasking of dominant ideologies at work' (4). Against this, they contend that popular fiction is a specific space, with its own ideological economy, making available a historically variable, complex and contradictory range of ideological discourses and counter-discourses to be activated in particular conditions of reading. While they accept that it may be possible to describe the Bond novels and films as racist, sexist and reactionary, to stop there is to fail to explore how these texts engage with a popular audience. That is, of course, 'Unless one subscribes to the view that the reading, cinema-going and television publics simply enjoy sexist, racist and reactionary texts' (ibid.). Rather than simply condemn these texts, Bennett and Woollacott seek to explore why and how they make their appeal.

In *Bond and Beyond*, Bennett and Woollacott track the diverse and changing ways in which the figure of James Bond has been produced and reproduced through a range of different texts and practices. Since his emergence in the 1950s the figure of Bond has, at different moments of his career as a popular hero, articulated (that is, expressed and been connected to) a series of ideological concerns. 'The ideological and cultural elements out of which the figure of Bond has been woven may have been constant, but these have been combined in different mixes and shifting permutations' (19). It is the ideological 'malleability' of the figure of Bond which has ensured his continuing popularity. As Bennett and Woollacott point out, 'it is not the popularity of Bond that has to be accounted for so much as the popularity of different Bonds, popular in different ways and for different reasons at different points in time' (20). They describe the figure of Bond as a 'mobile signifier' (42), and claim that the only thing that has remained constant throughout his career as a popular hero is the way in which he 'has functioned as a shifting focal point for the articulation of historically specific ideological concerns' (20).

A significant part of Bennett and Woollacott's discussion of Bond is taken up with the ways in which the films (and other 'texts of Bond' – see below) helped to organize and predispose 'readers to read the novels in certain ways, privileging some of their aspects at the expense of others' (43). At the centre of their argument is the claim that 'the conditions of Bond's existence have been *inter-textual*' (44). They use the hyphen to indicate the theoretical difference between their usage of the term and its usual employment (without the hyphen) within cultural studies to signify the way in which one text is marked by the signs of other texts. As Bennett and Woollacott make clear their employment of the term is quite different: 'we intend the concept inter-textuality to refer to the social organisation of the relations between texts within specific conditions of reading' (45). Moreover, they argue that

> the latter overrides and overdetermines the former. Intertextualities . . . are the product of specific, socially organised inter-textualities; it is the latter which, in providing the objective determinants of reading practices, provide the framework within which intertextual references can be produced and operate (86).

Thus, they argue,

> The figure of Bond has been produced in the constantly changing relations between the wide range of texts brought into association with one another via the functioning of Bond as the signifier which they have jointly constructed. In turn, it is this figure which, in floating between them, has thereby connected these texts into a related set in spite of their manifold differences in other aspects (45).

In other words, what unites these texts is not an author (even the novels are written by a number of authors), but the figure of Bond. It is Bond who 'furnishes the operative principle of textual classification' (52). Moreover, when Bond changes, 'such changes form a part of the social and cultural determination which influence the way the texts concerned are available to be read' (52–3). An objection to this argument might be to claim that the novels (as the original source of Bond) have a privileged status over the other 'texts of Bond'. Bennett and Woollacott claim that such an argument 'is impossible to maintain' (53).

> The 'texts of Bond' have comprised a constantly accumulating and 'mutating' set of texts, 'mutating' in the sense that additions to the set have connected with the pre-existing 'texts of Bond' in such a way as to reorganise kaleidoscopically the relationships, transactions and exchanges between them. None of the texts in which the figure of Bond has been constructed can thus be regarded as privileged in relation to the others in any absolute or permanent sense. Rather; each region of this textual set occupies a privileged position in relation to the others, but in different ways depending on the

> part it has played in the circulation and expanded reproduction of the figure of Bond (54).

Therefore, although Ian Fleming's novels came first and supplied much of the material for the films that followed, once the films were in circulation, it was the films which dominated imaginative constructions of the figure of Bond. Moreover, it was the films which produced the popular audience for the novels. But more than this, Bennett and Woollacott would insist, it was the films which provided the interpretative framework through which to read the novels. Once this is acknowledged, the rather one-way relationship (questions of difference and similarity, etc.) usually brought into play in discussions of film adaptations of novels begins to look unconvincing. As Bennett and Woollacott contend, the films 'have culturally activated the novels in particular ways, selectively cueing their reading, modifying the exchange between text and reader, inflecting it in new directions by inserting the novels within an expanded inter-textual set' (55). What makes this possible is the way in which reading is always a process in which

> the inter-textually organised reader meets the inter-textually organised text. The exchange is never a pure one between two unsullied entities, existing separately from one another, but is rather 'muddied' by the cultural debris which attach to both texts and readers in the determinate conditions which regulate the specific forms of their encounter (56).

Bennett and Woollacott reject both the view that the text determines its own reading (invites recognition of its objective properties) and the contrary view that it is the reader who produces the meaning of the text. They accuse both approaches of working with a 'metaphysical view of texts' (60), in that the first claims that the meaning of a text pre-exists its conditions of reading, while the second, although accepting the possibility of variable readings, nonetheless insists that these are variable readings of the same text. Against both of these positions, they argue for a rethinking of the text-reader relationship, in which texts are 'conceived as having no existence prior to or independently of the varying "reading formations" in which they have been constituted as objects-to-be-read' (64). In other words, a text only becomes a text when read, just as a reader only becomes a reader in the act of reading; neither can exist outside this relationship. This of course exposes Bennett and Woollacott to the accusation that they are claiming that readers and texts have no objective existence. But, as they explain,

> This is not to suggest that texts have no determinate properties – such as a definite order of narrative progression – which may be analysed objectively. But it is to argue that such properties cannot, in themselves, validate certain received meanings above others; they do not provide a point of 'truth' in relation to which readings may be normatively and hierarchically ranked, or discounted. Nor are we suggesting that readers do not have determinate

> properties. They most certainly do, but complexly varying ones which, rather than being attributable to the reader as a subject independent of the text, are the product of the orders of inter-textuality which have marked the reader's formation (65).

Regimes of inter-textuality organize how readers read texts. We never get access to texts 'in themselves', but always as situated within a network of inter-textual relations. In their approach to Bond, as they explain, they have 'stressed the degree to which these have always been variably produced – not as "the same text" but as different "texts-to-be-read" – as a result of their insertion within different regimes of inter-textuality' (260). In other words, text and context are not separate or separable moments available for analysis at different times. Text and context are always part of the same process, the same moment – they are inseparable: one cannot have a text without a context, or context without a text. Moreover, Bennett and Woollacott contend that all previous approaches to questions of meaning production have assumed that one can separate textual meaning from the meanings produced in actual acts of reading. The first supposedly approximates to the essential properties of the text (and can be determined without reference to factors outside the text); the second, influenced by extra-textual variables, may change through history and across cultures, but it is still a reading of (a variation on) the essential properties of the text (in other words, different readings of the same text). This is a mode of analysis which, despite its reference to the activities of readers, always ends up privileging the text. There is an objective structure and there is the endless flow of subjective responses. Drawing on the work of the French linguist Michel Pecheux, Bennett and Woollacott argue that meaning (or reading) cannot exist prior to its articulation by a reader. It cannot pre-exist the encounter between reader and text. This is not an attempt to reduce text to context, but an insistence that context and text cannot be conceived of as separate entities. As they explain,

> The concept of reading formation . . . is an attempt to think of contexts of reception as sets of discursive and inter-textual determinations which, in operating on both texts and readers, mediate the relations between them and provide the mechanisms through which they can productively interact (263).

Bennett and Woollacott offer the following summary of their contribution to the debate on reading as production,

> Much previous debate on the question of reading has deadlocked on the opposition between the view of the text as dictating its readings and the view that readers are able to mobilise cultural resources which enable them to read against the grain of the text or to negotiate its meanings in particular ways. Our purpose has been to displace the terms of this dispute by suggesting that neither approach takes sufficient account of the cultural and ideological forces which organise and reorganise the network of inter-textual relations within

> which texts are inserted as texts-to-be-read in certain ways by reading subjects organised to read in certain ways. The relations between texts and readers, we have suggested, are always profoundly mediated by the discursive and inter-textual determinations which, operating on both, structure the domain of their encounter so as to produce, always in specific and variable forms, texts and readers as the mutual supports of one another (249).

Another way to think about reading formations is as paratextuality. Paratexts establish forms of anticipation and expectations, guiding how we might come to interpretation. Gerard Genette (1997) uses the term to describe the texts that act as 'thresholds of interpretation' between, say, a literary novel and its reader. What he has in mind includes book covers, titles and subtitles, name and gender of author, prefaces, dedications, introductions, illustrations, reviews and interviews. He argues that these, and other paratexts, always come before our reading of a novel and 'mediate the book to the reader' (1997: xviii). But more than this, they build our expectations and begin to frame our interpretation.[5]

In other words, paratextuality is the name given to the other texts that surround a text. In the previous section Bennett and Woollacott referred to the 'other texts of Bond' and what they had in mind was academic criticism, showbiz journalism, fanzine articles, advertising copy and interviews with the actors and other filmmakers involved in the production of the Bond films. Although they do not use the term, this is what is meant by paratextuality. For example, before viewing the latest Bond film, *Spectre* (2015), we might encounter a whole range of accompanying texts – previews, advertisements, promotional campaigns, interviews with actors, writers and directors, posters and trailers. After we watch the film we may encounter a whole range of other texts: reviews, Internet discussion groups, merchandising, DVDs and CDs, fan materials, novels and computer games. The paratextual activity that we encounter may encourage us to watch the film or television programme, but it may also begin to shape how we will watch; that is, how we will make meaning and attribute value. Is it possible to watch, say, *Star Wars: The Force Awakens* (2015) without being aware of the many paratexts that surround it? But the more important question concerns the relationship between text and paratext. Jonathan Gray argues that

> Given their extended presence, any filmic or televisual text and its cultural impact, value and meaning cannot be adequately analysed without taking into account the film or program's many proliferations. Each proliferation, after all, holds the potential to change the meaning of the text, even if only slightly. Trailers and reports from the set, for instance, may construct early frames through which would-be viewers might think of the text's genre, tone, and themes (2010: 2).

In other words, paratexts do not just encourage us to watch a film of television programme, they help shape how we will watch it and make it meaningful.

By shaping our expectations such framing might encourage a particular focus on a certain aspect of the narrative or provide a new context for understanding the production as a whole. Given that it is rare that we encounter a text outside of such a framing, should we regard paratexts as more than the 'noise' that surrounds them? Gray argues that we should view them as part of the general textuality of the text. In other words, a text is made meaningful, as it exists in a network of paratextuality, which is fundamental to a text's context. Like a reading formation, paratextuality is a fundamental part of what we mean by context and is inseparable from our consumption of texts. Gray contends that 'paratexts are not simply add-ons, spinoffs, and also-rans: they create texts, they manage them, and they fill them with many of the meanings that we associate with them' (6). But Gray goes further than this in that he insists that to call a television programme or a film screened at the cinema a text and the texts that surround it paratexts is not to suggest an absolute distinction between the two. On the contrary, as he explains, 'I argue . . . that a film or program is but one part of a text, the text always being a contingent entity, either in the process of forming and transforming or vulnerable to further formation or transformation' (7).

My son loves Peppa Pig[6] and so he watches the television programmes over and over again. But increasingly he watches the show with and through a series of paratexts. These are drawn from an enormous range of possibilities, including membership of Peppa's Muddy Puddles Club, novelty eggs, shampoo and bubble bath, sticking plasters, comics, story books, ABC, 123, and colouring books, stickers, inflatable chairs, greetings cards, balloons, toothbrushes, painting easels, musical instruments, DVDs, bags, clothes, slippers and wellingtons, plates, bowls, cups and cutlery, toys and replica figures, wash mitts, edible cupcake toppers, bedding, theme park, drinks bottles, videogames, music, microphones, electronic games, jewellery, torches, wrapping paper, website, jigsaw puzzles, backpacks, handbags, sleeping bags, writing sets, paint-boxes, keyrings, dressing up costumes, charm bracelets, pencil cases, lunch boxes, luggage tags, fish tanks, bedroom lights, bunting, watches, headphones, laptops, play tents, playing cards, umbrellas, storage units, towels, cakes, food, including yoghurt, and tins of spaghetti and beans, and boardgames. My son is of course not aware of the full range of paratextuality that surrounds Peppa Pig, but it is difficult to believe that what he is aware of has not had an impact on how he understands, say, the television programme. The array of paratexts he does know may allow him to wander imaginatively in the world of Peppa Pig. His replica of Grandpa Pig's Train, for example, may enable him to enter and extend the narrative landscape of the story of the train as told on television. It might even be that the television story has become just another version, a starting point for his own stories of the train, Grandpa Pig, Peppa and George. Moreover, when he watches again the television version it may now be framed by his own dramatizations of the narrative possibilities of the train's adventures. It is often very difficult to know which is the primary text for a child. A child may love the books or the replica figures more than the television programme. The promise of paratextual study, similar to that of the use of reading formations, is that it enriches

our understanding of texts and their consumption and makes visible and material what we mean by context.

## Notes

1 As Karl Marx observed, 'Consumption produces production . . . because a product becomes a real product only by being consumed' (1973: 91). Terry Eagleton makes the similar point that 'Literary texts do not exist on bookshelves: they are processes of signification materialised only in the practice of reading. For literature to happen, the reader is quite as vital as the author' (1983: 74). A key figure in the promotion of the reader is Roland Barthes. He argues that a work is an object of production, whereas a text only comes into being in acts of consumption. Like de Certeau (see previous chapter), Barthes thinks of the consumption of a work as an act of production – it transforms the work into a text. In other words, what we bring to the work is as important as what the work makes available to us. It is this encounter between work and reader that produces the text. Crucial to this argument is the distinction Barthes makes between 'work' and the 'text': 'the work can be held in the hand, the text is held in language' and is 'experienced only in an activity of production' (Barthes 1977: 157). In other, when I buy Ursula Le Guin's *The Dispossessed* I carry from the shop a work, when I sit down to read the work it becomes a text as I begin to produce meaning from the words on the page. As Barthes explains, the transition from work to text is 'experienced only in an activity of production' (157).

2 Fish (1980) is aware that this opens him up to the dreaded accusation of relativism. This is a charge he strongly refutes, arguing that

> everyone is situated somewhere, there is no one for whom the absence of an a situational norm would be of any practical consequence . . . In other words, while relativism is a position one can entertain, it is not a position one can occupy. No one can be a relativist, because no one can achieve the distance from his own beliefs and assumptions which would result in their being no more authoritative for him than the beliefs and assumptions held by others, or, for that matter, the beliefs and assumptions he himself used to hold . . . The point is that there is never a moment when one believes nothing, when consciousness is innocent of any and all categories of thought, and whatever categories of thought are operative at a given moment will serve as an undoubted ground. (319–20)

3 Janice Radway argues that readers of romantic fiction also operate in an 'interpretative community'. How the women read this genre of fiction, she argues, is governed by 'reading strategies and interpretative conventions that the reader has learnt to apply as a member of a particular interpretative community' (1984: 11). For a discussion of Radway's work on romance readers see Storey 2015.

4 For other interesting work on reading formations, see Tony Bennett (1983), John Storey (1992 and 2010), John Tulloch (1995).

5 Literary criticism is itself paratextual. It has the powerful ability to guide how one reads a novel. Once I had read Pierre Macherey's *A Theory of Literary Production* I found it difficult to not read novels in terms of their contradictions (Macherey 1978; Storey 2015 and 2010). Similarly, once I had read Franco Moretti's (1983) account of *Dracula*, the novel was never quite the same again.

6 Peppa Pig is a very successful British animated television series aimed at children under five. It has been running for just over ten years and is broadcast in more than 150 countries around the world.



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# 5

# MEDIA CONSUMPTION

If we were looking for an example of media consumption it would be hard to find one more compelling than television. Of course some might say, 'Why use television as an example of media consumption? Surely it is an old technology?' One reason to use it is that its consumption is still extremely high (Miller 2010). Although there is a great deal of talk about how social media is replacing TV, Toby Miller has no doubt that 'television is becoming *more* popular, not less' (19). Justin Lewis argues that people are actually watching more television than ten years ago (2013: 66). Miller gives the example of advertising expenditure in the 2008 US Presidential Election: 'US$2.2 billion was spent on TV and less than half a billion on radio, newspapers, magazines, and the Internet combined' (15). Such expenditure was undoubtedly related to informed perceptions of patterns of media consumption.

Even if we think of television as an old media, it is one that seems to be working on the same side as new media. It is often claimed that the Internet has swept television aside. While it is true that the Internet has damaged sales of CDs and newspapers, its impact on television is more complicated. According to Miller, 'The early signs are that the Internet and TV will transform one another' (2010: 12). Jonathan Gray and Amanda D. Lotz make much the same point: 'Television is neither "beating" nor "losing" to new media in some cosmic clash of technology; rather, television is an intrinsic part of "new" media' (2012: 3).

What is extraordinary about television is how ordinary it has become. For something less than 100 years old, its ubiquity is quite amazing. To say it is part of the fabric of our everyday lives is to state the obvious. Every important event is now a television event. For example, according to Reuters one billion people watched the 2014 World Cup Final on TV.[1]

In this chapter I critically assess two absolutely classic accounts of media consumption that continue to echo through all attempts to think seriously about what it means to consume television. It is not important that they are writing about an old US primetime soap, it is in their methodology and theoretical framing that their continued powerful relevance exists. The first is Ien Ang's *Watching Dallas* (1985) and the second is Tamar Liebes and Elihu Katz's *The Export of Meaning: Cross-cultural Readings of Dallas* (1993). It is difficult to overestimate the influence of these two studies. The chapter begins with a discussion of the foundations of the cultural studies approach to the consumption of media texts – the early work of Stuart Hall and David Morley.

## The encoding/decoding model

The publication of Stuart Hall's 'Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse' (first published in 1973) is perhaps the moment when cultural studies finally emerges from left-Leavisism, 'pessimistic' versions of Marxism, American mass communication models, culturalism and structuralism, and begins to take on a recognizable form of its own. In Hall's model of televisual communication (see Figure 5.1), the circulation of 'meaning' in televisual discourse passes through three distinctive moments: 'each has its specific modality and conditions of existence' (Hall 1980: 128). First, media professionals put into meaningful televisual discourse their particular account of, for example, a 'raw' social event. At this moment in the circuit, a range of ways of looking at the world are 'in dominance'. This is the moment of encoding, when the media professionals involved determine how the 'raw' social event will be encoded in discourse. In the second moment, once the meanings are encoded in meaningful discourse, that is, once they have taken televisual form, the formal rules of language and television are now 'in dominance'. Finally, in the third moment, the moment of audience decoding, another range of ways of looking at the world are 'in dominance'. The audience is confronted not by a 'raw' social event, but by a discursive translation of the event. If the event is to become 'meaningful' to the audience, it must now decode and make sense of this discourse.

As Hall explains, 'If no "meaning" is taken, there can be no "consumption". If the meaning is not articulated in practice, it has no effect' (ibid.). If an audience acts upon its decoding, this then itself becomes a social practice, a 'raw' social event, available to be encoded in another discourse. Thus, through the circulation of discourse, 'production' becomes 'consumption' to become 'production' again. The circuit starts in the 'social' and ends, to begin again, in the 'social'. In other words, meanings are not simply 'transmitted', they are always produced: first by the encoder from the 'raw' material of everyday life; and then, second, by an audience situated in relation to other discourses. Each moment is 'determinate', operating in its own conditions of production and consumption. Moreover, as Hall makes clear, the moments of encoding and decoding may not be perfectly symmetrical. There is nothing inevitable about the outcome of the process – what is intended and what

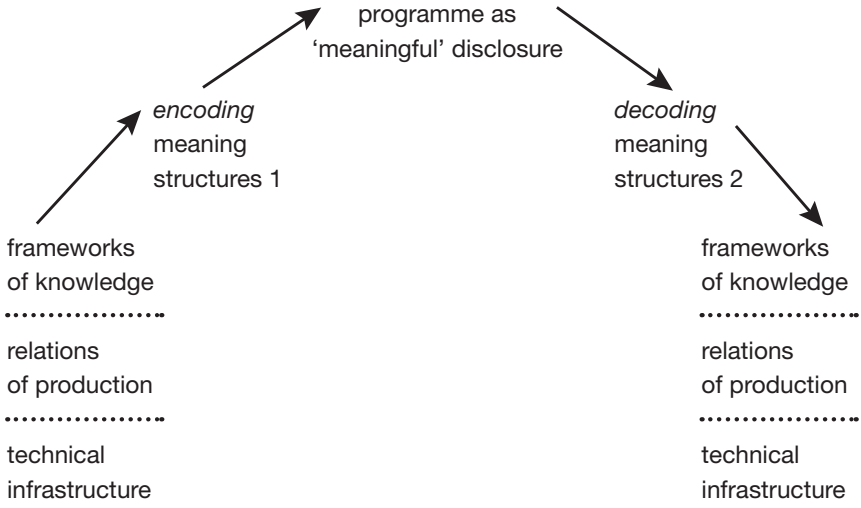



**FIGURE 5.1** Televisual communication.
Source: Hall (1980: 130).

is taken may not coincide. Media professionals may wish decoding to correspond with encoding, but they cannot prescribe or guarantee this. Governed by different conditions of existence, encoding and decoding are open to variable reciprocity. This may be simply the result of misunderstanding. Hall acknowledges this, but he is more interested in more deliberate strategies of understanding. Drawing on the work of sociologist Frank Parkin (1971), Hall develops 'three hypothetical positions from which decodings of a televisual discourse may be constructed' (Hall 1980: 136). The first position is 'the dominant-hegemonic position'. This position is occupied

> [w]hen the viewer takes the connoted meaning from, say, a television newscast or current affairs programme full and straight, and decodes the message in terms of the reference code in which it has been encoded, we might say that the viewer is operating inside the dominant code (ibid.).

To decode a television discourse in this way is to decode in harmony with the 'professional code' of the broadcasters. The dominant code is always articulated through the professional code. As Hall explains,

> The professional code is 'relatively independent' of the dominant code, in that it applies criteria and transformational operations of its own, especially those of a technico-practical nature. The professional code, however, operates *within* the 'hegemony' of the dominant code. Indeed, it serves to reproduce

> the dominant definitions precisely by bracketing their hegemonic quality and operating instead with displaced professional codings which foreground such apparently neutral-technical questions as visual quality, news and presentational values, televisual quality, 'professionalism' and so on (ibid.).

The second decoding position is 'the negotiated code' (137). Hall regards this as the position most likely to be adopted by the majority of viewers. Decoding from this position always involves 'a mixture of adaptive and oppositional elements' (ibid), in which the televisual discourse is negotiated through and in terms of the situated conditions of the viewer. An example of the negotiated code might be a viewer of *Benefits Street* (2014)[2] who agrees in general terms with the programme's assumptions about people on benefits but insists her unemployed father is very different. The third decoding position identified by Hall is 'the oppositional code'. This is the position occupied by the viewer who recognizes the preferred code of the televisual discourse but who none the less chooses to decode within an alternative frame of reference. This would be the case of a viewer of *Benefits Street* who sees it as an example of 'poverty porn' produced from a particular class perspective.

As Hall readily acknowledged, this hypothetical model would 'need to be empirically tested and refined' (136). David Morley's *Nationwide*[3] study was in part set up to test Hall's model, to see how individual interpretations of televisual texts relate to socio-cultural background. To accomplish this Morley arranged for 29 different groups of people to view two episodes (from 1976 and 1977) of the BBC's early evening news and current affairs programme. The first programme was shown to 18 groups, the second to 11. Each group consisted of between five and 10 people. The groups were selected on the grounds that they might be expected to differ in their decodings from 'dominant' to 'negotiated' to 'oppositional'.

Much of what Morley found seemed to confirm Hall's model. For example, a group of university arts students and a group of teacher training college students produced readings which moved between 'negotiated' and 'dominant', while a group of shop stewards produced an 'oppositional reading'.[4] However, when both the middle-class bank managers and the working-class apprentices produced the same dominant readings, the correlation between class and reading position looked less secure, forcing Morley to acknowledge that decodings are not determined 'directly from social class position' (Morley 1980: 134). Rather, as he reformulates it: 'it is always a question of how social position plus particular discourse positions produce specific readings; readings which are structured because the structure of access to different discourses is determined by social position' (ibid.). In this way, Morley is able to explain the similarity in decodings between the working-class apprentices and the middle-class bank managers in terms of the formulation: determination of class plus other discourses (bodies of ideas and shared socio-cultural practices which help constitute us as social subjects and thus shape how we see and think about the world). Thus when we are 'interpellated' by a text, this is always in a context of other interpellations (for discussion of this term, see Althusser

2013 and Storey 2015). The text-reader encounter does not occur in a moment isolated from other discourses, but always in a field of many discourses, some in harmony with the text, some which are in contradiction with it. One reads, for example, as a student, a Catholic, a socialist and a member of a youth subculture. Each discourse may pull how we read in a different direction. Each may assume a different level of importance in any given social context. The response of the black further education students and other predominantly black groups to *Nationwide* – their 'critique of silence' – is therefore not to be explained as a failure of communication (the technical inability of the encoders to get their 'message' across). Rather, what it demonstrates is the discourses of the text coming into conflict with the discourses of the reader. 'Here,' as Morley explains, 'the action of the cultures and discourses which these groups are involved in acts to block or inflect their interpellation by the discourse of *Nationwide*' (143). The reverse is also evident in the decodings made by the working-class apprentices. 'Here it is not simply a case of the absence of "contradictory" discourses; rather it is the presence of other discourses which work in parallel with those of the programme – enabling these groups to produce "corresponding" representations' (ibid.). In the process of decoding, other discourses (both supporting and contradicting) are always in play, 'although their action is more visible when it is a case of negative-contradictory rather than positive-reinforcing effect' (144).

Despite the impact of these other determinations (these other discourses), Morley still concludes that a person's social-class position is an important determinant of which decoding position a person is likely to occupy. Social class is still important because it determines access (or the nature of access) to different discourses. As he explains, 'the subject's position in the social formation structures his or her range of access to various discourses and ideological codes' (158). This then may explain the correlation between the readings made by the middle-class bank managers and the working-class apprentices. The bank managers produced a dominant reading because of their political commitment to the conservatism of *Nationwide*'s discourse, while the apprentices accepted the conservatism uncritically because of a lack (unlike the shop stewards) of an alternative political discourse. Class, he contends, is the key to both readings. The bank managers decoded on the basis of 'class interest' while the apprentices' decoding can be explained in terms of the 'class interest' of the British educational system (the working-class apprentices were schooled to be politically uncritical).

In the Afterword to *The 'Nationwide' Audience*, Morley sums up (rather too modestly, in my opinion) the achievements of his research:

> I have been able to do no more than to indicate some of the ways in which social position and (sub)cultural frameworks may be related to individual readings. To claim more than that, on the basis of such a small sample, would be misleading. Similarly, I would claim only to have shown the viability of an approach which treats the audience as a set of cultural groupings rather than as a mass of individuals or as a set of rigid socio-demographic categories.

> Clearly, more work needs to be done on the relation between group and individual readings (163).

The early work of Hall and Morley is absolutely fundamental to the development of cultural studies, and to the ongoing project of cultural studies more generally. Hall and Morley laid the foundations, by both example and provocation, of a way to understand consumption as a structured and situated practice.

## *Watching Dallas*

In Ien Ang's now classic study, *Watching Dallas* (first published in the Netherlands in 1982), her starting point is an attempt to understand the success of *Dallas* in the Netherlands, where it was regularly watched by 52 per cent of the population. It is in this context that she placed the following advertisement in *Viva*, a Dutch women's magazine:

> I like watching the TV serial *Dallas*, but often get odd reactions to it. Would anyone like to write and tell me why you like watching it too, or dislike it? I should like to assimilate these reactions in my university thesis. Please write to . . . (Ang, 1985: 10).

Following the advertisement she received 42 letters (39 from women or girls), from both lovers and haters of *Dallas*. These form the empirical basis of her study of the pleasure(s) of watching *Dallas* for its predominantly female audience. She is concerned not with pleasure understood as the satisfaction of a pre-existent need, but with 'the mechanisms by which pleasure is aroused' (9). Instead of the question 'What are the effects of pleasure?' she poses the question 'What is the mechanism of pleasure; how is it produced and how does it work?'

Ang writes as 'an intellectual and a feminist', but also as someone who has 'always particularly liked watching soap operas like *Dallas*' (12).

> The admission of the reality of this pleasure [my own] . . . formed the starting point for this study. I wanted in the first place to understand this pleasure, without having to pass judgment on whether *Dallas* is good or bad, from a political, social or aesthetic view. Quite the contrary; in my opinion it is important to emphasise how difficult it is to make such judgments – and hence to try to formulate the terms for a progressive cultural politics – when pleasure is at stake (ibid.).

For Ang's letter writers the pleasures or displeasures of *Dallas* are inextricably linked with questions of 'realism'. The extent to which a letter writer finds the programme 'good' or 'bad' is determined by whether they find it 'realistic' (good) or 'unrealistic' (bad). Critical of both 'empiricist realism' (a text is considered realistic to the extent to which it adequately reflects that which exists outside itself) (34–8)

and 'classic realism' (the claim that realism is an illusion created by the extent to which a text can successfully conceal its constructedness) (38–41), she contends that *Dallas* is best understood as an example of what she calls 'emotional realism' (41–7). She connects this to the way in which *Dalla*s can be read on two levels: the level of denotation and the level of connotation (see discussion of Roland Barthes in Chapter 2 of this volume and in Storey 2015). The level of denotation refers to the literal content of the programme, general storyline, character interactions, etc. The level of connotation(s) refers to the associations and implications that resonate from the storyline and character interactions, etc.

> It is striking; the same things, people, relations and situations which are regarded at the denotative level as unrealistic, and unreal, are at the connotative level apparently not seen at all as unreal, but in fact as 'recognisable'. Clearly, in the connotative reading process the denotative level of the text is put in brackets (42).

Viewing *Dallas*, like watching any other programme, is a selective process, reading across the text from denotation to connotation, weaving our sense of self in and out of the narrative. As one letter writer says:

> Do you know why I like watching it? I think it's because those problems and intrigues, the big and little pleasures and troubles occur in our own lives too . . . In real life I know a horror like JR, but he's just an ordinary builder (43).

It is this ability to make our own lives connect with the lives of a family of Texan millionaires that gives the programme its emotional realism. We may not be rich, but we may have other fundamental things in common: relationships and broken relationships, happiness and sadness, illness and health. Those who find it realistic shift the focus of attention from the particularity of the narrative ('denotation') to the generality of its themes ('connotation').

Ang uses the term a 'tragic structure of feeling' (46) to describe the way in which *Dallas* plays with the emotions in an endless musical chairs of happiness and misery. As one letter writer told her: 'Sometimes I really enjoy having a good cry with them. And why not? In this way my other bottled-up emotions find an outlet' (49). Viewers who 'escape' in this way are not so much engaging in

> a denial of reality as playing with it . . . [in a] game that enables one to place the limits of the fictional and the real under discussion, to make them fluid. And in that game an imaginary participation in the fictional world is experienced as pleasurable (ibid.).

Whatever else is involved, part of the pleasure of *Dallas* is quite clearly connected to the amount of fluidity viewers are able or willing to establish between its fictional

world and the world of their day-to-day existence. In order to activate *Dallas*'s tragic structure of feeling the viewer must have the necessary cultural capital to occupy a 'reading formation' (see Chapter 4 in this volume) informed by what she calls, following Peter Brooks (1976), the 'melodramatic imagination'. The melodramatic imagination is the articulation of a way of seeing that finds in ordinary day-to-day existence, with its pain and triumphs, its victories and defeats, a world that is as profoundly meaningful and significant as the world of classical tragedy. In a world mostly cut loose from the certainties of religion, the melodramatic imagination offers a means of organizing reality into meaningful contrasts and conflicts. As a narrative form committed to melodrama's emphatic contrasts, conflicts and emotional excess, *Dallas* is well placed to give sustenance to, and make manifest, the melodramatic imagination. For those who see the world in this way (Ang claims that it demands a cultural competence most often shared by women), 'the pleasure of *Dallas* . . . is not a compensation for the presumed drabness of daily life, nor a flight from it, but a dimension of it' (Ang, 1985: 83). The melodramatic imagination activates *Dallas*'s tragic structure of feeling, which in turn produces the pleasure of emotional realism. However, because the melodramatic imagination is an effect of a specific reading formation, it follows that not all viewers of *Dallas* will activate the text in this way.

A key concept in Ang's analysis is what she calls 'the ideology of mass culture' (15). The ideology articulates the view that popular culture is the product of capitalist commodity production and is therefore subject to the laws of the capitalist market economy; the result of which is the seemingly endless circulation of degraded commodities, whose only real significance is that they manipulate consumers and make a profit for their producers. She quite rightly sees this as a distorted and one-sided version of Marx's analysis of capitalist commodity production, in that it allows 'exchange value' to completely mask 'use value' (see discussion in Chapter 8 of this volume). Against this, she insists, as would Marx, that it is not possible to read off how a product might be consumed from the means by which it was produced. The ideology of mass culture, like other ideological discourses, seeks to interpellate individuals into specific subject positions (Louis Althusser 2013 and discussion in Storey 2015). The letters suggest four positions from which to consume *Dallas*: (i) those who hate the programme; (ii) ironical viewers; (iii) fans and (iv) populists.

Those letter writers who claim to hate *Dallas* draw most clearly on the ideology. They use it in two ways. The programme is identified first negatively as an example of mass culture; second, as a means to account for and support their dislike of the programme. As Ang puts it, 'their reasoning boils down to this: "*Dallas* is obviously bad because it's mass culture, and that's why I dislike it" ' (95–6). In this way, the ideology both comforts and reassures: 'it makes a search for more detailed and personal explanations superfluous, because it provides a finished explanatory model that convinces, sounds logical and radiates legitimacy' (96). This is not to say that it is wrong to dislike *Dallas*, only that professions of dislike are often made with a confidence born of uncritical thought.

Viewers who occupy the second position demonstrate how it is possible to like *Dallas* and still subscribe to the ideology of mass culture. The contradiction is resolved by 'mockery and irony' (97). *Dallas* is subjected to an ironizing and mocking commentary in which it 'is transformed from a seriously intended melodrama to the reverse: a comedy to be laughed at. Ironizing viewers therefore do not take the text as it presents itself, but invert its preferred meaning through ironic commentary' (98). From this position the pleasure of *Dallas* derives from the fact that it is bad – pleasure and bad mass culture are reconciled in an instant. As one of the letter writers puts it: 'Of course *Dallas* is mass culture and therefore bad, but precisely because I am so well aware of that I can really enjoy watching it and poke fun at it' (100). For both the ironizing viewer and the hater of *Dallas*, the ideology of mass culture operates as a bedrock of common sense, making judgements obvious and self-evident. Although both operate within the normative standards of the ideology, the difference between them is marked by the question of pleasure. On the one hand, the ironizers can have pleasure without guilt, in the sure and declared knowledge that they know mass culture is bad. On the other hand, the haters, although secure in the same knowledge, can, nevertheless, suffer 'a conflict of feelings if, *in spite of this*, they cannot escape its seduction' (101; original emphasis).

Third, there are the fans, those who love *Dallas*. For the viewers who occupy the previous two positions, to actually like *Dallas* without resort to irony is to be identified as someone duped by mass culture. As one letter writer puts it: 'The aim is simply to rake in money, lots of money. And people try to do that by means of all these things – sex, beautiful people, wealth. And you always have people who fall for it' (103). The claim is presented with all the confidence of having the full weight of the ideology's discursive support. Ang analyses the different strategies that those who love *Dallas* must use to deal consciously and unconsciously with such condescension. The first strategy is to 'internalize' the ideology; to acknowledge the 'dangers' of *Dallas*, but to declare one's ability to deal with them in order to derive pleasure from the programme. A second strategy used by fans is to confront the ideology of mass culture as one letter writer does: 'Many people find it worthless or without substance. But I think it does have substance' (105). But, as Ang points out, the writer remains firmly within the discursive constraints of the ideology as she attempts to relocate *Dallas* in a different relationship to the binary oppositions – with substance/without substance, good/bad. 'This letter writer "negotiates" as it were within the discursive space created by the ideology of mass culture, she does not situate herself outside it and does not speak from an opposing ideological position' (106). A third strategy of defence deployed by fans against the normative standards of the ideology of mass culture is to use irony. These fans are different from Ang's second category of viewer, the ironist, in that the strategy involves the use of 'surface irony' to justify what is in all other respects a form of non-ironic pleasure. Irony is used to condemn the characters as 'horrible' people, while at the same time demonstrating an intimate knowledge of the programme and a great involvement in its narrative development and character interactions.

The letter writer who uses this strategy is caught between the dismissive power of the ideology and the pleasure she obviously derives from watching *Dallas*. Her letter seems to suggest that she adheres to the former when viewing with friends, and to the latter when viewing alone (and perhaps secretly when viewing with friends). As Ang explains: 'irony is here a defence mechanism with which this letter writer tries to fulfil the social norms set by the ideology of mass culture, while secretly she "really" likes *Dallas*' (109).

As Ang shows, the fans of *Dallas* find it necessary to locate their pleasure in relation to the ideology of mass culture; they 'internalize' the ideology; they 'negotiate' with the ideology; they use 'surface irony' to defend their pleasure against the withering dismissal of the ideology. What all these strategies of defence reveal is that 'there is no clear-cut ideological alternative which can be employed against the ideology of mass culture – at least no alternative that offsets the latter in power of conviction and coherence' (109–10). The struggle therefore, as so far described, between those who like *Dallas* and those who dislike it, is an unequal struggle between those who argue from within the discursive strength and security of the ideology of mass culture, and those who resist from within (for them) its inhospitable confines. 'In short, these fans do not seem to be able to take up an effective ideological position – an identity – from which they can say in a positive way and independently of the ideology of mass culture: "I like *Dallas* because . . ."' (ibid.).

The final viewing position revealed in the letters, one that might help these fans, is a position informed by the ideology of populism. At the core of this ideology is the belief that one person's taste is of equal value to another person's taste. As one letter writer puts it: 'I find the people who react oddly rather ludicrous – they can't do anything about someone's taste. And anyway they might find things pleasant that you just can't stand seeing or listening to' (113). The ideology of populism insists that as taste is an autonomous category, continually open to individual inflection, it is absolutely meaningless to pass aesthetic judgements on other people's preferences. Given that this would seem to be an ideal discourse from which to defend one's pleasure in *Dallas*, why do so few of the letter writers adopt it? Ang's answer is to point to the ideology's extremely limited critical vocabulary. After one has repeated 'there's no accounting for taste' a few times, the argument begins to appear somewhat bankrupt. Compared to this, the ideology of mass culture has an extensive and elaborate range of arguments and theories. Little wonder, then, that when invited to explain why they like or dislike *Dallas*, the letter writers find it difficult to escape the normative discourse of the ideology of mass culture.

However, according to Ang, there are ways to escape: it is the very 'theoretical' nature of the discourse which restricts its influence 'to people's opinions and rational consciousness, to the discourse people use when talking about culture. These opinions and rationalizations need not, however, necessarily prescribe people's cultural practices' (115). This would in part explain the contradictions experienced by some letter writers: confronted by both 'the intellectual dominance of the ideology of mass culture and the "spontaneous", practical attraction of the populist

ideology' (ibid.). The difficulty with adopting the populist ideology for a radical politics of popular culture is that it has already been appropriated by the culture industries for its own purposes of profit maximization. However, drawing on the work of Bourdieu, Ang argues that populism is related to the 'popular aesthetic' (see Chapter 3 in this volume), in which the moral categories of middle-class taste are replaced by an emphasis on contingency, on pluralism and, above all, on pleasure. Pleasure, for Ang, is the key term in a transformed feminist cultural politics. Feminism must break with 'the paternalism of the ideology of mass culture . . . [in which w]omen are . . . seen as the passive victims of the deceptive messages of soap operas . . . [their] pleasure . . . totally disregarded' (118–19). Even when pleasure is considered, it is there only to be condemned as an obstruction to the feminist goal of women's liberation. The question Ang poses is can pleasure through identification with the women of 'women's weepies' or the emotionally masochistic women of soap operas 'have a meaning for women which is relatively independent of their political attitudes'? (133). Her answer is yes: fantasy and fiction do not

> function in place of, but beside, other dimensions of life (social practice, moral or political consciousness). It . . . is a source of pleasure because it puts 'reality' in parenthesis, because it constructs imaginary solutions for real contradictions which in their fictional simplicity and their simple fictionality step outside the tedious complexity of the existing social relations of dominance and subordination (135).

Of course this does not mean that representations of women do not matter. They can still be condemned for being reactionary in an ongoing cultural politics. But to experience pleasure from them is a completely different issue: 'it need not imply that we are also bound to take up these positions and solutions in our relations to our loved ones and friends, our work, our political ideals, and so on' (ibid.).

> Fiction and fantasy, then, function by making life in the present pleasurable, or at least livable, but this does not by any means exclude radical political activity or consciousness. It does not follow that feminists must not persevere in trying to produce new fantasies and fight for a place for them . . . It does, however, mean that, where cultural consumption is concerned, no fixed standard exists for gauging the 'progressiveness' of a fantasy. The personal may be political, but the personal and the political do not always go hand in hand (135–6).

Ang's position complicates what we might think of as the politics of consumption.

## *Dallas* and cultural imperialism

*Dallas* is also the subject of a research project carried out by, Tamar Liebes and Elihu Katz. Their starting point is very different from Ang's; their research begins

with the concept of cultural imperialism, and with a question this perspective prompts; that is whether or not television programmes, made in the United States, but successful worldwide, like *Dallas*, are more than just cultural commodities for sale in the global marketplace, 'but also agents [for the] subversion of indigenous values' (1993: viii). In other words, the question they set out to answer is, is *Dallas* and programmes like it the very substance of cultural imperialism? It is perhaps worth noting at the outset that Liebes and Katz are not convinced by the cultural-imperialism thesis. As they contend,

> To prove that *Dallas* is an imperialistic imposition, one would have to show (1) that there is a message incorporated in the program that is designed to profit American interests overseas, (2) that the message is decoded by the receiver in the way it was encoded by the sender, and (3) that it is accepted uncritically by the viewers and allowed to seep into their culture . . .
>
> Whatever the message in the text – if there is one – our interest is in what message reaches the viewers. We argue that ideology is not produced through a process of stimulus and response but rather through a process of negotiation between various types of senders and receivers. To understand the messages perceived by viewers of a television program, one cannot be satisfied with abstract generalizations derived from content analysis, however sophisticated. The actual interaction between the program and its viewers must be studied. In the case of *Dallas*, the challenge is to observe how the melodrama of a fictional family in Texas is viewed, interpreted and discussed by real families throughout the world, in the light of the drama of their own lives and those of the fictional and real others whom they have come to know through symbolic culture and actual community. (4)

To fathom the cultural and political influence of *Dallas*, they decided to observe and to study the reception of *Dallas* in a number of Israeli homes. Rather than focus on Israelis in general, and in order to see the extent to which 'different ethnicities might "use" . . . *Dallas* to explore and redefine their own identities and to compare themselves not just with Americans but with other Israelis' (viii), they chose four cultural groups: veteran kibbutz members of Western origin, new immigrants from Russia, Israeli Arabs and Moroccan Jews. For further comparison, they also included in their study American viewers in Los Angeles, part of the programme's original audience, and Japanese viewers in Tokyo, one of the few places where *Dallas* failed. From their Israeli sample they constructed 44 small groups of family and friends. Added to this were ten American groups and 11 Japanese.

When asked to retell an episode from *Dallas*,

> some groups chose to represent the story more sociologically, as if it were the story of a linear progress through a social obstacle course. Other groups retold the story more psychologically, emphasizing the motivations and

> personalities of the characters, while yet others retold the story in terms of themes and leitmotifs (152).

When questioned about particular details in the narrative of an episode, some groups (for example, Moroccan Jews and Israeli Arabs) employed a referential frame (reading the programme in relation to their own lives) to explain what had happened in terms of 'real life'. Other groups, the American and kibbutz groups, for example, used a critical frame (reading the text as text) and explained what had happened in terms of genre.

One significant difference between the different groups concerned the framing discourse chosen to interpret the programme. For the Americans, kibbutzniks and Japanese, the framing discourse was aesthetic; for the Moroccan Jews it was moral; and for the Russians immigrants it was ideological. For example, one Russian respondent described *Dallas* as 'propaganda for the American way of life' (76). On the other hand, an Israeli Arab condemned in more general terms the life the programme supposedly depicts: 'When materialism dominates, society falls apart, and the material begins to be everything' (88). One Japanese viewer had difficulty taking the programme seriously because of the way in which it violated his sense of social realism: 'it is hard for me to believe that such a marriage between Bobby and the girl, which is typical to the middle class, happens in high society' (134).

The conclusion Liebes and Katz draw from their study, echoing Hall's encoding/decoding model, is that a programme like *Dallas* 'may beam a homogeneous message to the global village, but our study argues that there is pluralism in the decoding' (152). In other words, although the different groups offered distinct ways in which to understand *Dallas*, they can all be seen to clearly relate to the 'content' of the programme – the programme is the same for all the groups; what is different, and inflects how *Dallas* is understood, is the cultural mode of understanding that each different group brings to their involvement with the programme. What Liebes and Katz also demonstrate quite clearly are the obvious deficiencies with cultural imperialism as a mode of analysis. It operates with an impoverished concept of culture; it has a reductive notion of the foreign, and it assumes a monolithic understanding of the culture supposedly being 'imposed'.[5]

## Notes

1 http://uk.reuters.com/article/uk-soccer-world-television-idUKKBN0TZ21Y20151216 (accessed 8th January 2016).

2 *Benefits Street* is a British documentary series, set in Birmingham, UK, and first broadcast on Channel 4 in January 2014. It ran for five episodes.

3 *Nationwide* was a BBC news and current affairs programme that ran from 1969 to 1983.

4 Richard Dyer (1977) notes an interesting problem with the way the model seems to always assume that encoding will be from a dominant or hegemonic position. What happens to the clarity of the model when the encoded 'message' is 'radical' or 'progressive'? See Morley (1992) for a response to this and other problems and criticisms.

5 See Storey 2010 for a critique of the 'Americanization' version of the argument.



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# 6

# NON-MEDIA-CENTRIC MEDIA CONSUMPTION

In this chapter I will consider a number of approaches to media consumption that, in contrast to the work discussed in the previous chapter, does not begin with a media text or practice; rather they begin with the everyday and then attempt to tease out how this is enabled and constrained by media use. The work discussed here either follows or presents a pre-history of a position advocated by David Morley in which he calls for a non-media-centric study of the media. As Morley points out,

> [W]e need to 'decentre' the media . . . so as to better understand the ways in which media processes and everyday life are interwoven with each other. . . . The key issue here, to put it paradoxically, is how we can generate a non-media-centric form of media studies, how to understand the variety of ways in which new and old media accommodate to each other and coexist in symbiotic forms and also how to better grasp how we live with them as parts of our personal or household 'media ensemble' (2007: 200).

Although we increasingly watch television on a range of different platforms (smart phone, computer, VCR) and in a series of different places (hotel rooms, the pub, shops, on airplanes), for most people the usual experience of television is the home, where it is watched to relax after work or to fill time if unemployed, to entertain children, to avoid talking to others or as subject matter for conversations. There is a television programme I watch every Sunday morning called *The Big Question* (BBC1). Each week it always seems to feature someone with views I find absolutely abhorrent. As a consequence I often find myself remonstrating with the television. If I am watching it with someone else I often involve him or her in my disagreements with what is being said. Does such behaviour make me a little weird or does it tell us something about the ways in which media and everyday lives are interwoven with each other?

The chapter discusses work by Dorothy Hobson, David Morley, Hermann Bausinger, Mary Ellen Brown and Helen Wood. Again, the work I discuss is selected for its contribution to theoretical and methodological considerations of consumption.

## Television talk

In the introduction to *Crossroads: The Drama of a Soap Opera*, Dorothy Hobson observes

> it is only by long and relaxed talks and viewing with the audience that any understanding of how people watch television can be achieved. The effort is well worthwhile for it reveals the important contribution which viewers make to any television programme which they watch (1982: 12).

Hobson's account of the consumption of the British soap opera *Crossroads* forms only a small part of her study of the production of the programme. Nevertheless, her observations have a formative place in the development of 'ethnographic' work in (British) cultural studies. Hobson conducted a series of unstructured interviews with viewers of the programme, mostly women, after watching episodes with them in their homes. As she explains, 'It is important to stress that the interviews were unstructured because I wanted the viewers to determine what was interesting or what they noticed, or liked or disliked about the programme and specifically about the episode which we had watched' (105).

Although her book does not seek to articulate a precise theoretical position, the research which informs it is nonetheless structured by clear, underlying assumptions about the productive work of audiences. As she explains,

> Different people watch television programmes for different reasons, and make different 'readings' of those programmes, and much of what they say is determined by preconceived ideas and opinions which they bring to a programme. The message is not solely in the 'text' but can be changed or 'worked on' by the audience as they make their own interpretation of a programme (105–6).

Watching *Crossroads* with its audience allowed Hobson to understand the extent to which 'Watching television is part of the everyday life of viewers. It is not, as is sometimes suggested, a separate activity undertaken in perfect quiet in comfortable surroundings' (110). Television is usually watched in the midst of other everyday activities. As Hobson discovered, domestic routines and responsibilities and the expectations of other family members ensured that many of the women with whom she watched *Crossroads* were not allowed the luxury of the detailed concentration expected and enjoyed by staff and students watching in darkened rooms on media studies courses. As she quickly was made aware, domestic circumstances impact on both the level of concentration with which, and the perspective from which,

a programme is viewed. As she explains, 'To watch a programme at meal time with the mother of young children is an entirely different experience from watching with a seventy-two-year-old widow whose day is largely structured around television programmes' (111).

Meaning is not, as Hobson discovered, something which happens only once, in the first moment of consumption as one sits in front of the television screen. The making of meaning is an ongoing process which may reach well beyond the first moment of consumption. New contexts will bring about the enactment of new significances; a narrative seemingly discarded seems suddenly to have a new relevance and a new utility. Travelling on a train back from London, Hobson discovered how viewers can integrate and reintegrate the world of soap opera, for example, into their own lives: playing a 'fantastical' game in which the fictional and the real are allowed to merge. She recounts how she overheard, during the course of that train journey, a conversation between four pensioners in which they talked about their respective children and grandchildren, and then without comment, the conversation switched to a discussion about the current problems of a character in the British soap opera *Coronation Street* (125). She listened as the four women discussed recent happenings in the soap opera and interwove these with a discussion of recent narratives in their own family lives; family narratives then in turn provoked further discussion of soap opera narratives; soap-opera narratives then provoked more discussion of family narratives. And so it went on.[1]

Hobson's research also reveals the extent to which viewers use their own experience to measure and judge the events happening in television programmes like *Crossroads*. On the basis of these findings, she dismisses as 'invalid' the common claim that the appeal of soap opera is escapism. Soap operas, she maintains, 'are precisely a way of understanding and coping with problems which are recognized as "shared" by other women, both in the programme and in "real life"' (131). What is important, what the women she interviewed sought to relate to, is the raising of social problems, regardless of the adequacy or the supposed progressiveness of the programme's narrative solutions. As one woman told Hobson, in response to a question about *Crossroads*' failure to pursue an issue to a radical conclusion, 'you can make your own conclusions' (132). Hobson insists that viewers 'work with the text and add their own experiences and opinions to the stories in the programme' (135). People

> do not sit there watching and taking it all in without any mental activity or creativity . . . they expect to contribute to the production which they are watching and bring their own knowledge to augment the text. Stories which seem too fantastic for an everyday serial are transformed through a sympathetic audience reading whereby they strip the storyline to the idea behind it and construct an understanding on the skeleton that is left (135–6).

I think Hobson is absolutely correct to point to the creativity of the audience for *Crossroads*; where I disagree with her is about the extent of its creativity.

She claims, 'To try to say what *Crossroads* means to its audience is impossible for there is no single *Crossroads*, there are as many different Crossroads as there are viewers' (136). Later she adds,

> there can be as many interpretations of a programme as the individual viewers bring to it. There is no overall intrinsic message or meaning in the work, but it comes alive and communicates when the viewers add their own interpretation and understanding to the programme (170).

Against these claims, I would want to insist on two points of objection. First, it is undoubtedly the case that programmes have material structures, which must set definite limits on the range and possibilities of interpretation. Second, viewers always view in contexts both social and discursive (see discussion of Morley in previous chapter), and these must set definite limits on the range and possibilities of interpretation. For these reasons, I think Hobson is wrong to propose what is in effect an entirely subjective theory of interpretation. Moreover, I think it is the case that her own excellent study of women watching *Crossroads* contradicts this theoretical claim.

In another interesting piece of work based on interviews with a woman working as a sales manager in a telephone sales office, Hobson develops the ideas she had first formulated on the train journey back from London. On the basis of this new research she argues that 'women use television programmes as part of their general discourse on their own lives, the lives of their families and friends and to add interest to their working lives' (1990: 62). Her research highlights how quickly a conversation about a television programme can become a conversation about the lives and interests of the women involved. For example, discussion of events in a soap opera can produce a discussion about events in the real lives of viewers. In this way, Hobson maintains, viewers are able to use events within television narratives to explore issues in their own lives, issues that might otherwise remain too painful to speak about openly in public. She argues that recognition of how women use television in this way should

> disprove the theory that watching television is a mindless, passive event in the lives of the viewers. On the contrary, the events and subjects covered in television programmes often acted as the catalyst for wide-ranging and open discussions. The communication was extended far beyond the moment of viewing (1990: 66).

As she concludes, 'It is the interweaving of the narratives of fiction with the narratives of their reality that formed the basis for sharing their experiences and opinions and creating their own culture within their workplace' (71). Making a similar point, Mary Ellen Brown argues that such conversations illustrate what she calls 'a carnivalesque sense of play in the crossing of the boundary between fiction and reality' (1990: 195). Furthermore, Brown maintains that women's talk about

soap operas is best understood as a fundamental part of the long tradition of women's oral culture – a 'feminine discourse' (183). As she explains,

> As consumers of soap operas and the products they advertise, women do participate in the process of consumption, but the extent to which women can be said to be the passive objects or 'victims' of dominant discursive practices by watching and enjoying soap operas is limited by the women's use of these same cultural forms to affirm their own positions of subjectivity in a woman's discursive tradition. This breaking of the rules is a source of pleasure, and the act of taking that pleasure entails defiance of dominant reading practices which attempt to shape the construction of meaning in our culture. Because the hierarchy of dominant values is either ignored or parodied in some of the reading practices around soaps, these practices may open up new possibilities for ways of thinking about culture from the subordinate's point of view (198).

As both Hobson and Brown remind us, what we might call 'television talk' is not just talk about what is on, has been on or is coming on television, it is also talk provoked by television.

## Family television

David Morley makes the point that

> Once one takes seriously the fact that television is a domestic medium (and is characterised by programme forms specifically designed for that purpose), it becomes clear that the domestic context of television viewing is not some secondary factor, which can subsequently be sketched in. Rather, the domestic context of TV viewing, it becomes clear, is constitutive of its meaning (1992: 321).

This is the focus of Morley's *Family Television*.

It had originally been Morley's intention to follow up his investigation of the *Nationwide* audience (see previous chapter) by conducting further interviews with the interviewees in the more 'natural' environment of their families and the home. Limitations of time and a lack of funding combined to ensure that this did not happen. In a way, then, it could be argued that *Family Television* represents to a certain extent the 'completion' of the *Nationwide* research project. Specifically, what Morley seeks to accomplish in this research, in a classic cultural studies move, is to bring into a critical and fruitful relationship questions which until then had generally been kept apart, seen as the separate provinces of different disciplinary approaches – how television is interpreted (literary/semiological approaches) and how television is used (sociological approaches). Combining 'the respective strengths of these two different perspectives' enabled him, he argues, 'to consider

problems of audience decoding/choice in the context of family leisure' (1986: 13). Moreover, by locating the audience in a domestic context, he is able to demonstrate the ways in which the consumption of television always involves so much more that isolated individuals making particular interpretations of specific programmes. As he explains,

> 'Watching television' cannot be assumed to be a one-dimensional activity which has equivalent meaning or significance at all times for all who perform it. I was concerned to identify and investigate the differences hidden behind the catch-all description 'watching television'; both the differences between the choices made by different kinds of viewers in relation to different viewing options, and the differences (of attention and comprehension) between different viewers' responses to the 'same viewing materials – differences which are masked by the finding that they all "watched" a given programme' (ibid.).

Watching television is always so much more than a series of acts of interpretation; it is above all else a social practice. That is, it can be a means both to isolate oneself (Don't talk to me, I'm watching this), or to make contact with other family members (watching a programme you are indifferent about, or worse, in order to make contact with a particular member of the family or the family as a whole). It can also be a means to reward or punish children (You cannot watch Y until you've done X). In these ways, the consumption of television is as much about social relationships as it is about interpretations of individual programmes. The German media theorist Hermann Bausinger provides an example of a woman's account of her husband's behaviour:

> 'Early in the evening we watch very little TV. Only when my husband is in a real rage. He comes home, hardly says anything and switches on the TV.' Although [as Bausinger observes] this is a direct expression of his psychic state, which is . . . habitualized and routinized, the specific semantic of the everyday comes in: pushing the button doesn't signify, 'I would like to watch this', but rather, 'I would like to hear and see nothing' (1984: 344).

Furthermore, contrary to the myth, which this example might seem to support, that watching television kills conversation, Bausinger in fact argues that 'Media contents are materials for conversation' (350). As we have already noted, watching television actually generates a common currency (television talk) to be exchanged in the cultural economy of everyday life (this is also true where other media are concerned). Just before Christmas 2015 there was wide media coverage of observations made by the Right Reverend Nick Baines, the Bishop of Leeds. Contrary to the usual religious concerns about television and family life, Baines suggested that the real meaning of Christmas was to be found in part with the family watching television together. He described television as 'a medium of

common conversation' (2015: 53) and cited 'a recent poll of 2,000 parents' in which 'watching television was seen as one of the top activities for family bonding' (ibid.).

Television talk is not just a currency that operates in the family, it is also important in most of the everyday interactions between people. As one respondent told Morley about television talk at work: 'We haven't got much else in common so we talk a lot about TV' (1986: 79). In this way, rather than an alternative to a social life, the consumption of television may play an integral part in its success. In certain instances, not being able to deal in the currency of television talk (i.e. not having seen particular programmes) may put a person at a distinct social disadvantage in the workplace or with a specific peer group. As Morley maintains,

> television can be seen to provide in one sense an alibi, in another sense a context, for encounters between family members, where the content of the television programme they are watching together may often simply serve as a common experiential ground for conversation. In this kind of instance, television is being used as a focus, as a method for engaging in social interaction with others. So, far from simply disrupting family interaction, television is being used purposefully by family members to construct the occasions of their interactions, and to construct the context within which they can interact. It is being used to provide the reference points, the ground, the material, the stuff of conversation (22).

In the course of his study Morley interviewed 18 white working-class/lower-middle-class families from an inner-city area in South London. One key finding was the contrasting styles of viewing described by men and women. Men claimed to view attentively, while women said they view distractedly. These findings are not too surprising when one considers the nature of gender relations in most homes. Put simply, for men home is a site of leisure (an escape from work), whereas for women it is a site of work (regardless of whether or not they are also employed outside the home). Therefore an investigation of the consumption of television in the home is an investigation of an activity 'which men are better placed to do wholeheartedly, and which women seem only to be able to do distractedly and guiltily, because of their continuing sense of their domestic responsibilities' (147). A second finding was that men tend to watch factual and sports programmes, whereas women watch fictional programmes. Based on interviews, and not on participant observation, Morley is only too aware that he is dealing with respondents' own accounts of how and what they watch. Nevertheless, as he points out with reference to the enactment of specific gender stereotypes by the male interviewees,

> Even if it could be successfully argued that my results misrepresent the actual viewing behaviour of these men, it would remain a social fact of considerable interest that these were the particular accounts of their behaviour that these viewers felt constrained to give (52).

## Talking with television

Helen Wood argues that television 'has traditionally been analysed as the one-way mode of communication par excellence' (2009: 2). Against this she wishes to propose that it has the potential to be both 'interactive' and 'dialogic' (ibid.). In order to demonstrate this she recorded 12 white, working-class women watching and responding to five British morning talk shows – *Kilroy* (BBC1), *The Time . . . The Place* (ITV1), *Vanessa* (ITV1), *This Morning* (ITV1) and *Good Morning* (BBC1).[2]

Wood's primary methodology is to simultaneously record the programme watched and the viewer response to the programme as it was watched. She maintains that the simultaneity of recording both programme and response captures what she calls 'texts-in-action' (5), as meaning is made in a dialogue between mediated and non-mediated talk. In other words, rather than meaning being something produced by the television programme and consumed by the viewer, it is constructed in the interaction and dialogue between programme and viewer.

Audiences do not get meaning from viewing, they make it and perform it as they engage in dialogue with the television. Drawing on Judith's Butler's theory of 'performativity' (1999, 1993; Storey 2013), Wood suggests that meaning is something we make in our interactions with television rather than something we receive from simply viewing. As she explains it, 'the method requires thinking about the text and audience simultaneously as an active encounter where meaning is established' (117).

It is in these 'para-social' interactions that a mediated space is created in which meaning is produced as the women engage in dialogue with the programme. Interaction tends to fall within three stages. The first stage involves direct address to participants in the programme. Examples might include supporting the opinion of a participant. In the second stage the viewer begins to provide a critical commentary on what is being said. For example, in a discussion on *Kilroy* on paying for care for the elderly, one of the viewers responded: 'Well, you're wealthy to afford a hundred and twenty pounds and still be able to live' (165). In the third stage, the viewer uses the studio discussion to reflect on her own situation. Wood provides the example of Alice, a viewer whose position begins to shift once she inserts her own circumstances into the studio discussion (171, 188–89). As Wood explains,

> Alice employs a mode of mapping her experience onto the discussion occurring in the studio. She negotiates her experience intersubjectively through a number of moves: firstly with Valerie [in the studio], whose particular points she supports; secondly against Kilroy, who questions their position; thirdly, with the institutional face of the National Health Service; fourthly, as a daughter whose gendered duty is to care for her parents; fifthly, sharing experiences with her sister-in-law as another female caregiver; and then finally in her coda with those in the studio who also cannot afford care, arguably her mediated working-class counterparts (190).

In these various ways meaning is made in the interaction and dialogue between television and viewer. The advantage of Wood's methodology, especially as it manifests itself in the final stage, is that 'we are able to see the shifting positions that one might occupy over the duration of the viewing experience, rather than attempting to fix viewing positions in terms of reading after the event' (171). What we have is a jointly constructed text in which the responses of the viewer are also involved in the production of meaning. The dialogue of television and viewer in a mediated interactive space supersedes the monologue of the television programme.

## Notes

1 Another example of how meaning continues beyond the initial moment of consumption is the experience of Rose Cohen, who emigrated from Russia to the United States in the 1880s. She writes in her autobiography of the moment she read her first book in English, a love story whose name she cannot recall: 'I felt so proud that I could read an English book that carried it about with me in the street' (quoted in Denning 1987: 36).

2 The research methodology also included focus groups and individual interviews.



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# 7

# CONSUMPTION AND IDENTITIES

In this chapter I discuss ways of thinking about the relationship between consumption and identity. This will include a critical assessment of Judith Butler's theory of performativity, and accounts of both 'displaced meaning' and the historical role played by the department store in the process of learning to make identities in social practices of consumption. What these accounts have in common is that they all see consumption as fundamental to the production of identity.

## We are what we consume

When we meet someone for the first time, in order to get to know the kind of person they are, we ask certain questions. An obvious question is what kind of work they do. But sooner or later, in order to get to know them better, we will ask questions about matters of consumption. What books do they read? What films do they like? Do they have favourite television programmes? To what kinds of music do they listen? Which football team do they support? These, and many more like them, are all questions that connect consumption with questions of identity. On knowing the answer to enough of these questions, we feel able to construct a cultural and social pattern and thus to begin to locate the person in a particular cultural and social space – we begin, in other words, to think we know who they are.

Traditionally, identity has usually been understood as something coherent and fixed; an essential quality of a person that is guaranteed by nature, especially human biology ('human nature'). This traditional view is sometimes modified to produce a second view of identity in which it is still something fixed and determined, but in this formulation biology is said to combine with social variables such as class, 'race', ethnicity, or gender, to produce and guarantee (what is still) a coherent and fixed identity. Over the course of the nineteenth century and the early part of the

twentieth a number of major intellectual assaults were made on this way of seeing identity, each in its different way making a successful challenge to the idea of a fixed and coherent self. In different ways, Charles Darwin's theory of evolution (the evolving self), Karl Marx's concept of history (the historical self), Sigmund Freud's theory of psychoanalysis (the unconscious self) and Ferdinand de Saussure's theory of language (the self-enabled and constrained in and through language) all helped to 'decentre' the traditional self.

Out of these challenges, and more recently out of the theoretical debates about post-structuralism and postmodernism (see Storey 2015), a third way to understand identity emerged. This view posits identity, not as something fixed and coherent, but as something constructed and always in a process of change. This is identity as 'production' rather than inheritance. It is identity constituted in, not outside, history and culture. Moreover, according to this model, the concept of identity is itself replaced by the concept of identities – multiple and mobile identities.

According to Stuart Hall, 'identities are about questions of using the resources of history, language and culture in the process of becoming rather than being' (1996a: 4). Although identities are clearly about 'who we think we are' and 'where we think we came from', they are also about 'where we are going'. Identities are always a narrative of the self *becoming*. If you ask who I am, I will tell you a story. In this sense, as Hall points out, identities are increasingly less about 'roots' and more about 'routes' (ibid.). Our identities are positions we occupy and vacate, in a never-ending journey of self-formation. So, for example, I may be in one moment a supporter of Manchester United, at another a university professor, at another a father and in another a friend. Each of these moments has an appropriate context of articulation. That is, depending on context, our identities form particular hierarchies of the self. In particular contexts, the identity 'in dominance' may be one thing; in another context it might be something quite different. But these other non-dominant identities are always present, always waiting ready to play a part in the changing formation of the self. Therefore, in a situation where being a Manchester United supporter is my most important identity, how I might perform this identity may well be limited by the fact that I am still a university professor. Michel Foucault's comment on the nineteenth-century French poet Charles Baudelaire's view of the modern individual provides an interesting link to post-structuralist notions of identity:

> Modern man [sic], for Baudelaire, is not the man who goes off to discover himself, his secrets and his hidden truth; he is the man who tries to invent himself. This modernity does not 'liberate man in his being'; it compels him to face the task of producing himself (1982: 41).

The task of producing the self in the mid-nineteenth century may have been the privileged labour of only the modern middle-class male artists; in the late twenty-first century it is now seen as a practice engaged in by all of postmodernity's shifting subjectivities.

Our identities (rather than our identity) are formed out of out everyday social being – our actions and interaction in the social. This is why it is important to include consumption in a discussion of identities. As Madan Sarup observes, '[c]onsumption is [now] a mode of being, a way of gaining identity' (1996: 105). Our identities are in part constructed out of the things we consume – what we listen to, what we watch, what we read, what we wear, etc. In this way, as Sarup observes, 'the market . . . offers tools of identity-making' (125). Or to put it another way, what we consume and how we consume it says a great deal about who we are, who we want to be, and how others see us. Consumption is perhaps one of the most significant ways we perform our sense of self. What we consume provides us with a script with which we can stage and perform in a variety of ways the drama of who we are.[1]

Of course identity formations are not freely chosen or freely performed. We cannot, for example, determine what commodities the culture industries make available to practices of consumption. Nor can we escape the fact that our current patterns of consumption are always likely to be informed by past consumption and, more generally, by our own personal histories and our location in the class structure. Moreover, although it may be true that our biology is less important than it was once thought to be in debates about identity, who we are still has a certain biological basis, which clearly shapes many of our practices of consumption. But it still remains the case that how our biology is understood and how it is performed, and the determining power it can wield, are open to the powerful flow of social and historical change. To put it more simply, being a man or a woman (how these identities are performed) is not the same in all historical periods and in all societies – it has changed and it changes. Or to take a different example: in *Imagined Communities* Benedict Anderson demonstrates how nationality or nationness 'are cultural artefacts of a particular kind' (1983: 13). He argues that nations are imagined political communities. '[A nation] is imagined because the members of even the smallest nation will never know most of their fellow-members, meet them, or even hear of them, yet in the minds of each lives the image of their communion' (15). What distinguishes all communities is 'the style in which they are imagined' (ibid.). Furthermore, a nation 'is imagined as a community, because, regardless of the actual inequality and exploitation that may prevail in each, the nation is always conceived as a deep, horizontal comradeship' (16). Anderson sees the emergence of the nation with the emergence of two nation-enabling cultural forms, the novel and the newspaper: 'for these forms', as he explains, 'provided the technical means for "re-presenting" the kind of imagined community that is the nation' (30). The daily newspaper, with its juxtaposition of news stories, presents its own imagined community, inviting the reader to make coherent sense of what might appear an arbitrary array of items. In this way, it mimics and reinforces the type of imagination necessary in order to figure oneself as belonging in an imagined community. In addition, the very act of reading a daily newspaper reinforces and reproduces a sense of communal belonging.

> We know that particular morning and evening editions will overwhelmingly be consumed between this hour and that, only on this day, not that. The . . . ceremony . . . is performed in silent privacy, in the lair of the skull. Yet each communicant is well aware that the ceremony he [or she] performs is being replicated simultaneously by thousands (or millions) of others of whose existence he is confident, yet of whose identity he has not the slightest notion. Furthermore, this ceremony is incessantly repeated at daily or half-daily intervals throughout the calendar. What more vivid figure for the secular, historically-docked, imagined community can be envisioned? At the same time, the newspaper reader, observing exact replicas of his own paper being consumed by his subway, barbershop, or residential neighbours, is continually reassured that the imagined world is visibly rooted in everyday life (39–40).

As Anderson's example demonstrates, a text expresses a reality that pre-exists it, contributes to the reality in which it is consumed and, most importantly for our present discussion, contributes to the reality of the subjectivity of the person who consumes it. Although newspapers no longer really play the role suggested by Anderson, what his example points to is a particular way of seeing identity, not as something fixed and guaranteed by nature, but as a series of subject positions.

Identities are also formed by the kind of music to which we listen. Paul Gilroy draws attention to the way in which the fusion of popular music genres – Asian bhangra and black hip hop, for example – have produced new hybrid forms of music, remarking that 'much of their power resides in their capacity to circulate a new sense of what it means to be British' (1993: 61). Simon Frith, again using music as an example, argues that 'identity comes from the outside not the inside; it is something we put or try on, not something we reveal or discover' (1996: 122). He contends that

> social groups [do not] agree on values which are then expressed in their cultural activities but that they only get to know themselves as *groups* (as a particular organisation of individual and social interests, of sameness and difference) *through* cultural activity . . . Making music isn't a way of expressing ideas; it is a way of living them (111).

He argues that, 'Music constructs our sense of identity through the direct experiences it offers of the body, time and sociability, experiences which enable us to place ourselves in imaginative cultural narratives' (124). Therefore, music that becomes popular, according to Frith, does so

> because it places us in the social world in a particular way . . . The experience of pop music is an experience of identity in responding to a song, we are drawn, haphazardly, into emotional alliances with performers and with the performers' other fans . . . Music . . . symbolises and offers the immediate experience of collective identity (121).

We can see this very clearly in the profound public response to the deaths in 2015 of David Bowie and Prince. What was being mourned was not the death of two musicians, but a loss of identity. Something similar, although not connected directly to music, surrounded the death of Muhammad Ali in 2016.

## Identities and performativity

One of the most influential ways of thinking about identity in relationship to consumption can be found in the work of Judith Butler. Butler begins from Simone de Beauvoir's observation that 'one is not born a woman, but, rather, becomes one' (de Beauvoir 1984: 12). Although de Beauvoir's argument has the advantage of seeing gender as something made in culture and not something fixed by nature, the problem with this model of sex and gender, according to Butler, is that it assumes that male and female biology is outside culture. Against this, she argues that biology is itself always already culturally gendered as 'male' and 'female' and, as such, already guarantees particular versions of the feminine and the masculine. In other words, the distinction between sex and gender is not a distinction between nature and culture; it is between two versions of the cultural. Therefore, as she contends 'one is not born a woman, one becomes one; but further, one is not born female, one becomes female' (1999: 33).

Butler's argument is that gender is not the expression of biological sex, it is performatively constructed in culture and, moreover, what is constructed in culture also constructs biology as male or female. So, whereas de Beauvoir maintains that biological identity sets the limits of gender identity, Butler argues that gender identity produces biological identity. To fully comprehend this, and to appreciate its implications for an understanding of identity formation, we need to understand performativity. Butler's concept of performativity should not be confused with the idea of performance understood as a form of play-acting in which a more fundamental identity (a 'natural self') remains intact behind the theatricality of the identity on display. As she explains it, 'there is no identity behind the expressions of gender; that identity is performatively constituted by the very "expressions" that are said to be its results' (ibid.). For Butler, then, what seems like the expression of biology is in fact what produces the apparent authority of the biological. In other words, the more I behave like a 'man', the more this seems to confirm the determining role of my 'male' biology.

Butler's theory of performativity is a development of JL Austin's theory of performative language ('speech acts'). Austin divides language into two types, constative and performative. Constative language is descriptive language. The sky is blue is an example of a constative statement. Performative language, on the other hand, does not merely describe what already exists; it brings something into being. 'I now pronounce you husband and wife' is an obvious example; it does not describe something, it brings it into existence; that is, when the words are spoken by an appropriate person, they transform two single people into a married couple. As Austin explains, 'the issuing of the utterance is the performing of an action'

(1962: 6). Butler argues that gender works in much the same way as performative language. At the moment of birth, in answer to the question 'What is it?', the answer is always 'It's a boy' or 'It's a girl'. The use of the pronoun boy or girl transforms the pre-human 'it' into a gendered subject. In this, the first of many performative acts, the body of the child is made culturally intelligible. The pronouncement, 'It's a girl' or 'It's a boy', comes with rules and regulations that pre-exist the child, which the child is expected to follow and obey: 'little boys do this, little girls don't do that', etc. In other words, what seems like an announcement of recognition is in fact a moment of constitution: the 'it' is made a subject (male or female) and thus begins a continuous process of subjectification in which the 'it' is required to conform to culturally intelligible (i.e. socially acceptable) norms of male or femaleness – in this way, the subject is subjected. So naming me a boy does not reveal my gender identity, it produces it – a production that maps out key aspects of my identity and my social 'destiny'.

However, for 'it's a girl' or 'it's a boy' to make sense it has to conform to a structure of cultural intelligibility that already exists (that is, we have to already know what it means to say 'it's a girl' or 'it's a boy'). But more than this, the structure of intelligibility demands that such a pronouncement be made: it is an act of conformity to a world that has already agreed to divide humans into male and female on the grounds of certain aspects of biological difference. Each time this happens, the pronouncement is citing previous pronouncements and it is the fact that it is citing these previous pronouncements that gives it its authority and validity. This part of Butler's argument draws on Jacques Derrida's extension of Austin's theory of performative language. As Derrida asks, 'Could a performative utterance succeed if its formulation did not repeat a "coded" or iterable utterance, in other words, if the formula I pronounce in order to open a meeting, launch a ship or a marriage were not identifiable as conforming with an iterable model?' (1982: 18). In other words, the power of each pronouncement, why it makes sense, why it has authority and validity, and requires conformity, is the weight of previous citations. Moreover, this first citation is the beginning of a continuous process of further citations, as the 'it' is required to conform to the social norms of its assigned gender identity. Our gender identity, therefore, is 'not the product of a choice, but the forcible citation of a norm, one whose complex historicity is indissociable from relations of discipline, regulation, punishment' (Butler 1993: 232). A variety of discourses, including those from parents, fashion, educational institutions, the media, will all combine to ensure our conformity to the reiteration and citation of gender norms. In this way, the performance of gender creates the illusion of an already existing gendered self (guaranteed by biology). Sarah Chinn provides an excellent summary of the process, and how it is implicated in learned patterns of consumption,

> The naturalizing effects of gender means that gender feels natural – even the understanding that it is performative, that our subjectivities themselves are constructed through its performance, does not make it feel any the

> less intrinsic. Our identities depend upon successful performance of our genders, and there is an entire cultural arsenal of books, films, television, advertisements, parental injunctions and peer surveillance to make sure those performances are (ideally) unconscious and successful (1997: 306–7).

If, as Butler maintains, 'gender reality is created through sustained social performances' (1999: 180): it is acting like a man or a woman that produces gender identities. There is not a 'natural self' that performs different identities – a distinction between being and doing. Rather being ('natural self') and doing ('presentation of self') are the same: it is doing masculine things that make a man masculine; men do not have masculinity, they do masculinity/masculinities, and part of how it is done is through social practices of consumption. In other words, our gender identities are in part constructed through conforming to learned patterns of consumption. But more than this, the logic of Butler's argument is that all identities are constructed in this way.

## Identities and displaced meaning

In Chapter 1, I discussed Colin Campbell's argument that the consumer revolution required a shift from traditional to modern hedonism. As he maintains,

> The capacity to gain pleasure from self-constructed, imaginative experience crucially alters the essential nature of all hedonistic activity . . . In modern hedonism . . . if a product is capable of being represented as possessing unknown characteristics then it is open to the pleasure-seeker to imagine the nature of its gratifications and it thus becomes an occasion for day-dreaming. Although employing material from memory, the hedonist can now imaginatively speculate upon what gratifications and enjoyments are in store, and thus attach his favoured day-dream to this real object of desire. In this way, imagined pleasures are added to those already encountered and greater desire is experienced for the unknown than the known (1987: 85–6).

Campbell also claims that it is generally the case that the 'real' experience of consumption will fail to match the experience imagined in anticipation. In this way, 'The consummation of desire is thus a necessarily disillusioning experience', in that the gap between anticipation and reality will always produce, regardless of the pleasures actual experience of consumption may bring, a 'resultant recognition that something is missing' (86). Although his argument is that consumers are driven from object to object, from anticipatory daydreaming to disillusioning reality, longing for an object of desire which can be experienced in actuality as it is experienced in imaginative anticipation, his 'central insight [however] . . . is the realization that individuals do not so much seek satisfaction from products, as pleasures from self-illusory experiences which they construct from their associated meanings' (89). In this way,

> The essential activity of consumption is thus not the actual selection, purchase or use of products, but the imaginative pleasure-seeking to which the product image lends itself, 'real' consumption being largely a resultant of this 'mentalistic' hedonism. Viewed in this way, the emphasis upon novelty as well as that upon insatiability both become comprehensible (89).

Working with a similar model, the Canadian anthropologist Grant McCracken claims to have detected a way in which consumption can 'cultivate hopes and ideals'. As he explains,

> Consumer goods are bridges to these hopes and ideals. We use them to recover this displaced cultural meaning, to cultivate what is otherwise beyond our grasp. In this capacity, consumer goods are also a way of perpetually renewing our consumer expectations. The dark side of this aspect of consumption also helps to enlarge our consumer appetites so that we can never reach a 'sufficiency' of goods and declare 'I have enough'. This aspect of consumption also helps to illuminate some of the irrational, fantastic, escapist attachments we have to consumer goods (1990: 104).

McCracken uses the term 'displaced meaning' to indicate that the process he seeks to describe is one that 'consists in cultural meaning that has deliberately been removed from the daily life of a community and relocated in a distant cultural domain' (104). According to this perspective, consumption 'is one of the means by which a culture reestablishes access to the cultural meaning it has displaced' (ibid.). Consumption, in other words, acts as a 'bridge' to cultural meanings that would otherwise remain lost.

McCracken claims that the process of displaced meaning is propelled by a growing awareness of the fact that we live in a world in which the real and the ideal rarely exist in close proximity. Therefore, he argues,

> Confronted with the recognition that reality is impervious to cultural ideals, a community may displace these ideals. It will remove them from daily life and transport them to another cultural universe, there to be kept within reach but out of danger. The displaced meaning strategy allows a culture to remove its ideals from harm's way (106).

This strategy not only safeguards ideals, it also allows them to be demonstrated with safety. Ideals may be located temporally in a past golden age (the Leavisite 'organic community') or in a far better future (Utopia), or they may be located spatially in an existing place in another part of the world (what used to be misleadingly called 'actually existing socialism'). These locations can be called upon to demonstrate what has been possible, what is possible or what will be possible when the local difficulties of the here and now are overcome.

McCracken argues that what is true of cultures and communities is also true for individuals:

> Like cultures, individuals display a characteristic refusal to attribute the failure of ideals to the ideals themselves. Like cultures, individuals prefer to displace their ideals, removing them from the 'here and now' to the relative safety of another time or space. Individuals, like cultures, find the displaced-meaning strategy a useful sleight of hand, one that sustains hope in the face of impressive grounds for pessimism (108).

In this way, individuals, like cultures, will seek out suitable locations in other times or other spaces for the safe keeping of their ideals. We may each have our own particular golden age in the past (memories of a carefree childhood) or we may locate our hopes in a possible golden age in ideal future (when I do this . . . when I get that . . . things will be . . .) or in a special geographic location (when I go to . . . things will be . . .). Displacing hopes and ideals in this way may well keep them safe, but how do we remain in contact with them? McCracken argues that part of the answer lies in consumption. The texts and practices we consume 'serve both individuals and cultures as bridges to displaced meaning' (109). As he observes,

> The question of recovery is a delicate one. The process of meaning displacement is undertaken in the first place in order to establish a kind of epistemological immunity for ideas. When an attempt is made to recover this meaning, care must be taken to see that this immunity is not compromised. Recovery must be accomplished in such a way that displaced meaning is brought into the 'here and now' without having to take up all of the responsibilities of full residence. When displaced meaning is recovered from its temporal or spatial location, it must not be exposed to the possibility of disproof. In other words, access must not be allowed to undo the work of displacement (109–10).

It is possible to construct a similar model for thinking critically about consumption and strategies of displacement from the work of the post-structuralist psychoanalyst Jacques Lacan. According to Lacan, we are born into a condition of 'lack', and subsequently spend the rest of our lives trying to overcome this condition. 'Lack' is experienced in different ways and as different things, but it is always a non-representable expression of the fundamental condition of being human. The result is an endless quest in search of an imagined moment of plenitude. Lacan figures this as a search for what he terms l'objet petit a (the object small other) (1989: 17); that which is desired but forever out of reach; a lost object, signifying an imaginary moment in time when we were whole. Unable to ever take hold of this object, we console ourselves with displacement strategies and substitute objects.

Lacan argues that we make a journey through three determining stages of development. The first is the 'mirror stage', the second is the 'fort-da' game, and the third is the 'Oedipus complex'. Our lives begin in the realm Lacan calls the Real. Here we simply are. In the Real we do not know where we end and where everything else begins. The Real is like Nature before symbolization (i.e. before cultural classification). It is both outside in what we might call 'objective reality' and inside in what Freud calls our instinctual drives. The Real is everything before it becomes mediated by the Symbolic. The Symbolic cuts up the Real into separate parts. If it were possible to get beyond the Symbolic, we would see the Real as everything merged into one mass. What we think of as a natural disaster, for example, is an irruption of the Real. However, how we categorize it is always from within the Symbolic; even when we call it a natural disaster, we have symbolized the Real. To put it another way, nature as Nature is always an articulation of culture: the Real exists, but always as a reality constituted (that is, brought into being) by culture – the Symbolic. As Lacan explains it, 'the kingdom of culture' is superimposed 'on that of nature' (1989: 73): 'the world of words . . . creates the world of things' (72).

In the realm of the Real, our union with the mother (or who is playing this symbolic role) is experienced as perfect and complete. We have no sense of a separate selfhood. Our sense of being a unique individual begins to emerge only in what Lacan calls 'the mirror stage'. As Lacan points out, we are all born prematurely. It takes time to be able to control and coordinate our movements. This has not been fully accomplished when the infant first sees itself in a mirror (between the ages of six and 18 months). The infant, 'still sunk in his motor incapacity and nursling dependence' (2013: 256), forms an identification with the image in the mirror. The mirror suggests control and coordination that as yet do not exist. Therefore, when the infant first sees itself in a mirror, it sees not only an image of its current self but also the promise of a more complete self; it is in this promise that the ego begins to emerge. According to Lacan,

> The mirror stage is a drama whose internal thrust is precipitated from insufficiency to anticipation – and which manufactures for the subject, caught up in the lure of spatial identification, the succession of phantasies that extends from a fragmented body-image to a form of its totality (257).

On the basis of this recognition or, more properly, misrecognition (not the self, but an image of the self), we begin to see ourselves as separate individuals: that is, as both subject (self that looks) and object (self that is looked at). The 'mirror stage' heralds the moment of entry into an order of subjectivity Lacan calls the imaginary:

> The imaginary for Lacan is precisely this realm of images in which we make identifications, but in the very act of doing so we are led to misperceive and misrecognize ourselves. As a child grows up, it will continue to make such imaginary identifications with objects, and this is how the ego will be built

> up. For Lacan, the ego is just this narcissistic process whereby we bolster up a fictive sense of unitary selfhood by finding something in the world with which we can identify (Eagleton 1983: 165).

With the consumption of each new image we will attempt to return to a time before 'lack', to find ourselves in what is not ourselves; and each time we will fail. 'The subject . . . is the place of lack, an empty place that various attempts at identification try to fill' (Laclau 1993: 436). In other words, desire is the desire to find that which we lack, our selves whole again, as we were before we encountered the Imaginary and the Symbolic. All our acts of identification are always acts of misidentification; it is never our selves that we recognize but only ever another potential image of our selves. '[D]esire is a metonymy' (Lacan 1989: 193): it allows us to discover another part, but never the whole.

The second stage of development is the 'fort-da' game, originally named by Freud after watching his grandson throw a cotton reel away ('gone') and then pull it back again by means of an attached thread ('here'). Freud saw this as the child's way of coming to terms with its mother's absence – the reel symbolically representing the mother, over which the child is exerting mastery. In other words, the child compensates for his mother's absence by taking control of the situation: he makes her disappear (fort) and then reappear (da). Lacan rereads this as a representation of the child beginning to enter the Symbolic, and, in particular, its introduction into language: 'the moment when desire becomes human is also that in which the child is born into language' (113). Like the 'fort-da' game, language is 'a presence made of absence' (71). Once we enter language, the completeness of the Real is gone forever. Language introduces an alienating split between being as object and subject; before language we had only a self-complete nature, after language we are both object and subject: this is made manifest every time I think (subject) about myself (object). In other words, 'I identify myself in language, but only by losing myself in it like an object' (94). I am 'I' when I speak to you and 'you' when you speak to me. As Lacan explains, 'It is not a question of knowing whether I speak of myself in a way that conforms to what I am, but rather of knowing whether I am the same as that of which I speak' (182). In an attempt to explain this division, Lacan rewrites René Descartes's (1993) 'I think therefore I am' as 'I think where I am not, therefore I am where I do not think' (Lacan, 1989: 183). In this formulation 'I think' is the subject of the enunciation (the Imaginary/Symbolic subject) and 'I am' is the subject of the enunciated (the Real subject). Therefore, there is always a gap between the I who speaks and the I of whom is spoken. In order to engage in culture we have given up self-identity with our nature. When 'I' speak I am always different from the 'I' of whom I speak, always sliding into difference and defeat: 'when the subject appears somewhere as meaning, he is manifested elsewhere as "fading", as disappearance' (1989: 218).

The Symbolic is an intersubjective network of meanings, which exists as a structure we must enter. It is, therefore, what we experience as reality: reality being the symbolic organisation of the Real. Once in the Symbolic our subjectivity is

both enabled (we can do things and make meaning) and constrained (there are limits to what we can do and how we can make meaning). The Symbolic order confirms who we are. I may think I am this or that, but unless this is confirmed – unless others and I can recognize this in the Symbolic – it will not be really true. The day before I was awarded my PhD I was no more intelligent than the day after, but in a symbolic sense I was: I now had a PhD and I could call myself Doctor! The Symbolic order had recognized and therefore allowed others and myself to recognize my new intellectual status.

The third stage of development is the 'Oedipus complex': the encounter with sexual difference. Successful completion of the Oedipus complex enforces our transition from the Imaginary to the Symbolic. It also compounds our sense of 'lack'. The impossibility of fulfilment is now experienced as a movement from signifier to signifier, unable to fix upon a signified. For Lacan (1989), desire is the hopeless pursuit of the fixed signified (the 'other', the 'Real', the moment of plenitude, the mother's body), always forever becoming another signifier – the 'incessant sliding of the signified under the signifier' (170). Desire exists in the impossibility of closing the gap between self and other – to make good that which we 'lack'. We long for a time when we existed in 'nature' (inseparable from the mother's body), where everything was simply itself, before the mediations of language and the Symbolic. As we move forward through the narrative of our lives, we are driven by a desire to overcome the condition, and as we look back, we continue to 'believe' (this is mostly an unconscious process) that the union with the mother (or the person playing the symbolic role of the mother) was a moment of plenitude before the fall into 'lack'. The 'lesson' of the 'Oedipus complex' is that

> [t]he child must now resign itself to the fact that it can never have any direct access to . . . the prohibited body of the mother . . . [A]fter the Oedipus crisis, we will never again be able to attain this precious object, even though we will spend all our lives hunting for it. We have to make do instead with substitute objects . . . with which we try vainly to plug the gap at the very centre of our being. We move among substitutes for substitutes, metaphors for metaphors, never able to recover the pure (if fictive) self-identity and self-completion . . . In Lacanian theory, it is an original lost object – the mother's body – which drives forward the narrative of our lives, impelling us to pursue substitutes for this lost paradise in the endless metonymic movement of desire (Eagleton, 1983: 167, 168, 185).

It is not difficult to think of examples of the Lacanian notion of desire driven by lack and most of these examples will involve consumption. Consumerism is a discourse compelled by lack; it always suggests incompleteness, a lack that only consumption itself can make good. The discourse of consumerism can be seen as a Lacanian displacement strategy, an example of the continual quest for fulfilment and the endless metonymic movement of desire. The promise it holds out is that

consumption, or the right kind of consumption (this jacket, that coat) is the answer to all our existential problems; consumption will make us whole again; consumption will return us to the blissful state of the Real.

## Thinking consumption and identities historically

Although the relationship between identity and consumption is said to be a key feature of debates on post-structuralism and postmodernism, it is certainly not something that is entirely new to the world: writing in 1747, Richard Campbell, for example, mocked those who sought to hide their true selves behind their chosen patterns of consumption.

> There are Numbers of Beings in about this Metropolis who have no other identical Existence than what the Taylor, Milliner, and Perriwig-Maker bestow upon them. Strip them of these Distinctions, and they are quite a different Species of Beings; have no more Relation to their dressed selves, than they have to the Great Mogul, and are insignificant in Society as Punch, deprived of his moving Wires, and hung up upon a Peg (quoted in McKendrick 1982: 51; capitals in original).

What makes this different from post-structuralist and postmodern positions, of course, is the very idea of a true self that can be disguised and concealed. These accounts of identity and consumption argue, as we have already noted, that we are in part what we consume; identity is not an essence to be dressed in particular ways, it is something we become and continue to become; identity is not what we are but what we are becoming, and dressing in a particular way may form part of this process. Stuart Ewen quotes the psychologist Henry Floyd Allport (writing in 1924), who argues that 'our consciousness of ourselves is largely a reflection of the consciousness which others have of us . . . My idea of myself is rather my own idea of my neighbor's view of me' (quoted in Ewen 1976: 34). Advertising, as we shall see in the next chapter, plays on this notion of the self by locating the products it advertises in a world where self is continually under the watchful gaze of others; and the only way to be sure that we can successfully withstand such scrutiny is by using one of the products advertising offers to us to purchase. In similar fashion, the psychologist William James observed in 1890, 'There is a blurred line between what I think of as mine and what I think of as me. It is clear that between what a man calls me and what he simply calls mine, the line is difficult to draw' (quoted in Silverstone and Hirsch 1992: 56). A key moment in this connection between commerce and identity occurs with the development of the department store in the nineteenth century. The Swiss historian Philippe Perrot describes the impact of the department store in France as dramatic: it 'brought about the psychological "take off" of the desire for consumption in the modern sense, the extended socialisation of needs' (quoted in Laermans 1993: 80).

By the close of the nineteenth century the department store was a familiar feature of city shopping; for example, the Bon Marche in Paris, Harrods in London, Kendals in Manchester, Lewis's in Liverpool, Bainbridge's in Newcastle upon Tyne, Macy's in New York, Wanamaker's in Philadelphia. As Rachel Bowlby explains,

> Within a very short period, department stores had been established as one of the outstanding institutions in the economic and social life of the late nineteenth century; and together with advertising, which was also expanding rapidly, they marked the beginning of present-day consumer society (1985: 3).

The department store brought into being many of the aspects of shopping we now take for granted. For example, as Bowlby also points out

> The principle of *entrée libre* or open entry did away with what had previously been a moral equation between entering a shop and making a purchase. At the same time, a fixed price policy, supported by clear labelling, put an end to the convention of bargaining which focused attention on shopping as paying. Assistants in department stores received commissions on sales, so were inclined to be flattering rather than argumentative: the customer was now to be waited on rather than negotiated with and money, in appearance, was not part of the exchange (particularly since paying in fact took place in a separate part of the store). People could now come and go, to look and dream, perchance to buy, and shopping became a new bourgeois leisure activity – a way of pleasantly passing the time, like going to a play or visiting a museum (3–4).

In this way, the discourse of commerce had shifted from an insistence on the 'immediate purchase of particular items' to an attempt to generate and provoke the 'arousal of free-floating desire' (Williams 1982: 67). In other words, with the advent of the department store shopping became detached from buying and with this development came the pleasure of looking, with 'just looking' entering for the first time the vocabulary of shopping.[2] As Rudi Laermans observes, 'The early department stores pioneered the transformation of traditional customers into modern consumers and of "just merchandise" into spectacular "commodity signs" or "symbolic goods". Thus they laid the cornerstones of a culture we still inhabit' (1993: 94).

But what do these developments in the practice of shopping have to do with questions of identity? The answer is that articulating identities through the consumption of commodities is a social practice that has had to be learned. This is not to suggest that it is a practice that was imposed on people by capitalist entrepreneurs, which certainly was not the case; but it is a practice with a history. As Michael B Miller makes clear, with specific reference to France, but generalizable to other areas of Western Europe and North America, the department store did

not simply reflect changing consumer practices, it actively and powerfully contributed to them. 'Far more than a mirror of bourgeois culture in France, the Bon Marche gave shape and definition to the very meaning of the concept of a bourgeois way of life' (1981: 182). The department store gave embodiment to this way of life; its catalogues operated as a 'cultural primer', telling readers who wanted this way of life, and these specific identities, 'how they should dress, how they should furnish their home, and how they should spend their leisure time' (183). In this way, the department store promoted the idea that a middle-class self was something that could be purchased. Stuart Ewen and Elizabeth Ewen call this possibility 'the commercialization of the self' (1982: 215).

John B. Thompson makes the very important point that 'with the development of modern societies, the process of self-formation . . . is increasingly nourished by mediated symbolic materials, greatly expanding the range of options available to individuals and loosening – without destroying – the connection between self-formation and shared locale' (1995: 207). In other words, the relationship between self-formation (the making of identities) and shared locale (a particular social context) is clearly a relationship of 'structure' and 'agency'. Again to paraphrase Marx (1977), we make our identities from materials and in conditions not of our making.[3] Therefore, although the expansion of goods for consumption, made available by the emergence of the department store, massively increases the repertoire of materials from which identities can be made, identities are always made from the position of a shared locale, a particular social context, with its tradition, its history, its routines of everyday life. I am in complete agreement with Thompson when he argues for a position in which the self is envisaged as

> neither . . . the product of an external symbolic system, nor as a fixed entity which the individual can immediately and directly grasp; rather the self is a symbolic project that the individual actively constructs . . . out of the symbolic materials which are available to him or her, materials which the individual weaves into a coherent account of who he or she is, a narrative of self-identity. This is a narrative which for most people will change over time as they draw on new symbolic materials, encounter new experiences and gradually redefine their identity in the course of a life trajectory (210).

Therefore, while we can recognize that using consumption to articulate multiple and mobile identities has a history, and the early days of the department store constitute a key moment in this history, this is not the same as saying that it is something that capitalist entrepreneurs have imposed on an easily manipulated body of consumers.

## Notes

1 It should not be forgotten that undoubtedly the least attractive aspect of this drama is to do with the fact that identities are always the result not only of identifications through

sameness, but also the marking out and maintaining of difference. Identity as difference can take us a long way beyond discussions of consumption, to bring us face to face with the brutal corners of history where racial hatred and ethnic cleansing, rather than 'conspicuous consumption', are the vicious mechanisms of identity formation.

2 Like most popular pleasures, especially those practised by women, shopping soon attracted its cultural critics. For example, a man writing in the *New York Times* (June 1881) complained about 'the awful prevalence of the vice of shopping among women . . . [an addiction] every bit as bad as male drinking or smoking' (quoted in Laermans 1993: 88; my italics).

3 The actual quotation is: 'Men make their own history, but they do not make it just as they please; they do not make it under circumstances chosen by themselves, but under circumstances directly encountered, given and transmitted from the past' (Marx 1977: 10).

# 8

# CONSUMERISM AND CONSUMER SOCIETY

All the previous chapters have focused on different ways to think about consumption. In this chapter we will explore debates around consumerism and consumer society. I will begin with a brief discussion of the difference between consumption and consumerism, as too often the terms are mistakenly used interchangeably. This will be followed by a critical engagement with the birth of consumer society, anti-consumerism, advertising and commodity activism.

## Consumption and consumerism

Karl Marx distinguishes between 'production in general' and specific historical modes of production. As he explains it, production in general 'is common to all social conditions, that is without historic character, *human*' (1973: 320). But the human need to produce is always located historically in a particular mode of production: i.e. humans have always produced but how they produce is always historically situated. In other words, there is a difference between a slave mode of production and a capitalist mode of production. If we think of this in terms of consumption, we arrive at similar conclusions: there is 'consumption in general' and there are specific modes of consumption. Humans have always consumed, but in different historical periods we have consumed differently. As Marx points out,

> Hunger is hunger, but the hunger gratified by cooked meat eaten with a knife and fork is a different hunger from that which bolts down raw meat with the aid of hand, nail and tooth. Production thus produces not only the object but also the manner of consumption, not only objectively but also subjectively. Production thus creates the consumer (1973: 92).

Our contemporary attitudes to consumption, our consumption practices and our consumption desires, have developed alongside the historical development of

capitalism as a mode of production. Put simply, consumerism is the capitalist version of consumption; it is a particular historical mode of consumption unique to this mode of production. Consumerism is not, therefore, just consumption, it is increasingly a way of life, producing a sense – what Gramsci would call a 'common sense' (1971) – that who we are is defined and expressed through the commodities we consume. Consumerism is a practice that seeks to define people first and foremost as consumers. Moreover, it is a way of life that is dependent on more of the same – i.e. more capitalism.[1]

One of the things that makes consumption under capitalism different is that the vast majority of what we consume has been produced as commodities to be sold for profit. Consumerism depends on a world of things. As Marx explains in the opening sentence of volume one of *Capital*, 'The wealth of societies in which the capitalist mode of production prevails appears as an immense collection of commodities' (Marx 1976: 127). Commodities have three features: 'exchange value', 'use value', and 'value.' Exchange value is the price a commodity can secure in the marketplace. In order to achieve this it must have a use value (i.e. be of some use to someone). But underpinning these two values is what Marx calls value and this is measured by the 'human labour . . . objectified or materialized in it' (129). Moreover, as he explains, 'A commodity appears at first sight an extremely obvious, trivial thing. But its analysis brings out that it is a very strange thing, abounding in metaphysical subtleties and theological niceties' (163). The strangeness of the commodity does not arise from its exchangeability or from its use value, but from its concealment of human labour. In a capitalist economy commodities seem to exist only in relation to one another. However, what appear to be relations between things are in fact relations between people. Commodity exchange, according to Marx,

> It is nothing but the definite social relation between men [sic] themselves which assumes here, for them, the fantastic form of a relation between things. In order, therefore, to find an analogy we must take flight into the misty realm of religion. There the products of the human brain appear as autonomous figures endowed with a life of their own, which enter into relations both with each other and with the human race. So it is in the world of commodities with the products of men's [sic] hands. I call this the fetishism which attaches itself to the products of labour as soon as they are produced as commodities, and is therefore inseparable from the production of commodities (165).

According to Marx, the 'fetishism of the world of commodities arises from the peculiar social character of the labour which produces them' (ibid.). In previous modes of production the social relations of work are clear and direct; it is only under capitalism that they are concealed behind the exchange of commodities. If I make something and then exchange it for something made by another person the social relations of work are plain to see. But if I make something for a capitalist

in return for wages, what I make and what others make now exists in the marketplace for me to purchase with money. What I make becomes a commodity available to me if I have sufficient money to purchase it. What another worker makes is also available for me to buy if I can afford it. The products of our labour now exist as commodities that circulate as exchange values to be converted for money into use values. The value embodied in the commodity by labour is now concealed beneath exchange and use value.

Further to this, commodity fetishism conceals from me the conditions of labour behind what I buy. If I go to a supermarket to buy oranges I may know in which country the oranges originate, but it is unlikely I will know the social conditions of their production. My relationship to the labour of others is thus concealed in a relationship between things – my money and the oranges. In this way, then, when we go shopping we are surrounded by commodities seemingly supplied by the market and available for us to consume by the means of money. But behind all this, and hidden by commodity fetishism, are the conditions of human labour. What is also often hidden is exploitation on a massive scale. What is made for very little in the third world is often sold for significantly more in the first. For example, T-shirts made to promote the Walt Disney film *Pocahontas* sold for $10.97 each in the USA. The workers making the T-shirts earned $2.22 for an eight-hour day in which they would make 50 T-shirts with a total value of $548.50 (Kernaghan 1997: 101). Although this is clearly outrageous, it is only an exaggeration of the normal practices of capitalism. As David Harvey observes, 'To pretend this all arrives magically through the market, facilitated by the magic of money that happens to be in our pocket, is to succumb totally to the fetishism of the commodity' (2010: 61).

Commodity fetishism, in other words, arises from the concealment of the social relations of human labour behind the exchange of commodities. But what ultimately defines commodities, what they all have in common, is not use value or exchange value (these are various and variable) but the fact that they all embody what Marx calls the 'phantom-like objectivity' (1976: 128) of human labour. This phantom presence is concealed behind the language of exchange value. Every time we walk around a shopping centre we encounter commodities speaking the language of exchange value, but behind the announcement of price and possibility is the phantom of human labour hidden from view. It would be a very different experience if say each item of clothing we examined informed us of the human labour that produced it. Imagine a shopping experience in which instead of beautiful images of attractive models wearing beautiful clothes we were confronted by large photographs of children working in appalling conditions for starvation wages, accompanied by the words: *This is why the shirt is such good value for money*.

## Birth of consumer society

Although modern and postmodern consumption is now established as a field of critical enquiry, attention to early modern consumption is still in its preliminary

stages. Ann Bermingham suggests that one of the reasons for this is to be found in a version of history made popular by some dominant versions of postmodern theory; that is, the claim that consumer society is a product of late capitalism. Against this view, Bermingham argues the case for locating the birth of consumer society in the seventeenth, and certainly no later than the eighteenth century. As she points out, the coming to dominance of capitalism witnessed not only an expansion of production, but also a rapid growth in consumption. Moreover, the neglect of consumption in our understanding of these historical changes, she maintains, is a direct consequence of the influence of 'theorists of modernism [who] have assigned consumer society to the late twentieth century' (1995: 3). As she explains,

> In short, modernism's master narrative of culture has obscured the early history of consumption and its relationship to social and cultural forms, substituting in its place a history of culture focused on artistic production, individualism, originality, genius, aestheticism, and avant-gardism. This would help to explain why critics of postmodernism like Fredric Jameson [1984], nostalgic for a more 'authentic' culture, see consumer society as part of the superficial, schizophrenic, 'logic' of late capitalism. Indeed, it is only by operating outside the limits of modernism that we can see a 'consumer society' that is nearly four hundred years old. This vantage point reveals cultural and social formations which by the later eighteenth century had come to represent all that a nascent modernism both needed – and needed to suppress – in order to constitute itself (ibid.).

Although Bermingham insists that we must reject the notion that consumer society is simply a phase of late capitalism, and instead see it as 'intrinsic to all phases of capitalism, even the earliest' (4), she does not argue that consumer society is a monolithic entity, unchanging since its inception in the seventeenth century. What is required, she argues, are histories of consumption which track it through the different phases in capitalist development. She argues for histories of consumption that take as their object of study not just a past that can be empirically investigated, but also the past as present in a series of historical accounts of production. As she explains,

> The modernist distrust of mass culture which has to a large extent both written the history of consumption and blinded us to its history, rests on a tendency to think in essentialist terms about culture, class, and identity. Accordingly, culture is high and pure, classes are homogeneous and stable, and identity is unified and transparent. All of these assumptions need to be questioned if we are to write a history of consumption since the seventeenth century (14).

Histories of consumption, which are able to break free of the confines of the modernist historical perspective, will undoubtedly recognize, as she claims,

> that one of the most extraordinary aspects of mass consumption since the seventeenth century, and perhaps the thing that distinguishes the modern period from any that preceded it, is the fact that consumption has been the primary means through which individuals have participated in culture and transformed it (ibid.).

Moreover, as historian Joyce Appleby points out, such histories should show to be totally inadequate the claim

> that ordinary people – the masses – consume because they have been infected with artificial wants dreamed up by the international league of producers, [nor would it be adequate to] treat [consumption] as a residual category-what people do when they are blocked from nobler activities like philanthropy, meaningful politics and becoming mature (1993: 172).

Although Bermingham and Appleby are among a growing body of historians who have sought to establish the view that a consumer society first appears in the West in the seventeenth century, another influential body of work in historical scholarship has made the argument that it is to the eighteenth century that we should look for the origins of consumerism. J. H. Plumb, for example, asserts with great confidence that, 'During the eighteenth century extraordinary economic and social changes swept through Britain and brought into being the first society dedicated to ever-expanding consumption based on industrial production' (1982: 316). In similar fashion, Neil McKendrick, John Brewer and J. H. Plumb claim with conviction, 'There was a consumer revolution in eighteenth-century England' (1982: 1). As they explain,

> More men and women than ever before in human history enjoyed the experience of acquiring material possessions. Objects which for centuries had been the privileged possessions of the rich came, within the space of a few generations, to be within the reach of a larger part of society than ever before, and, for the first time, to be within the legitimate aspirations of almost all of it (ibid.).

The consumer revolution of the eighteenth century was the result, they claim, of changes in ways of thinking, changes in retail skills and changes in economic prosperity across all classes. McKendrick claims 'that consumer behaviour was so rampant and the acceptance of commercial attitudes so pervasive that no one . . . should doubt that the first of the world's consumer societies had unmistakenly emerged [in England] by 1800' (1982: 13).

Whether we think it begins in the seventeenth or eighteenth centuries, what is clear is that consumer society has a longer history than most 'sociological' accounts of it suggest.

## Anti-consumption

For some critics (see Lewis 2013) consumer society[2] appears to exist because we want it to exist. That is, it is our needs and desires that force business and industry to meet our demands. But, according to John Galbraith, writing in the late 1950s, the opposite is in fact true: it is production that creates consumption. As he pointed out, 'Production only fills a void that it has itself created' (1958: 127). Writing almost a 100 years earlier, Marx pointed out that consumer society is the result of both production and consumption.

> Production mediates consumption; it creates the latter's material; without it, consumption would lack an object. But consumption also mediates production, in that it alone creates for the products the subject for whom they are products. The product only obtains its "last finish" in consumption . . . Without production no consumption; without consumption no production' (Marx 1973: 91, 93).

Consumer society is not the creation of our desire to consume; it is the outcome of capitalism's need to sell what it produces. Capitalist production needs consumption. Consumerism is the ideology that seeks to match consumption with production by convincing us, now redefined as consumers rather than citizens, that consuming commodities is what identifies us as human beings and that every problem and every desire has a commodity solution. In this section we will consider three ways in which this ideology has been challenged. The first is organized around the idea that consumption is a pathology, the second advocates a return to 'simplicity' and the third, the most obviously 'political', seeks to organize opposition to consumerism.

In his discussion of the joke and its relation to the unconscious, Sigmund Freud analyses the role played by condensation; that is, the way humour often depends on the coming together of two thoughts 'condensed' into one. One of his examples is anecdotage, 'a composite formation' (Freud 2002: 13) made up of two elements, anecdote and dotage. Together they form a new word, anecdotage; the joke being that in old age men often fall into anecdotage. The word affluenza works in the same way: it combines affluence and influenza to suggest that consumerism is a kind of pathology, a condition of individuals, who, while struggling to keep up with the Joneses, fall deeper and deeper into unhappiness.

'Happiness' studies (see Layard 2011) are absolutely right to point to the fact that quality of life is not something that can only be achieved through consumption.[3] Retail therapy may not be therapy at all. However, to casually suggest that individual consumption is the problem and that stopping consuming so much will make us happier is to side-step questions of inequality and power. It is all very well to say stop buying things and instead take a walk on the beach or an evening with friends, as if these did not involve consumption, including transport, clothing, food and drink, and that these 'simple' activities are themselves governed

by inequality and power. If consumerism was driven by an inherent acquisitive impulse – people are just naturally greedy – why has this only manifested itself under the capitalist mode of production? While it is true that people have always consumed, it is not true that there has always been consumerism. Therefore consumerism cannot be explained by focusing on individual greed and an explanation should be sought elsewhere.

The Voluntary Simplicity Movement advocates a reduction in consumption as part of a broader strategy that claims 'we can work less, want less, and spend less, and be happier in the process' (Linda Breen Pierce; quoted in Maniates 2002: 199). What is called for goes under different names: downshifting, downsizing or simply simplifying. As Michael Maniates asks, is it 'a subversive attempt to strike at the heart of consumer capitalism? Or is it an irrelevant subculture, one that has enjoyed more than its share of media attention?' (2002: 202). While it is possible to point to how we seem to have chosen more spending power rather than a reduction in working hours, we have to be careful about who is included within the parameters of the pronoun. Put simply, the decision about reducing hours versus consuming was not one in which the vast majority of people had a say. Unless buying less is matched by working less, a reduction in consumption would mean an increase in unemployment. These are not individual choices but matters that demand massive structural change.

Simple living and downshifting tends to be a practice pursued by the affluent. As Jo Littler points out, 'One problem of the practice of deliberately consuming less is that it is by definition an option practiced by those with enough resources and cultural capital to be able to consume in the first place. The poor may be under-consumers, but this is rarely by active choice' (2009: 107). Maniates cites an example of 12 ways we can simplify our lives.

> 1. Avoid shopping, 2. Leave the car parked, 3. Live in a nice neighbourhood (that will allow you to walk to stores or easily access public transport), 4. Get rid of your lawn, 5. Cut down on your laundry, 6. Block junk mail, 7. Turn off the TV, 8. Communicate by email, 9. Don't use a cellular phone, 10. Drink water rather than store-bought beverages, 11. Patronize your public library, and 12. Limit the size of your family (quoted in Maniates 2002: 211).

Leaving to one side how offensively inappropriate this advice is to the billions of people around the world who involuntarily under-consume, its many assumptions, especially around social class, make it is also deeply problematic in the affluent West. Do we all have the ability to choose to live in a nice neighbourhood?

The *Adbusters Media Foundation*, a Canadian-based but globally active anti-consumerism group founded by Kalle Lasn in 1989, see themselves as revolutionaries fighting 'a guerrilla information war fought not in the sky or on the streets . . . but in newspapers and magazines, on radio, TV and in cyberspace' (quoted in Bordwell 2002: 250). The main weapon in this war is the practice of 'culture jamming'. Tim Jordan defines culture jamming as 'an attempt to reverse and

transgress the meaning of the cultural codes whose primary aim is to persuade us to buy something or be someone' (2002: 102). Its aim is to free human consciousness from the fantasy world of consumerism. As Rick Poyner argues,

> Advertising's right to colonise the physical environment of the street and act as primary shaper of the mental environment is taken for granted and there is no officially sanctioned public competition for the thoughts, beliefs, imagination and desires of the passer-by. Apart from other ads (quoted in Bordwell 2002: 238).

The *Foundation* publishes a magazine, *Adbusters*, runs a website, organizes events such as the *No Shopping Day*, *TV Turn-Off Week*, *World Car-Free Day*, *Buy-Nothing Christmas* and produces what it calls 'subvertisements' and 'uncommericials'.

> I quite openly say that the bulk of us are caught in a media-consumer trance; that we basically sit down in front of the our TV sets every night and absorb consumption messages . . . And then on Saturday mornings we hop into our cars and dash off to the malls and do exactly what all those ads have been telling us to do. I think most of us are living lives of mindless consumption. I think we are dupes (Kalle Lasn, interviewed by Kim Humphrey in 2006; quoted in Humphrey 2010: 89; see also Lasn 1999).[4]

Although Lasn is careful to use the pronoun 'we', it is quite clear that he does not really include himself in its collectivity – people 'living lives of mindless consumption'. Rather than go down to the mall zombie-like and buy what he has been told to buy, he organizes No Shopping Days and produces 'subvertisements' and 'uncommericials' (see Lasn 1999). We are back to the world of Chapter 2: an enlightened few in the midst of a manipulated many.

In a lot of anti-consumerism, what should be a critique of consumer capitalism often gets lost in a moral argument about individual consumption. To blame the individual consumer for confusing genuine needs with frivolous desires is to fall for the neoliberal fantasy that the sovereign consumer drives economic life. In such a critique, capitalism is guilty of nothing more than trying to keep up with demand. But before we define consumerism as a moral problem, and begin to blame consumers for its practice, we should remind ourselves that consumption is fundamental to capitalism. All three positions on anti-consumption tend to ignore the fact that capitalism depends on consumption. Without it production would cease and with it the flow of profits. Consumerism is the ideology of this need. The problem, and the solution, is capitalism and not human greed. While capitalism's ever increasing demand for growth is a problem, to blame this on individual consumers is at best an act of political displacement, producing analysis that is both naive and complicit. Too often it amounts to little more than moralism underpinned by dubious psychology and a solution that is hopelessly fixated on little more than self-help.

While it is true that consumption generally needs to stay within sustainable limits in order to reduce pressure on the planet and its resources, we should not lose sight of the fact that incredible levels of inequality mark contemporary consumption. Put simply, the rich need to consume less and the poor consume more. This might be possible in a reformed capitalism. Although it is difficult to be precise, Maniates estimates that about one billion people over-consume and four billion do not consume enough (2002: 206). It is estimated that the richest 20 per cent of the world's population are responsible for about 85 per cent of total private spending (Humphrey 2010: 6). Such figures are hardly surprising when we place them together with the massively unequal global distribution of wealth. It is estimated that 62 richest people in the world own as much as the poorest 3.6 billion and the richest 1% (about 73 million) own as much as everyone else put together (7.3 billion).[5]

To simply moralize about sustainability and individual consumption and ignore the massive inequalities of consumption is to promote a politics that capitalism is very willing to support. Moralism tends to condemn from a lofty position of absolute certainty. Of course in reality no such position ever exists. Gramsci envisaged hegemony operating on a continuum between incorporation and resistance. If we think of this in terms of consumerism, as with everything else, there are no absolute positions of incorporation or resistance, but only a 'compromise equilibrium' in which our point of balance is unstable and always shifting.[6] Marx also pointed to the fact that the expansion of consumption was contradictory. On the one hand it stabilized capitalism, while on the other it increased the desire of workers to expect more. It was these increasing expectations that produced what he called 'an essential civilising moment' (287). In order to consume, the worker needs wages; in order to consume more, he or she needs higher wages. In this way, then, the stimulation of the expansion of consumer desire both stabilizes and threatens the foundations of the system. That is, by producing ever more needs and promoting ever more desires, the system 'educates' consumers to demand even more with the possible effect that demand may exceed what capitalism is able to produce. In other words, capitalism may encourage the desire to consume to a point beyond which it cannot deliver on its promises: at this moment the system is potentially confronted by its 'gravediggers' (Marx and Engels 1998: 24).

## Advertising and the organisation of desire

What is different about consumption under capitalism is that it is accompanied by an advertising industry. Capitalism is the first mode of production to have such a means to organize and stimulate consumption. Making the material meaningful is not unique to capitalism, but what is unique is the development of a whole industry whose work it is to saturate consumption with signification. Advertising has grown up alongside capitalism. Consumer society could just as easily be called advertising society. Perhaps the latter term would be more accurate, as it points to what really

drives consumerism: not consumers but advertising. Advertising seeks to establish a particular hegemony over what is important in life. But more than this, advertising is fundamental to the hegemony of capitalism itself – it is a key site for the legitimation of the economic system.

Advertising is a powerful culture industry that spends millions on trying to persuade us to buy this or that product.[7] While not wishing to suggest that it is always successful and that we are little more than cultural dupes, through a process of persuasion and manipulation advertising seeks to regulate and organize the capitalist marketplace. Advertising is everywhere and everywhere it tells the same story: buy this and life will be better.[8] In telling this story it tells another: capitalism is a mode of production that can guarantee happiness for everyone. Do not worry if this does not yet seem the case; keep buying, as the 'good life' is just over the horizon. Advertising seeks to organize expectations and aspirations as it produces and reproduces consumer desire.

Writing in 1979, Christopher Lasch had no doubt who was to blame for consumerism:

> In a simpler time, advertising merely called attention to the product and extolled its advantages. Now it manufactures a product of its own: the consumer, perpetually unsatisfied, restless, anxious, and bored. Advertising serves not so much to advertise products as to promote consumption as a way of life. It 'educates' the masses into an unappeasable appetite not only for goods, but for new experiences and personal fulfilment. It upholds consumption as the answer to the age-old discontents of loneliness, sickness, weariness, lack of sexual satisfaction; at the same time it creates new forms of discontent peculiar to the modern age (1979: 72).

Writing 15 years earlier, Herbert Marcuse had arrived at a similar conclusion: 'The people recognize themselves in their commodities; they find their soul in their automobile, hi-fi set, split-level home, kitchen equipment. The very mechanism which ties the individual to his society has changed, and social control is anchored in the new needs which it has produced' (2002: 11).

As Marx points out, each capitalist demands

> that his workers should save, but only *his own*, because they stand to him as workers; but by no means the remaining *world of workers*, for these stand towards him as consumers. In spite of all "pious" speeches he therefore searches he therefore searches for means to spur them on to consumption, to give his wares new charms, to inspire them with new needs by constant chatter etc. (1973: 287).

Marx would be quite amazed by how the need for 'new charms' and 'constant chatter' has developed into the very powerful industry of advertising. By the second half of the twentieth century the 'chatter' had become very sophisticated. It had

come to dominate most TV channels. For example, 41 per cent of primetime television in the US consists of commercials; in Australia they take up 13 minutes in every hour; while in the UK the average viewer is exposed to 48 commercials a day (Lewis 2013: 64–5). Even when not watching television it is difficult to escape advertising: we encounter it in sponsorship and product placement and on billboards and other forms of signage, on the Internet and on radio, in magazines and newspapers, in the post and on our telephones, and it is weaved into the narratives of feature films and worn by sporting heroes in the stadiums it names. It has become an inescapable part of the fabric of everyday life.

While we can criticize or reject this or that advert it is impossible to escape the sheer noise of the general proposition that advertising as a whole relentlessly repeats – what and how much we consume is the measure of what it means to be truly human. For every problem identified by advertising there are commodity solutions. These are only ever a product away. Buy this and all your worries will be over or all your dreams will come true. The heroes and heroines of advertising's key narrative are there to show us what is possible when you buy the right product. In this way, rather than satisfaction, advertising seeks instead to spread dissatisfaction: to highlight problems that only the purchase of commodities can solve. Stuart Ewen gives the example of an advert from the *Ladies' Home Journal* (1920). It comes from the early days of advertising as an industry. It is a useful example because it works with a basic idea that is still fundamental to advertising in the twenty-first century – the identification of problems that only the purchase of a particular commodity can solve.

> You will be amazed to find how many times in one day people glance at your nails. At each glance a judgment is made . . . Indeed some people make a practicing of basing their estimate of a new acquaintance largely upon this one detail (quoted in Ewen 1976: 38).

If a woman accepts the invitation offered by this advert and begins to worry about her own nails and intends to do something about it, it doesn't matter whether she buys this product or another, as she has already been 'interpellated' (see Althusser 2013 and Storey 2015) as a consumer subject, for whom the problem and the solution are defined by particular commodities. It is not individual adverts that create consumerism but the unrelenting production of the claim that the consumption of particular commodities is the solution to most of life's problems.

Advertising is more than a cheerleader for consumer capitalism; it is absolutely fundamental to its progress and profitability. It works like a dating agency: its role is to ensure that production meets consumption. And each time a match is successful, the reproduction of capitalism is a little more secure. However, this does not mean we are all cultural dupes, unable to escape advertising's powerful sweep. We have to be careful to distinguish between what advertising seeks to achieve and what is actually achieved. There are many adverts we just ignore and others we enjoy without any intention to purchase. We should not simply assume that the power of advertising translates unproblematically into our manipulation and passivity.

## Commodity activism

The final example of consumption in consumer society is what Sarah Banet-Weiser and Roopali Mukherjee call 'commodity activism' (2012: 1). What the term is meant to suggest are the many ways in which political activism is increasingly entangled with commerce and the branding strategies of multinational corporations. That is, protest has become something that can be articulated by large companies in search of brand loyalty and increased profits.

It would be easy to see commodity activism as the workings of capitalist hypocrisy and manipulation, as people are duped into thinking that buying goods is the same as political engagement. But Banet-Weiser and Mukherjee refuse this easy move. They 'critically challenge the idea that hard-and-fast certainties separate capitalist power and popular resistance' (3). Instead they are interested in the complexities and contradictions of these developments, pointing to the fact that consumption has a long history as a form of political practice. This has taken the form of consumer boycotts, as happened during the apartheid regime in South Africa. It has also been used in a positive way, to urge people to buy something in support of a political cause. For example, in Manchester, the city where I was born, there is a 'gay village'. It is a collection of businesses, pubs and shops and is to a large extent organized around practices of consumption. I can remember when it consisted of one pub, *The Union*; now it is large enough, and well beyond its origins around Canal Street, to be a significant part of the tourist map of the city. There can be no doubt that it would not exist but for the commodity activism of the gay liberation movement.

Corporate philanthropy has a less celebrated history. It has existed since the industrial revolution. Sometimes it seemed well intentioned, but mostly it was a means to control the everyday lives of workers in order to generate even more profits. Whereas in the nineteenth century it was used as a means to influence production, a great deal of what now passes for corporate philanthropy is ultimately about organizing consumption and building brand loyalty. In both instances, the ultimate motivation is to maximize profits. In 2006, as part of the *Dove Campaign for Real Beauty*, Dove Soap, a subsidiary of Unilever, commissioned a video called 'Evolution' in which an 'ordinary' woman is transformed into a 'beautiful' model by means of elaborate make-up and very sophisticated computer technology. The point of the video is to show how unreal are the images of women we see in magazines. The video concludes with the words, 'No wonder our perception of beauty is distorted. Take part in the Dove Real Beauty Workshops for Girls'. On the accompanying website it is claimed that the *Dove Campaign for Real Beauty* is 'a global effort that is intended to serve as a starting point for societal change and act as a catalyst for widening the definition and discussion of beauty'. Dove's second video, 'Onslaught', shows a fast succession of unrealistic and distorted images of femininity and ends with the words, 'Talk to your daughter before the beauty industry does.' In a way, all that Dove is doing is what companies like it have always done. It is seeking to make a profit from insecurity. In the past the insecurity it promoted was the necessity to conform to normative standards of

beauty, whereas now it is how to resist the appeal of these normative standards. In both cases the answers is simple: buy Dove products.[9]

While, as we have noted, there is a history of political consumption, this is surely something else: it is the reduction of politics to consumption; a reduction of politics to the idea that it is buying this rather than that brand that really makes a difference. Social activism is replaced by commodity activism: there is no need to protest or campaign, all that is required is for you to buy stuff and the multinational corporations will do the rest. Protest is thus incorporated as a means to profits. Also, given that the funding for Dove's campaign comes from operating in the very industry being criticized, we could simply dismiss this as hypocrisy. But Banet-Weiser insists that it is more complex than this. As she explains,

> I try to resist overemphasizing either the incorporation of individual subjectivities by neoliberal capitalism or the autonomy of the consumer-citizen with this economy, but rather to see this dynamic as a kind of 'compromise' between creative production and capitalist practices (2012: 52).

I also share her reluctance to see it as either one or the other. Dove's motivation is to build its brand and expand its customer base, but for the young women, for example, who take part in the *Dove Campaign for Real Beauty* this is not their motivation; for them it is about building self-esteem. Can we just dismiss their motivation or simply subsume it under Dove's search for profits? The simple answer is no: we have to also recognize that in both Dove campaigns there is the possibility of a participatory politics being produced: in one, a challenge to the beauty industry's circulation of unattainable standards of beauty and thus the possibility of raising the self-esteem of young women, and in the other, the potential mobilization of mothers against the appeals of the beauty industry. But we also have to recognize that in both cases it is a politics that is channelled through and framed by consumption. For me this is a classic example of the working of hegemony in which there is a 'compromise equilibrium' (Gramsci 1971:76) between incorporation and resistance. But, as is usually the case, it is a compromise equilibrium in which the forces of incorporation are tipping the scales. But using hegemony to understand the complexities and contradictions avoids simple models of top-down power in which the human agency of the consumer all but vanishes. However, it is also a model that does not lose sight of the enormous and often crushing power of capitalism, without losing sight of human agency and the complexities and contradictions of the relationship between politics and consumption.

## Notes

1 Consumerism is not without it ethical alternatives: fair trade, recycling, consumer boycotts, green shopping, downshifting. For an excellent account of ethical consumption and cultural studies, see Littler (2016).

2 Consumer society is not an innocent term, a mere description of a particular moment in history. As Roberta Sassatelli (2007) argues, 'underneath the apparent simplicity

of the expression "consumer society" lies profound ambiguity. From its very first appearance, this term has been used more to convey condemnation than to describe; in particular, instead of being deployed to comprehend what characterized actual consumer practices, it served to stigmatize what appeared to be a growing and uncontrolled passion for material things' (2). Daniel Miller (2001) has also identified a similar moralizing and moralistic attack.

3 As Kim Humphrey's points out, 'Measured levels of subjective wellbeing in western countries do not rise with income, but nor do they significantly fall; they tend to remain fairly constant over time, and this constant is relatively high. Moreover, in international terms, wealthy nations tend consistently to exhibit high national average levels of subjective wellbeing relative to other countries' (2010: 146).

4 See also the excellent interview with Jo Littler (www.signsofthetimes.org.uk/The_shoe.html).

5 Figures quoted in the ***i*** newspaper (18/1/16).

6 Two very interesting accounts of anti-consumption can be found in Humphrey (2010) and Littler (2009).

7 Evidence of how profitable advertising has become is indicated by the fact that Sir Martin Sorrell, chief executive of the advertising agency WPP, was paid £70 in 2015 and £62 million in 2016. He is the highest paid chief executive in the FTSE 100. The figures were reported in the ***i*** newspaper (29/4/16).

8 Think of the enormous growth in the advertising of gambling on sport and how it presents betting as having little to do with winning and losing money but as itself a sporting activity that gains you self-respect, the esteem of friends and a social life worth living. This is particularly clear in its redefinition of football, not a game to be played or watched, but as an opportunity to gamble, as if this is the very essence of any match.

9 See Littler (2009) for a similar example.

# 9

# CONSUMPTION AND CULTURAL STUDIES

In this, the final chapter, I will begin with a critical discussion of the two main rivals to consumption as an object of study, production and textuality. I will then outline why cultural studies, influenced by Antonio Gramsci's concept of hegemony, value the study of consumption.

## The determining role of production?

There is a standard argument in circulation in some sections of the political economy of culture which claims that work on consumption in cultural studies points to nothing less than a turning away from the material conditions of power. Cultural studies has, or so the argument goes, vastly overestimated the power of consumers by failing to keep in view the 'determining' role of production. According to Nicholas Garnham,

> These conditions ['the core structural characteristics of the capitalist mode of production'] shape in determinate ways the terrain upon which cultural practices take place – the physical environment, the available material and symbolic resources, the time rhythms and spatial relations. They also pose the questions to which people's cultural practices are a response; they set the cultural agenda (1997: 71).

Moreover, as Peter Golding and Marjorie Ferguson contend, 'the shaping and packaging of most urban popular culture today results from sophisticated celebrity and product marketing on the part of media organisations before any element of consumer choice enters the marketplace' (1997: xxiv).[1] Even if this is true, it is only the beginning of the process. What they are describing is better understood, to borrow Stuart Hall's phrase, as 'determination by the economic in the first

instance' (1996b: 45). There are economic conditions and fear of economic reductionism cannot just will them away. However, the point is not simply to recognize these conditions, and it is certainly not to fall down before them in abject submission; what is required is not just an understanding of how these conditions produce a repertoire of commodities, but also an understanding of the many ways in which people select, appropriate and use these commodities, and make them into culture; in other words, an understanding of the relationship between 'structure' and 'agency'.

Capitalism is more than an economic system; it is also a social and cultural formation. Furthermore, as Bourdieu makes clear, although power is ultimately economic, how it is lived is always cultural, which includes, at a fundamental level, the practice of consumption (see Chapter 2 in this volume). It is in culture – what Marx called the 'ideological forms in which men [and women] *become conscious* of conflict and *fight it out*' (Marx 2013: 60; my italics) – that we live our relations to power. After Marx's death, Friedrich Engels found himself having to explain, through a series of letters, many of the subtleties of Marxism to younger Marxists who, in their revolutionary enthusiasm, threatened to reduce it to little more than a form of economic determinism. In a famous letter to Joseph Bloch, Engels explains,

> According to the materialist conception of history, the *ultimately* determining element in history is the production and reproduction of real life. Neither Marx nor I have ever asserted more than this. Therefore if somebody twists this into saying that the economic factor is the only determining one, he is transforming that proposition into a meaningless, abstract, absurd phrase. The economic situation is the basis, but various components of the superstructure . . . also exercise their influence upon the course of the historical struggles and in many cases determine their form . . . We make our own history, but, first of all, under very definite assumptions and conditions. Among these the economic ones are ultimately decisive. But the political ones, etc., and indeed even the traditions which haunt human minds also play a part, although not the decisive one (2013: 61).

What Engels is claiming is that the economic base produces the superstructural terrain (this terrain, not that), but that the form of activity (the lived culture) which takes place there is conditioned not just by the fact that the terrain was produced and is reproduced by the economic base (although this clearly enables and constrains possible outcomes), but also by the interactions of people as they occupy, and struggle over, the terrain. Gramsci makes much the same point:

> It may be ruled out that immediate economic crises of themselves produce fundamental historical events; they can simply create a terrain more favourable to the dissemination of certain modes of thought, and certain ways of posing and resolving questions involving the entire subsequent development of national life (1971: 184).

As Raymond Williams maintains, 'we have to discover the nature of a practice and then its conditions' (1980: 47). Working with this idea from Williams, I would suggest, leads to a critical perspective in which production is seen to provide, not a mechanistically determining factor, but the conditions of existence for the social practice of consumption. But we will not understand this practice by pretending that all the answers can be found in its conditions of existence, nor will we understand it by pretending that its conditions of existence are unimportant; it is the relationship between the two that needs to be adequately understood. However, while it is clearly important to locate the commodities people consume within the field of the economic conditions of their existence, it is clearly insufficient to do this and think you have also already analysed important questions of consumer appropriation and use. It seems to me that Gramscian hegemony theory, with its insistence on a dialectical relationship between incorporation and resistance,[2] still promises to do both, and even more importantly, to keep both in an active relationship, whereas the political-economy-of-culture approach threatens, despite its admirable intentions, to collapse everything back into the economic. Until the political-economy-of-culture approach regards the cultural (the 'ideological forms') as a serious terrain for agency, struggle, politics and study, it will deserve to bear the charge of 'reductionism' and 'functionalism' that Garnham so desperately seeks to defend it against (1997: 58).

Against the limited perspective of such forms of economic reductionism, I think we are right to reject the view that consumption is a simple reflection of production. We should, like Marx, see contradiction rather than hopeless complicity (see previous chapter in this volume). Moreover, as Paul Willis perceptively and persuasively argues, the capitalist drive for profit produces contradictions, 'supplying materials for its own critique' (1990: 139).

> People find on the market incentives and possibilities not simply for their own confinement but also for their own development and growth. Though turned inside out, alienated and working through exploitation at every turn, these incentives and possibilities promise more than any visible alternative. . . . Nor will it suffice any longer . . . to say that modern 'consumer identities' simply repeat 'inscribed positions' within market provided texts and artefacts. Of course the market does not provide cultural empowerment in anything like a full sense. There are choices, but not choices over choices – the power to set the cultural agenda. Nevertheless the market offers a contradictory empowerment which has not been offered elsewhere. It may not be the best way to cultural emancipation for the majority, but it may *open up the way to a better way* (160; my italics).

It is simplistic and, moreover, it is analytically disabling, to assume that practices of consumption must mirror the 'intentions' of production. The capitalist commodity, as we noted in the previous chapter, has a double existence, as both use value and exchange value. Crucial to Willis' argument is the fact that 'the

use-value of a commodity cannot be known in advance of investigation of actual use of the commodity' (Lovell 2013: 540). As Marx observed, how a commodity is used 'may arise from the stomach' or from the 'imagination' (quoted in Lovell 2013: 539). Too often supposedly radical attacks on capitalism are in reality little more than elitist and reactionary arguments about the extent of consumer choice made available by the market. Furthermore, as Terry Lovell points out, commodities

> have different use values for the individuals who use and purchase them than they have for the capitalists who produce and sell them, and in turn, for capitalism as a whole. We may assume that people do not purchase these cultural artifacts in order to expose themselves to bourgeois ideology . . . but to satisfy a variety of different wants which can only be guessed at in the absence of analysis and investigation. There is no guarantee that the use-value of the cultural object for its purchaser will even be compatible with its utility to capitalism as bourgeois ideology (542).

As Lovell's comments suggest, it is important to distinguish between the power of the culture industries and the power of their influence. Too often the two are conflated, but they are not necessarily the same. The trouble with the political-economy-of-culture approach is that it too often assumes that they are the same. To explore the extent of their influence requires specific and detailed focus on consumption, as it is actually lived in particular social and economic conditions. Moreover, if our focus is consumption, then our focus must be consumption as it is experienced and not as it should be experienced as already determined in a prior analysis of the relations of production.

There is a real sense in which the insistence on 'structure' as the only valid object of study in the political economy of culture is really a rejection of 'agency'. At times their complaints about work in cultural studies on consumption amount to little more than an argument in which if it can be shown that people make culture from the productions of the culture industries, this then invalidates the purposes of ideological critique. This sometimes seems to amount to a position in which in order to justify the theoretical methodology of the political economy of culture as *political*, it is essential to see 'ordinary people' as cultural dupes, hopelessly manipulated by the ruthless barons of the culture industries. As Angela McRobbie observes,

> It is as though 'letting the people in' to the field of analysis rocks the boat of left consensus.[3] The people are too difficult in their diversity, too unpredictable in their tastes, too likely to stray from the path of class politics, that it is better and perhaps safer to run the risk of being seen as elitist and have them safely suffering from either 'false consciousness' or ideological seduction (1996: 252).

Cultural studies has always: rejected the 'elitism' that haunts so much work in cultural theory and analysis (I have in mind Leavisism, the Frankfurt School, most versions of structuralism, economistic versions of Marxism, political economy) which always seem to want to suggest that 'agency' is always overwhelmed by 'structure'; that consumption is a mere shadow of production; that audience negotiations are fictions, merely illusory moves in a game of economic power. Moreover, 'pessimistic elitism' is a way of thinking which seeks to pass off itself as a form of radical cultural politics. But too often this is a politics in which attacks on power end up being little more than self-serving revelations about how other people are always 'cultural dupes'. Although cultural studies recognize that the culture industries are a major site of ideological production, constructing powerful images, descriptions, definitions, frames of reference for understanding the world, Gramscian cultural studies reject the view that those who consume these productions are 'cultural dupes', victims of 'an up-dated form of the opium of the people' (Hall 2013: 512).

However, Hall is also undoubtedly right to suggest that a number of people working in cultural studies have at times turned away entirely from 'economic' explanations:

> What has resulted from the abandonment of deterministic economism has been, not alternative ways of thinking questions about the economic relations and their effects, as the 'conditions of existence' of other practices . . . but instead a massive, gigantic, and eloquent disavowal. As if, since the economic in the broadest sense, definitely does not, as it was once supposed to do, 'determine' the real movement of history 'in the last instance', it does not exist at all! (1996b: 258)

Hall describes this as 'a failure of theorisation so profound, and . . . so disabling, that . . . it has enabled much weaker and less conceptually rich paradigms to continue to flourish and dominate the field' (ibid.). A return there must be, but it cannot be a return to the kind of analysis canvassed by the political economy of culture approach, in which it is assumed that 'access' is the same as appropriation and use, and that production tells us all we need to know about consumption. Nor does this mean the urgent necessity to build bridges to the political-economy-of-culture approach, but rather the need for a return to what has been, since the 1970s the most convincing and coherent theoretical focus of (British) cultural studies – hegemony theory.

## Textualism

The problem with some forms of textual analysis is the assumption that the patterns of meaning discovered in close textual analysis will automatically produce predictable meaning-effects in readers. Approaches of this kind work with an assumption that meaning is something hidden in a text. The purpose of textual

analysis in this model is to make visible what is hidden.[4] Moreover, this way of working is often informed (sometimes unconsciously) by a view in which 'other' meanings, as made by other readers, are seen as a 'contamination of the real meaning' (Hodge and Tripp 1986: 142) – ill-informed, irrelevant and easily dismissed. But, as I hope this book has made clear, reading is not the diving down into a text to find hidden treasure (the better the diver, the better the treasure); we do not read into a text, we read with it and across it and always from within an enabling and constraining context. In this way, to read a text is to mobilize and make something out of its *specific materiality*. Although it is the case that the materiality of a text results from a process of production, meanings are always made in consumption. Too often cultural critics confuse the difference between meaning and materiality; confusing a text's specific (and yet polysemic) materiality with its meaning – how it can be performed using a range of different theoretical approaches. Think of a novel, for example: the author makes the text material in a specific way (these words, in this order, etc.), but it is the novel's readers (including the author) who make it meaningful in actual practices of consumption, and this of course always opens up the possibility of difference and disagreement. As Hodge and Tripp point out with reference to the consumption of televisual texts,

> a television show is not a single stimulus, it is a vast meaning-potential complex, an interrelated set of verbal and visual meanings. But this potential is only abstract until there is someone to realise it. Interpretation is an intensely active process. Meaning is always constructed, or reconstructed, by the interaction of a set of signs with an overall code (Hodge and Tripp 1986: 7).

Texts may be characterized by 'structured polysemy', organized to generate 'preferred readings', to offer to readers specific positions of understanding and intelligibility, but what they cannot do is to guarantee that particular meanings or specific reading positions will be taken up. To know how a text is activated requires the study of actual consumers. Culture is not a body of 'pre-digested' meanings, imposed on the duped by the culture industries; it is an active, social practice of making meanings. Consumption is an encounter (as we noted in Chapter 5 of this volume) between the discourses of the text and the discourses of the reader. Critical analysis

> must aim to lay bare the structural factors which determine the relative power of different discursive formations in the struggle over the necessary multi-accentuality of the sign – for it is in this struggle over the construction and interpretation of signs that meaning . . . is produced (Morley 1980: 156).

For these reasons cultural studies is not concerned with the 'pure' or 'sacred' meaning of a text, discovered in the splendid isolation of an academic study. What interests cultural studies is the 'profane' meanings (see Willis 1978) which circulate

in the varied practices of making culture in everyday life. With reference to television, Hodge and Tripp make the crucial point,

> Much to the regret of those who wish to deal with television meanings as if they were pure and uncontaminated, we must be prepared to find that non-television meanings are powerful enough to swamp television meanings. If that is how television works in practice, then it is that process that we must study, and which is important for us to understand (1986: 144).

Hodge and Tripp's comments point to the way in which consumption must be seen as a practice in which consumer, context and the materiality of the text combine to produce meaning. As David Buckingham points out,

> Ultimately, textual analysis has distinct limitations: while it may provide a useful means of generating hypotheses, it is clearly incapable of accounting for the ways in which real audiences actually make sense of television. Viewers are not merely 'positioned' by television: they are also positioned in society and in history, and will therefore bring different kinds of prior knowledge to the text. As a result, they may refuse to accept, or indeed fail to perceive, the 'invitations' which the text offers (1987: 115).

Janice Radway makes a similar point:

> Commodities like mass-produced . . . texts are selected, purchased, constructed, and used by real people with previously existing needs, desires, intentions, and interpretative strategies. By reinstating those active individuals and their creative, constructive activities at the heart of our interpretative enterprise, we avoid blinding ourselves to the fact that the essentially human practice of making meaning goes on even in a world dominated by things and by consumption. In thus recalling the interactive character operations like reading, we restore time, process, and action to our account of human endeavour (1987: 221).

This is not to dismiss textual analysis, but it is to indicate the limitations of its place in cultural studies, especially the limits of its critical reach. Engaging in textual analysis allows a researcher to establish not the 'true' meaning of a text, but only the way a text, although polysemic, is structured so as to generate a 'preferred reading'.[5]

## Consuming with Gramsci

As the name implies, the primary focus of cultural studies is the study of culture. To fully understand this, we have to understand what culture means in cultural studies. After outlining the cultural studies concept of culture, I will then explain how this informs its understanding of consumption.

The cultural studies concept of culture derives from the work of Raymond Williams. In order to explain this I will briefly outline the shift in his thinking about culture, from seeing it as a network of shared meanings, to seeing it as consisting of both shared and contested meanings. The latter position, I will argue, is a result of the introduction in the 1970s of Antonio Gramsci's concept of hegemony into his thinking on culture. Writing in 1961, Williams proposed what he called the social definition of culture, in which culture is defined as

> a particular way of life, which expresses certain meanings and values not only in art and learning but also in institutions and ordinary behaviour. The analysis of culture, from such a definition, is the clarification of the meanings and values implicit in a particular way of life, a particular culture . . . the characteristic forms through which members of the society communicate (2013: 32).

This definition is crucial to the development of cultural studies as an disciplinary project for three reasons. First, Williams' definition 'democratically' broadens the then dominant Leavisite definition of culture (see Storey 2015), producing a more inclusive definition, in which instead of culture being defined as a body of only 'elite' texts and practices, ballet, opera, the novel, poetry, for example, it is redefined to include as culture, television, cinema, pop music, sport, for example. Second, culture as a particular way of life further broadens the definition of culture. So, for example, rather than culture being television as text, culture is embodied in the particular way of life that is involved in, say, the production, circulation and consumption of television. These two aspects of Williams' definition are usually noted and the discussion ends there. However, there is a third element in Williams' definition, one I think that is far more important for the intellectual formation of cultural studies than the other two: this is the connection he makes between a particular way of life and signification. The importance of a particular way of life is that it 'expresses certain meanings and values'. Furthermore, cultural analysis from the perspective of this definition of culture 'is the clarification of the meanings and values implicit in a particular way of life'. In other words, in Williams' social definition, cultures are networks of meanings that are embodied, performed and made concrete in particular ways of life.

In *Culture* he further clarifies his position and redefines culture as 'a realised signifying system' (1981: 12), arguing that it is fundamental to the shaping and holding together of all ways of life. This is not to reduce everything to culture as a realized signifying system, but it is to insist that culture defined in this way should be seen 'as essentially involved in all forms of social activity' (13). As he further explains, 'the social organisation of culture, as a realised signifying system, is embedded in a whole range of activities, relations and institutions, of which some are manifestly "cultural" ' (209). While there is more to everyday life than signifying systems, it is nevertheless the case that 'it would . . . be wrong to suppose that we can ever usefully discuss a social system without including, as a central part of its

practice, its signifying systems, on which, as a system, it fundamentally depends' (207). In other words, signification is fundamental to all human activities, including practices of consumption.

Culture, therefore, as defined by Williams, is not something restricted to the arts or to different forms of intellectual production, it is an aspect of all human activities. For example, if I pass a name card to someone in China, the polite way to do it is with two hands. If I pass it with one hand I may cause offence. This is clearly a matter of culture. However, the culture is not simply in the social act, nor is it just in the materiality of the card; it is in the realized meaning of both act and card. In other words, there is not anything essentially polite about using two hands; using two hands has been made to signify politeness. Signification has become embodied in a material practice, which can, in turn, produce material effects. Therefore, as Williams insists, 'Signification, the social creation of meanings . . . is . . . a practical material activity' (1977: 34). It is a social practice that requires human agency and human interaction. It is not something abstract; it is always something embedded in human action and interaction. To share a culture, therefore, according to this definition, is to interpret the world, make it meaningful and experience it as meaningful in recognizably similar ways. When Williams said that 'culture is ordinary' (1989; originally 1958), he was drawing attention to the fact that meaning-making is not the privileged activity of the few, but something in which we are all involved. However, this does not of course mean that we are all involved in it in the same way; meaning-making, like all other social activities, is always entangled in relations of power. While we may all be involved in the making of meanings, it is also the case that some meanings and the people who make them have more power than other people and other meanings. It is not until 'Base and Superstructure in Marxist Cultural Theory' (1980; originally 1973), *Marxism and Literature* (1977) and *Culture* (1981) that Williams really insists that signifying systems consist of both shared and contested meanings. As he consistently argues from 1973 onwards, cultures are where we share and contest meanings of ourselves, of each other and of the social worlds in which we live. After the introduction of Gramsci's concept of hegemony into his work in the 1970s, culture as a realized signifying system is always understood as consisting of both shared and contested meanings.

Gramsci uses hegemony to describe processes of power in which a dominant group does not merely rule by force but leads by consent: it exerts 'intellectual and moral leadership' (2013: 75). Hegemony involves a specific kind of consensus, a consensus in which a social group presents its own particular interests as the general interests of the society as a whole; it turns the particular into the general. Hegemony works by the transformation of potential antagonism into simple difference. This works in part through the circulation of signification that reinforces dominance and subordination by seeking to fix the meaning of social relations. As Williams explains, hegemony 'is a lived system of meanings and values . . . It thus constitutes a sense of reality for most people . . . It is . . . in the strongest sense a "culture" [understood as a realized signifying system], but a culture which has also to be seen as the lived dominance and subordination of particular classes' (1977: 110). If we

substitute the word culture for hegemony we are very close to Williams' social definition of culture. The difference being that the definition now includes relations of dominance and subordination.

Hegemony involves the attempt to saturate the social with meanings that support the prevailing structures of power. In a hegemonic situation subordinate groups appear to actively support and subscribe to values, ideals, objectives, etc., which incorporate them into the prevailing structures of power: relations of dominance and subordination. However, hegemony, as Williams observes, 'does not just passively exist as a form of dominance. It has continually to be renewed, recreated, defended, and modified. It is also continually resisted, limited, altered, challenged' (112). Therefore, although hegemony is characterized by high levels of consensus, it is never without conflict; that is, there is always resistance. However, hegemony seeks to arrest the proliferation of meanings; it seeks to reduce signification to meanings that can be controlled. For hegemony to remain successful, conflict and resistance must always be channelled and contained – re-articulated in the interests of the dominant.

There are two conclusions we can draw from Williams' concept of culture as a realized signifying system, and both, I want to suggest, point to the importance of consumption as an object of study. First, although the world exists in all its enabling and constraining materiality outside culture, it is only in culture that the world can be made to mean. In other words, signification has a 'performative effect' (Austin 1962; Butler 1993, 1999, and Chapter 7 in this volume); it helps construct the realities it appears only to describe. As Gramsci points out,

> It is obvious that East and West are arbitrary and conventional (historical) constructions, since every spot on the earth is simultaneously East and West. Japan is probably the Far East not only for the European but also for the American from California and even for the Japanese himself, who, through English political culture might call Egypt the Near East . . . Yet these references are real, they correspond to real facts, they allow one to travel by land and by sea and to arrive at the predetermined destination (2007: 176).

Moreover, as Gramsci continues, 'East and West . . . never cease to be "objectively real" even though when analysed they turn out to be nothing more than a "historical" or "conventional construct" ' (175). In other words, East and West are historical constructions, directly connected to the imperial power of the West. However, they are also forms of signification that have been realized and embedded in social practice. Cultural constructs they may be, but they do designate real geographic locations and guide real human movement and organize real political perceptions of the world. As Gramsci's example makes clear, meanings inform and organize social action. To argue that culture is best understood as a realized signifying system is not, therefore, a denial that the material world exists in all its constraining and enabling reality outside signification.

The second conclusion we can draw from seeing culture as a realized signifying system concerns the potential for struggle over meaning. Given that different meanings can be ascribed to the same 'sign' (that is, anything that can be made to signify), meaning-making is always a potential site of struggle. The making of meaning is always confronted by what Valentin Volosinov identifies as the 'multi-accentuality of the sign' (1973: 23). Rather than being inscribed with a single meaning, a sign can be articulated with different 'accents'; that is, it can be made to mean different things in different contexts, with different effects of power. The sign, therefore, is always a potential site of 'differently oriented social interests' (ibid.), and is often in practice 'an arena of . . . struggle' (ibid.). Those with power seek 'to make the sign uni-accentual' (ibid.): they seek to make what is multi-accentual appear as if it could only ever be uni-accentual. In other words, a 'sign' is not the issuing source of meaning but a site where the articulation of meaning (variable meanings) can be produced as it is re-articulated in specific contexts. We continually acknowledge the multi-accentuality of the sign when we describe an interpretation as, for example, a feminist reading, a queer reading, a post-colonial reading, a post-Marxist reading. In such instances, we implicitly acknowledge that the text in question has been made to mean from the critical perspective of a particular reading practice – i.e. a particular mode of consumption. This is not simply an issue of semantic difference, a simple question of interpreting the world differently. The different ways of making something signify are not an innocent game of semantics, they are a significant part of a power struggle over what might be regarded as 'normal' or 'correct' – an example of the politics of signification. It is about who can claim the power and authority to define social reality to make the world (and the things in it) mean in particular ways and with particular effects of power. Therefore, rather than engage in a fruitless quest for the true or essential meaning of something, cultural studies fixes its critical gaze on how particular meanings acquire their authority and legitimacy. As Hall explains,

> Meanings [i.e. cultures] . . . regulate and organise our conduct and practices – they help to set the rules, norms and conventions by which social life is ordered and governed. They are . . ., therefore, what those who wish to govern and regulate the conduct and ideas of others seek to structure and shape (1997: 4).

In *Mechanic Accents*, Michael Denning uses a mixture of Gramsci and Volosinov to critically assess the 'place and function' of dime novels 'within working-class cultures' in the United States in the nineteenth century (1988: 3). Denning recognizes the novels as 'products of the culture industry', but he refuses to locate them as simply operating on one side of a binary opposition of incorporation or resistance. In a Gramscian move informed by the work of Volosinov he insists that the novels

> can be understood neither as forms of deception, manipulation, and social control nor as expressions of a genuine people's culture, opposing and

> resisting the dominant culture. Rather they are best seen as a contested terrain, a field of cultural conflict where signs with wide appeal and resonance take on contradictory disguises and are spoken in contrary accents. Just as the signs of a dominant culture can be articulated in the accents of the people, so the signs of the culture of the working classes can be dispossessed in varieties of ventriloquism (ibid.).

As Denning makes clear, the novels are not the issuing source of meaning but a site where the articulation of meaning – variable meaning(s) – can be produced in a specific context for particular competing social interests.

On the basis of Williams' redefinition of culture, cultural studies has gradually come to define culture as the production, circulation and consumption of meanings that become embodied and embedded in social practice. Williams' definition of culture as a particular way of life, understood as a realized signifying system, lays the foundations for a cultural studies theory of consumption. What this means in terms of theoretical and empirical practice is that if our object of study is consumption it has to be consumption as actually experienced in everyday life and not as it is theoretically imagined as a consequence of the procedures of production or the material patterns of textuality.

Although cultural studies views consumption as a form of 'agency', it is critically aware that agency always takes place within the confines of specific structures. Agents are mostly aware of what they are actively doing when they consume; and to understand this we need to undertake ethnographic study. But agents may not be totally aware of the full significance of the structures in which they consume. Now this is not to suggest that agents are always passively positioned by the structures enabling and constraining the limits of consumption, but it is to make clear that in order to understand the structural conditions in which specific practices of consumption may take place, we need to always frame the research theoretically. In doing this we recognize that studying consumption is not the same as the experience of consumption we study. In other words, we should not pretend that our study is simply an innocent replication of what we study. If it were the same, what would be the point of ethnographic research? It is not undertaken to simply describe but to understand something about particular types of consumption. In Paul Willis' classic cultural studies text *Learning to Labour* (1977), a study of working-class kids consuming education, he ultimately knows more about the full consequences of their schooling than they do and after reading the book, so do we. This is not to patronize or not to take seriously the subjects of ethnography, but it is to recognize that what we are always seeking to do is more than describe and replicate the self-knowledge of the consumers we study. As Anthony Giddens observes in a discussion of Willis' study, working-class boys are aware of their location in the power structures of the school, and react against this by various acts of rebellion. What they are less conscious of are the structures of power outside the school and how these might relate to the power structure of the school. Moreover, their success in resisting the power structure of the school results in

them receiving an education that directs them to unskilled and unrewarding labour. In this way, as Giddens observes, their actions facilitate 'the reproduction of some general features of capitalist-industrial labour. Constraint, in other words, is shown to operate through the active involvement of the agents concerned, not as some force of which they are passive recipients' (1984: 289). The boys would soon become all too aware of how their 'resistance' to education prepared them for particular patterns of work. What Willis's theoretical framework brings to the situation is an understanding of how their actions also contribute to the structural needs of industrial capitalism. As social anthropologists George Marcus and Michael Fischer observe,

> Willis is explicitly concerned both with the remarkable insights of his working-class subjects about the nature of capitalist process and with the limited self-understanding that they display concerning the ironic implications of their rebellious behaviour at school. In learning to resist the school environment, his lads establish the kinds of attitudes and practices that lock them into their class position, foreclosing the possibility of upward mobility. Resistance is thus an intimate part of the process of reproducing capitalist-class relations. The linkage of the local situation of cultural learning and resistance at the level of the school to the situation of labor in capitalist production at the level of the shop floor is thus one of unintended consequences (1986: 82).

Angela McRobbie makes a similar point about how the 'anti-school culture' of adolescent working-class girls may operate as 'the most effective agent of control . . . pushing them into compliance with that role which a whole range of institutions in capitalist society also, but less effectively, directs them towards' (1978: 104).

Gramscian cultural studies is informed by the proposition that people make culture from the repertoire of commodities they consume. Making culture – 'production in use' – can be empowering to subordinate and resistant to dominant understandings of the world. But this is not to say that consumption is always empowering and resistant. To deny the passivity of consumption is not to deny that sometimes consumption is passive or active in ways that lead to what Gramsci calls incorporation. How both Willis' boys and McRobbie's girls actively consumed school was to make it meaningful in a very particular way. Their active consumption helped reproduce them in jobs for which they were always already intended. However, this is not something that could have simply been read off from the 'production' of school. There is of course a sense in which the question of agency in matters of consumption is not really the point. As Roger Silverstone reminds us, 'The key issue is not so much whether the audience is active but whether that activity is significant' (1994: 153). Ien Ang makes much the same point, 'audiences may be active, in myriad ways, in using and interpreting media, but it would be utterly out of perspective to cheerfully equate "active" with "powerful",

in the sense of "taking control" at an enduring, structural or institutional level' (1996: 243). We need to be cautious in our claims about the 'activity' of consumption. In my opinion, recognition of agency, although fundamental to the cultural-studies project, is not in itself enough. What matters, as Ang and Silverstone point out, is the nature and extent of the agency involved. This is not something we can decide in advance of actual 'ethnographic' investigation, but this does not mean that we dissolve all theoretical authority, and trust instead in the 'descriptive realism' of the ethnographic gaze. A commitment to ethnography must always be theoretically informed, structuring both our reasons for going and the nature of the questions we intend to ask when there. Moreover, we have to resist the idea that the culture of everyday life is little more than a degraded landscape of commercial and/or ideological manipulation, imposed from above in order to make profit and secure social control. Gramscian cultural studies insists that to decide on these matters requires vigilance and attention to the details of consumption. These are not matters that can be decided once and for all (outside the contingencies of history and politics) with an elitist glance and a condescending sneer. Nor can they be read off from the moment of production (locating meaning, pleasure, ideological effect, incorporation, resistance in, variously, the intention, the means of production or the production itself): these are only aspects of the contexts for consumption as 'production in use'; and it is, ultimately, in 'production in use' that questions of meaning, pleasure, ideological effect, incorporation or resistance can be contingently decided.

The introduction of hegemony theory into cultural studies has provided the means for a way of seeing consumption always in terms of an active relationship with production. However, perhaps it is now time to suggest that this is a relationship which should no longer be thought of exclusively in terms of 'incorporation' and 'resistance', but more neutrally, in a way which does not necessarily prejudge the range of possible outcomes, as an active relationship of 'structure' (production) and 'agency' (consumption).[6] Certainly, there can be no doubt that there are already many different ways of thinking, different ways of using, what Hall calls 'the enormously productive metaphor of hegemony' (1992: 280), and even in cultural studies it has never quite operated as first formulated by Gramsci. The concept has been expanded and elaborated to take into account other areas and relations of negotiation and struggle. Whereas for Gramsci the concept is used to explain and explore relations of power articulated in terms of class, recent formulations in cultural studies have extended the concept to include, for example, gender, 'race', ethnicity, meaning and pleasure. But what they all have in common is the 'Gramscian insistence' (before, with and after Gramsci), learned from Marx (1977), that we make culture and we are made by culture; there is agency and there is structure. It is not enough to celebrate agency; nor is it enough to detail the structure(s) of power. We must always keep in mind the dialectical play between agency and structure, between production and consumption, and between resistance and incorporation.

## Notes

1 John B. Thompson makes the pertinent and perceptive observation that

> It is all too easily assumed that, because individuals have been treated as passive consumers of images and ideas, they have become passive consumers . . . This assumption . . . commits the fallacy of internalism: it unjustifiably infers, on the basis of the production and characteristics of a particular cultural product, that this product will have a given effect when it is received by individuals in the course of their everyday lives. (1990: 116)

2 See Storey 2010 and 2015.

3 What McRobbie calls the 'left consensus' I would, as someone of the left, limit to a relatively small group of moralistic and pessimistic leftists.

4 This is often informed by what we might call 'textual determinism': the view that the value of something is inherent in the thing itself. This position can lead to a way of working in which certain texts and practices are prejudged to be beneath the legitimate concerns of a critical gaze. Against such thinking, I would contend that what really matters is not the object of study, but how the object is studied.

Michel de Certeau makes an interesting observation about how the notion of a text containing a hidden meaning can help sustain a certain power relationship in matters of pedagogy:

> This fiction condemns consumers to subjection because they are always going to be guilty of infidelity or ignorance when confronted by the mute 'riches' of the treasury. . . . The fiction of the 'treasury' hidden in the work, a sort of strong-box full of meaning, is obviously not based on the productivity of the reader, but on the social institution that overdetermines his [and her] relation with the text. Reading is as it were overprinted by a relationship of forces (between teachers and pupils) whose instrument it becomes. (1984: 171)

This may in turn produce a teaching practice in which 'students . . . are scornfully driven back or cleverly coaxed back to the meaning "accepted" by their teachers' (172).

5 What is a 'preferred reading', as with trying to establish an authorial intention, is not in the least straightforward.

6 The concept of 'resistance' was developed in cultural studies in the 1970s as a way of understanding, and possibly more significantly, as a means to value subcultural forms of consumption. I think its use now needs to be a great deal more circumspect. My preferred term is 'recontextualized' (Miller 1987). This allows discussion of resistance, but without prejudging the issues at stake.



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